Module Three

Mark &
the Gospels

The Servant King &
Servant Leadership

Manual for Trainers

January 2023

"For even the Son of Man did not come to be served,
but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many."

Mark 10:45

Introducing BUILD

'Building leaders, building churches, building the kingdom'

Most church leaders in the world today serve the growing churches of the majority world. It is impossible to overstate the significance of these local leaders for the current health and future prospects of the worldwide church, but most have received little or no training. In response, BUILD equips leaders to grow healthy churches. It does so with confidence because Jesus made a promise: "I will build my church" (Matthew 16:18).

BUILD stands for 'Biblical Understanding for In-service Leadership Development' and grew out of the Church of Uganda's (COU) response to its training needs. BUILD is first and foremost a grassroots church leadership training initiative, but it is implemented locally as a training programme. BUILD has its own course and materials, designed and developed in Uganda, which help deliver biblical, theological and practical education. It does so by training trainers to use its curriculum, which also forms the basis for an academic programme for some trainers.

This multiplication model means BUILD can have an extensive impact. This has been recognised and BUILD is used by other churches in similar contexts, particularly but not exclusively in East Africa. A regional BUILD network exists as a result.

The compiling of the BUILD curriculum has primarily been the work of Canon Dr Jem Hovil with Canon Stephen Ssenyonjo Kewaza. But due to the nature of the design and development process the materials capture the input and perspectives of many individuals. The bulk of the work was carried out through ten participatory curriculum development workshops hosted by Uganda Martyrs Seminary, Namugongo from 2009 to 2014. Those brought together participants from Uganda, South Sudan, Rwanda, Tanzania and Kenya, while others from Burundi and Congo contributed later. The workshops were based on earlier research that included 573 survey responses. That lengthy list of voices is representative of the many at the grassroots who continue to use the materials and provide feedback.

Special mention also goes to Mr Daniel Mukiibi Muwanguzi in Uganda who was instrumental in shaping the training there, and seeing it through the accreditation process. Canon Capt Benjamin Kibara Wathituni was key to a similar process in Kenya, and critical in both the ongoing revision and translation of materials. BUILD has grown under the watchful eye of a number of COU Archbishops. These include the Most Reverend Henry Luke Orombi, the COU's seventh Archbishop, who wrote these words to commend and launch the programme:

"The COU is very grateful for the BUILD initiative, which has given us simple, practical and effective tools for equipping our multitude of workers on the ground. Many leaders need training brought to them and on-going encouragement in the midst of the challenges of serving Jesus Christ today. BUILD is meeting those needs with its faithfulness to the truth and teaching of the Bible, and is bringing change to people's lives, churches and communities. All this is in keeping with the COU's core values, such as selfless service. The COU is very proud of this home grown resource, which we have had such a hand in developing. And we now praise God for the way in which he is using BUILD to strengthen and multiply church leaders in our neighbouring countries and beyond. We trust that you will find BUILD as useful and instructive as we do, and may God continue to bless this work and build his church, to the praise and glory of his name."

To echo that, we pray that you will be built up through BUILD and go on to build up many others in their faith and in their faithfulness as leaders in God's Church.

Abbreviations

Old Testament books

Gen	Genesis	Song	Song of Songs
Exod	Exodus	Isa	Isaiah
Lev	Leviticus	Jer	Jeremiah
Num	Numbers	Lam	Lamentations
Deut	Deuteronomy	Ezek	Ezekiel
Josh	Joshua	Dan	Daniel
Judg	Judges	Hos	Hosea
Ruth	Ruth	Joel	Joel
1-2 Sam	1-2 Samuel	Amos	Amos
1-2 Kgs	1-2 Kings	Obad	Obadiah
1-2 Chr	1-2 Chronicles	Jonah	Jonah
Ezra	Ezra	Mic	Micah
Neh	Nehemiah	Nah	Nahum
Esth	Esther	Hab	Habakkuk
Job	Job	Zeph	Zephaniah
Ps/Pss	Psalms	Hag	Haggai
Prov	Proverbs	Zech	Zechariah
Eccl	Ecclesiastes	Mal	Malachi

New Testament books

Matt	Matthew	1-2 Thess	1-2 Thessalonians
Mark	Mark	1-2 Tim	1-2 Timothy
Luke	Luke	Titus	Titus
John	John	Phlm	Philemon
Acts	Acts	Heb	Hebrews
Rom	Romans	Jas	James
1-2 Cor	1-2 Corinthians	1-2 Pet	1-2 Peter
Gal	Galatians	1-2-3 John	1-2-3 John
Eph	Ephesians	Jude	Jude
Phil	Philippians	Rev	Revelation
Col	Colossians		

Other abbreviations

NT	New Testament	v. (vv.)	verse (verses)
OT	Old Testament	ch. (chs)	chapter (chapters)
		p. (pp.)	page (pages)

Mark & the Gospels: The Servant King & Servant Leadership (BUILD COU & BUILD Partners). Licensed under a Creative Commons attribution, non-commercial, no derivatives license (view). Scripture quotations marked (NIV®) are taken from the Holy Bible, New International Version ®. NIV®. Copyright © 1973, 1978, 1984, 2011 by Biblica, Inc™. Used with permission. All rights reserved.

Introductory notes for trainers

Who is this manual for? *The manual has been designed to help church leaders strengthen other church leaders. For example, it will help those who lead parishes with a number of local congregations and leaders within them. Or those who have wider responsibility for churches and leaders in their area. In Anglican churches that includes vicars, archdeacons and diocesan education coordinators. And Bishops should be familiar with the programme. If you want help in training others, this manual is for you.*

In what ways is this manual different to the manual for participants? *The main difference is that there are notes for Trainers in italics. These provide additional material, which will help you to use the manual. The notes have been designed to build your training skills over time and through the course of the modules. However, you will need to 'own' the manual by adding your own comments, notes, questions and insights as you prepare and use the material. Finally, because of the additional notes, the page numbers are different. The section numbers and titles remain the same however. Use those section numbers and titles to guide your participants.*

How much time should be given to each learning unit? *The learning achieved is more important than the time allotted. And units may take less time to cover as the module progresses. However, two hours per unit is a good guideline, and six hours per day a good limit if you are able to have a residential or day workshop. However, the modules and their units can be taught in a variety of different ways. For example, a day a week; or a day or two a month; or through evening classes. The following timings can guide you as you discuss them with the participants:*

8.00 a.m. - 8.45 a.m.	*Devotions (including preaching practice)*
9.00 a.m. - 11.00 a.m.	*Session I (2 hours, followed by a 30 minute break)*
11.30 a.m. - 1.00 p.m.	*Session II (1½ hours, followed a 1 hour break)*
2.00 p.m. - 3.30 p.m.	*Session IIII (1½ hours, followed by a 30 minute break)*
4.00 p.m. - 5.00 p.m.	*Session IV (1 hour, followed by the evening break)*

The evening break can include time for learners to review the days' units, as well as to look ahead and prepare for the next day. It can also include recreation time.

What Bible passages can be used for the talk in the devotions? *The devotions and the preaching practice they include are an integral part of the training. Some of the following passages, which are not covered directly in the module, can be used: Mark 1:21-28; 2:18-22; 4:35-41; 7:24-30; 8:31-9:1; 9:2-13; 10:46-52; 14:1-11.*

How should the talk given in the devotions be evaluated? *Encourage discussion of the talk after it has been given, and after any response of prayer or worship that might follow. This must lead to the sort of feedback that will help preachers to grow in their confidence and ability. Use these three questions to guide the process:*

*(1) Was the talk **true** to the Bible passage of Scripture (evaluate the preacher's understanding of the Bible)? (2) Was it **relevant** to the listeners (evaluate their application)? (3) Was it **clear** in its presentation (evaluate their communication)?*

See Unit 13 of Module One for further guidelines.

What responsibilities need to be delegated? *This is important for a successful workshop. Share duties out early on. It is helpful to have someone in charge of the devotions; a timekeeper; a head of welfare; a person to liaise over any catering etc.*

Contents of Module Three

Introducing BUILD **2**

Abbreviations **3**

Introductory notes for trainers **4**

Contents of Module Three **5**

Contents of the previous modules **6**

Review questions for Module Two **7**

Unit 1. Introducing Mark and the gospels (Tools) **8**

Unit 2. Mark 2:1-12 (Encounter) **22**

Unit 3. Understanding the kingdom of God (Reflection) **40**

Unit 4. Encountering parables (Tools) **50**

Unit 5. Mark 4:26-33 (Encounter) **58**

Unit 6. Proclaiming the kingdom of God (Action) **64**

Unit 7. Matthew 5:1-12 (Encounter) **72**

Unit 8. Poverty and prosperity (Reflection) **78**

Unit 9. Matthew 6:9-15 (Encounter) **83**

Unit 10. Praying for the kingdom of God (Action) **88**

Unit 11. Mark 8:31-9:1 (Encounter) **96**

Unit 12. The servant king and servant leadership (Reflection) **102**

Unit 13. Mark 12:1-12 (Encounter) **109**

Unit 14. The cross and the Lord's Supper (Reflection) **115**

Unit 15. Making disciples (Action) **128**

Review questions for Module Three **134**

Blank worksheets for encountering additional Bible passages **135**

Blank worksheet for preaching additional Bible passages **137**

Contents of upcoming BUILD modules **138**

Contents of the previous modules

Module One **2 Timothy & the Pastoral Epistles:**
Preaching the Gospel & Godly Leadership

Unit 1. Introducing BUILD (Reflection)
Unit 2. How to hear God's voice today (Tools)
Unit 3. Understanding 1 and 2 Timothy (Tools)
Unit 4. How to encounter a Bible passage (Tools)
Unit 5. 2 Timothy 1:8-12 (Encounter)
Unit 6. What is the gospel? (Reflection)
Unit 7. Sharing the gospel (Action)
Unit 8. 2 Timothy 2:1-7 (Encounter)
Unit 9. Gospel centred ministry (Reflection)
Unit 10. 2 Timothy 3:14-17 (Encounter)
Unit 11. The Bible and biblical ministry (Reflection)
Unit 12. 2 Timothy 4:1-5 (Encounter)
Unit 13. How to preach a Bible passage (Action)
Unit 14. Titus 1:5-9 (Encounter)
Unit 15. Leaders of integrity (Action)

Module Two **Genesis & the Pentateuch:**
Knowing God's Story & Leading by Faith

Unit 1. The Pentateuch and the Bible's story (Tools)
Unit 2. Genesis 12:1-9 and God's salvation plan (Tools)
Unit 3. Understanding Bible stories (Tools)
Unit 4. Genesis 1:1-2:3 (Encounter)
Unit 5. God's world and our worldviews (Reflection)
Unit 6. Stewardship and sustainability (Action)
Unit 7. Genesis 11:1-9 (Encounter)
Unit 8. Sin and evil (Reflection)
Unit 9. Genesis 15 (Encounter)
Unit 10. God's covenants and our covenants (Reflection)
Unit 11. Exodus 3:1-12 (Encounter)
Unit 12. Jesus and the Old Testament (Reflection)
Unit 13. Encountering the Law (Tools)
Unit 14. Deuteronomy 5:6-21 (Encounter)
Unit 15. Leading by faith (Action)

Review questions for Module Two

- Look back through the titles of the units in the module (see above). Which units had the greatest impact on you and why is that the case?

- Think back to your time in and use of the module. In what ways has your leadership been challenged and changed as a result of the module?

- In a similar way, reflect on the ways in which your church has been influenced by any teaching from the module, which you have passed on in some way.

Unit 1. Introducing Mark and the gospels (Tools)

Overview

Welcome to Module Three of the Basic BUILD Curriculum: Mark and the Gospels: The Servant King and Servant Leadership. This extended unit will introduce you to Mark and the Gospels and, in doing so, to the module.

Outline

- Introducing Mark
- Four Steps for Understanding Mark and the Gospels
- Establishing the CONTEXT of Mark and the gospels
- Discovering the CONTENT of Mark and the gospels
- Making the CONNECTIONS between Mark's situation and today
- Teaching the CONTENT of Mark today
- Conclusion

Outcomes

At the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Know what Mark's gospel is all about
2. Explain why Isaiah is important to Mark
3. Describe how Mark uses Isaiah to place Jesus in the Bible's story
4. Summarise the situations Jesus and Mark are speaking into
5. List issues to keep in mind when reading Mark and the gospels
6. Recognise different types of writing in Mark and the gospels

Throughout the manual notes for Trainers are in italics. These give information and suggestions to help you facilitate the learning. The Participant Manual does not have these notes and the page numbers are different. Use the section numbers to guide the participants through the manual (for example: "Find section 1.1").

Suggestion: Mark's gospel was written to be read out loud. If people arrive the night before the training event or early in the day, encourage them to read it aloud in a group, perhaps as they wait for other participants to arrive. They will pick up the themes and feel the impact of the story as they read it together. This 'only' takes around an hour and a half.

Another suggestion: If you begin the day or workshop with a devotional talk you could do that from Isaiah 40:1-11. That will prepare the group to understand Mark's gospel, which is rooted in the Book of Isaiah. Develop some headings, for example:

***Wilderness** (v 3) – Isaiah spoke to God's people in EXILE. Their sin and rebellion (v. 1-2) have separated them from God. Isaiah wants them to understand that their exile is like their rebellious wanderings in the desert after the exodus. They need a greater exodus, a greater saviour, and a greater salvation.*

***Way** (v. 3) – God himself will come and rescue his people in a new EXODUS, that great picture of salvation that was so important to God's people. He will open a way so that he can return to his rebellious people and so that they can return to him.*

Word *(v. 8) – all this is a promise from God, a word he will keep. We saw God's story in Module Two, with all the promises he made, his determination to save his people and his commitment to his own reputation (v. 5). God is promising to keep all those promises himself as Mighty Saviour (v. 10) and Merciful Shepherd (v. 11).*

Wait *– God's people must put their hope in the Lord and* ***walk*** *his way (v. 31). We too must 'wait and walk' in response to the good news about Jesus, God's word, the living way. Mark's gospel begins with Isaiah 40:3 and applies the message to God's people in Jesus' day. God's people were still in exile, they were still waiting for a greater exodus. They had returned to the land but they had not returned to the Lord, and the Lord had not returned to them. They need to respond to Jesus in repentance and faith, and so do we.*

Encourage participants to criticise any daily talks constructively by discussing and feeding back on the following questions: first, was the talk ***true*** *to the text and therefore God's word; second, was it* ***relevant*** *for the listeners; third, was it* ***clear*** *in communication? Remember the 'pointing hand' explanation: a thumb pointing up indicating communication from God through his word, which we need to be* ***true*** *to; a finger pointing forward to ask whether it was* ***relevant*** *to the listeners; and three fingers pointing back at the speaker himself to raise the issue of whether it was* ***clear****.*

1.1 INTRODUCING MARK AND THE GOSPELS

Before looking at Mark, discuss one or both of these questions:

- Why are the gospels such a great treasure?

- Which of the four gospels is your favourite and why?

Mark's gospel begins with this wonderful sentence: "The beginning of the gospel about Jesus Christ, the Son of God." (Mark 1:1). Verses 2-13 build on those first words, they are Mark's **introduction**.

Read Mark 1:1-13 and discuss these questions:

- What does Mark tell us his book is all about?

It is all about Jesus. Jesus is the Christ or Messiah – God's chosen saviour and his anointed king. Jesus is the Son of God – more than just a man. This unit introduces us to Mark, but more importantly, Mark introduces us to Jesus.

- Why do you think Mark's book became known as a 'gospel'?

Mark says, "The beginning of the gospel about Jesus Christ". But he is not inventing a type of writing. He simply says that his book is full of good news – 'the gospel' – about Jesus.

Matthew, Luke and John do not label their books 'gospel'. Matthew begins with the words 'a record'; Luke 'an account'; and John 1:1-17 is all about 'witness' – about those who have seen and can testify that Jesus is the Christ. John the Baptist was a witness; John

the evangelist is a witness. He explains his purpose in John 20:30-31 and it confirms this: his book is full of signs that can lead us to believe that 'Jesus is the Christ'.

It is likely that Mark was written first and became known as Mark's Gospel. The others were written later for different situations and then also became known as gospels – Matthew, Luke and John's versions of the good news about Jesus. In that way 'gospel' became a type of writing.

- Why do you think Mark quotes from Malachi 3:1 and Isaiah 40:3?

The Old Testament is important to Mark. He is showing how Jesus' story connects with the Old Testament story. Mark uses Malachi 3:1, from the very end of the Old Testament, to introduce a quote from Isaiah and the messenger who prepares the way for the Lord. (Malachi 3:1 itself continues on that theme, "…Then suddenly the Lord you are seeking will come to his temple…")

Isaiah is particularly important to Mark. He focuses throughout on Jesus' fulfilment of Isaiah's prophecy. Mark's gospel refers back to many Old Testament texts, but Isaiah is his main reference point. We will keep things simple and make Isaiah our main OT reference point for understanding Mark.

Mark is all about the true end of the exile, brought about through a new exodus. A greater Moses will lead God's people and bring a greater salvation. Isaiah 40-55 is all about this and Mark applies this to the life and work of Jesus.

We learnt about the exodus in Module Two – and how it was Israel's great and foundational picture of salvation. But we only began to learn about the exile; we will look at that in more detail in Module Four.

Here in Mark 1:2-3 he is saying that in getting ready to meet Jesus, people are getting ready to meet God. You can look on to the rest of Malachi 3:1 and on to verse 2, with its teaching about God purifying his people if you have time.

Mark's focus on Isaiah is also reflected in the fact that he talks about the 'gospel about Jesus'. Isaiah 40:9-11 is about good news or 'good tidings': the announcement that the exile is coming to an end. Isaiah 41:27, 52:7 and 61:1 also refer to this. You might want to get the participants to look at those verses.

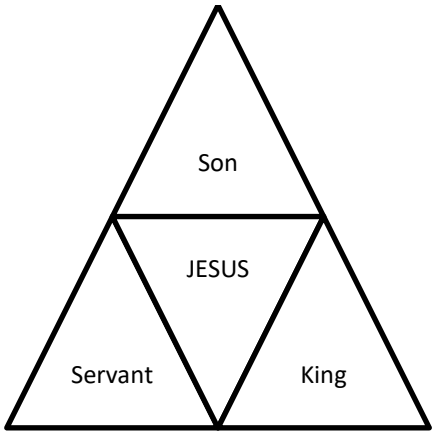
- In the light of Isaiah, how does John the Baptist fit in? What is his job?

To prepare the way for the Lord – he is the first evangelist, announcing the good news. John is a great prophet, but as Matthew puts it, "Among those born of women there has not risen anyone greater than John the Baptist; yet he who is least in the kingdom of heaven is greater than he" (Matthew 11:11). John stands at the turning point of the ages, announcing the kingdom of God.

- Look carefully. Do you notice any other themes from Isaiah?

Look at Mark 1:11. There is a deliberate echo of Isaiah 42:1 there – Mark introduces the theme of the Lord's servant, the Servant King. There are also echoes of Psalm 2:7 (the Son being recognised and enthroned as king), and Gen 22:2 (the father who is called to sacrifice his beloved son). This is important. Mark's introduction reveals Jesus' identity: the Son who is a Servant and a King. These insights will guide us through his gospel. And Psalm 2:7 picks up Nathan's prophecy about David's son and heir being the Son of God himself in 2 Samuel 7:14, so that text is also important to Mark as are the verses it

leads to and the understanding that David's kingdom will be an eternal kingdom (2 Samuel 7:16).



- Which events in the story of Israel, God's story, might Mark be looking back to in vv. 9-13?

We have already seen the link with the exodus and exile through the book of Isaiah. These verses reinforce this: Jesus' baptism is a type of exodus through the water; and Jesus' temptation in the wilderness is also an echo of Israel's exodus story, which in turn is a sort of exile. Remember, Mark is about the real end of the exile, a new exodus that Jesus will lead.

- Look ahead to Mark 1:14-15. John's work ends and Jesus' work begins. What is at the heart of Jesus' work?

Jesus went "proclaiming" the gospel – the good news of God. Jesus' work was to announce God's message. "The time has come" – it is the turning point in history. "The kingdom of God is near" (or 'at hand') – the kingdom of God is central to all Jesus' work and teaching. "Repent and believe the good news" – the introduction began with the 'good news' and it ends with it. The fact that God's rule is coming is good news. But it means repentance and faith. Turning from our ways and trusting God's ways.

1.2 FOUR STEPS FOR UNDERSTANDING MARK AND THE GOSPELS

We can use the *Four Steps for Understanding a Bible Book* that we learnt in Module One to help us in our encounter with Mark and the gospels. Can you **recall** those four steps?

Try and **explain** them to a fellow participant using these key words:

Context | Content | Connections | Content

The best way to do that is to draw the illustration we used, of a truck crossing a bridge. Can you remember that? Your trainer will help you.

Draw the simple bridge diagram from Module One for the participants:

- *The **context** (Jesus' and Mark's world) as one bank of a river*
- *The **context** (today's world) as the other side of the river*

- *The **content** of the Bible book, that we discover, as a truck stuck on one side*
- *The **connections** between then and now, as a bridge*
- *The **content** for us today, as the truck coming across the bridge*

Here they are again in summary:

FOUR STEPS FOR UNDERSTANDING A BIBLE BOOK

Step 1: Establish the original CONTEXT of the book
- Where does the book fit in the Bible's **story**?
- What **situation** was the book written for?
- What **style** of writing was it written in?

Step 2: Discover the CONTENT of the book
- What is the **structure** of the book?
- What are the main **themes** of the book?
- What is the **message** of the book?
- What is the **purpose** of the book?

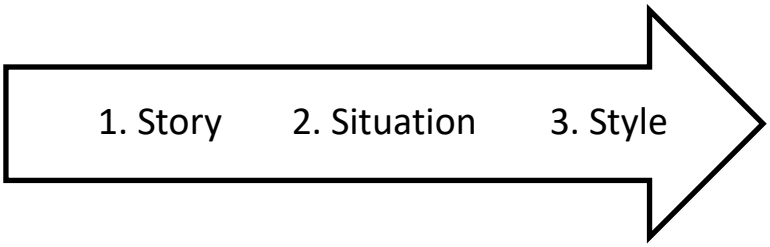
Step 3: Make the CONNECTIONS with our situation today
- What **connections** are there with our situation today?

Step 4: Teach the CONTENT of the book today
- What **main points** would you make?
- How would you **raise these issues** with your listeners?

We will now apply these to Mark's gospel.

1.3 ESTABLISHING THE CONTEXT OF MARK AND THE GOSPELS

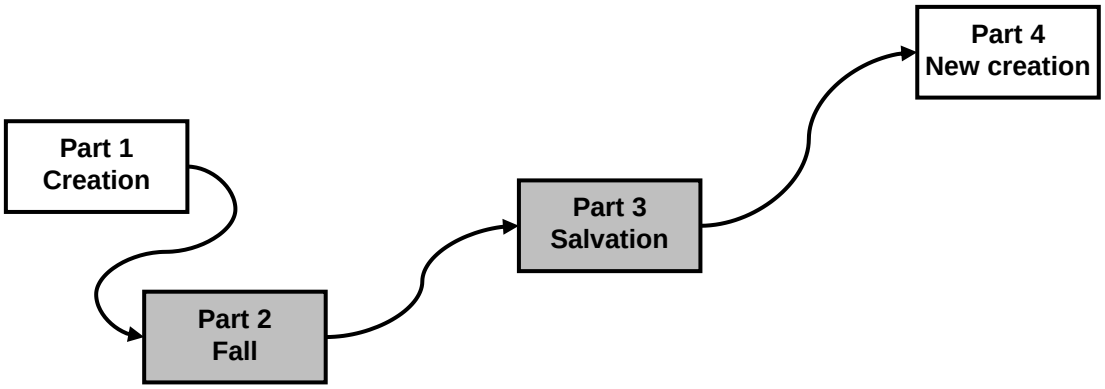
Remember the process:



1.3.1 Where does Mark's Gospel fit in the Bible's <u>story</u>?

To answer this question, we need to remember what we have learnt in Module Two and relate Mark's Gospel to that:

First, we learnt that there are four main parts to the Bible's story:



- Where does Mark's gospel fit within the story of the Bible as a whole?

It comes in the Salvation part of the story of the Bible.

Second, we discovered that there are four elements to God's promise
We saw that the Salvation stage began with God's promise to Abram in Genesis 12:1-3, and we identified four elements to his promise or four threads that run through God's story. These four elements run through the Bible's plot from start to finish:

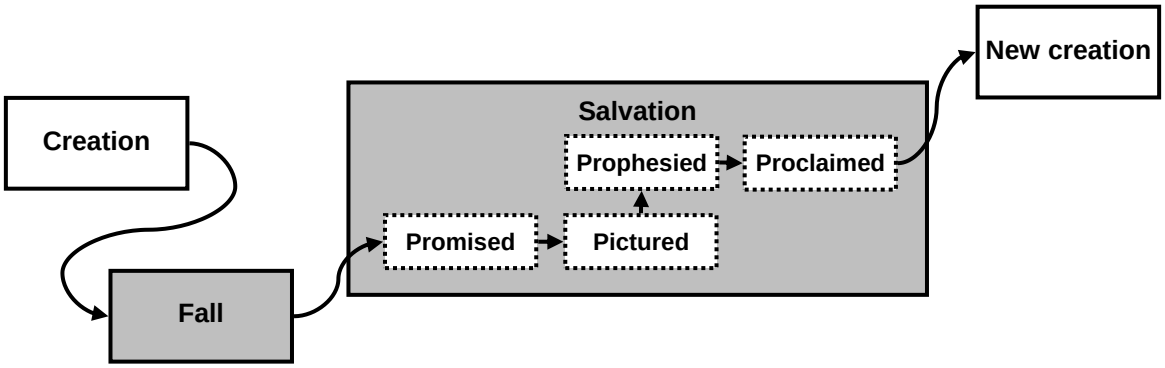
1. God's promise of a **people** – a nation under his care
2. God's promise of a **place** – a land in which to belong
3. God's promise of his **presence** – a covenant relationship to enjoy
4. God's promise of a **purpose** – a mission to accomplish

- In the light of Mark 1:1-13, **discuss** each of the four elements and the extent to which it had been fulfilled at the time of Christ's coming to Israel.

God's people were in God's place, but his presence was not with them – they had returned to the land but the Lord and his blessing had not returned to them or the land. And they had lost sight of their true purpose – to be a light to the nations.

This was nowhere near the salvation the prophets saw in the future – it was a huge disappointment. They saw a whole new creation, a new heaven and a new earth, but in reality, the people of God were still enslaved. Module Four will think about this in more detail.

Third, we found that the Salvation (solution) part of the Bible's story has four stages to it
The Salvation part of the Bible's story is the centre piece, the main story within the story. And that story, itself, has four main stages in it:



1. God's salvation is **promised** – a word to Abram that God begins to fulfil

2. God's salvation is **pictured** – a nation, Israel, who illustrate that salvation

3. God's salvation is **prophesied** – a hope for a rebellious people and their land

4. God's salvation is **proclaimed** – a Saviour, Jesus, the King of the Kingdom

- In the light of what we have said about Mark 1:1-13, **discuss** where Mark and the gospels come in the salvation part of the Bible's story. In other words, how do they relate to salvation promised, then pictured, then prophesied and then proclaimed?

*We saw that John is announcing the true end of the exile and a new exodus. The original exodus was from Egypt – an important part of **God's picture of salvation**, with Israel being formed as a nation, all based on **God's promise of salvation**. And that picture of salvation later included the story of the exile and return.*

But it was only a picture. Mark makes it clear that while the people of God may have returned to the land, they have not returned to the Lord and the Lord has not returned to them or their land.

*The **God's prophecy of salvation** promised so much more. In announcing the end of the exile Mark draws on that prophecy. Isaiah made it clear that the Lord himself will come as sin bearer and Spirit giver and end the exile. He will lead a new exodus – liberating his people to serve him, the King and his kingdom.*

*Now was the time of **God's proclamation of salvation** through Christ himself: Jesus, the saviour, leading his people out of exile in a new exodus and towards a new creation.*

The other gospels also set themselves in the story

Matthew uses a genealogy to outline the story in three stages: "from Abraham to David ... from David to the exile ... from the exile to the Christ" (Matt 1:14). Matthew is all about fulfilment (Matt 1:22 is the first of many references to this).

Luke is also about "the things that have been fulfilled among us" (Luke 1:1), the way they had seen God's story coming true.

John is a reflection on this. John the Baptist points to the coming Christ and then announces that, "The Word became flesh and made his dwelling among us" (John 1:14). John's introduction (John 1:1-18) is all about the fulfilment of the OT story, God's promise, his word, becomes a reality in Jesus.

1.3.2 What is the situation of Mark's Gospel?

IMPORTANT: When reading the gospels, it becomes clear that there are two settings we need to take into account: **Mark's situation** in 65 AD in Rome (his reasons for writing) and **Jesus' situation** 30+ years earlier in Palestine (his reasons for coming). This principle of two different contexts is important elsewhere in the Bible, but it is very important with the gospels.

To illustrate the importance of two contexts you can get the participants to cover one of their eyes and look around, to then try it with only the other eye covered, and to then uncover both. Reading the gospels with two contexts in mind is to read them with both eyes open.

a) Mark's situation
Begin with the five questions and answer them in relation to Mark and his writing: Who? Where? What? Why? When?

Who?
Early Christians tell us that the gospel was written by John Mark of Jerusalem, who we hear about in Acts 12:12. John Mark was a companion of Paul (Acts 12:25, Col 1:4, 2 Tim 4:11) and later Peter (1 Peter 5:13). Sources also tell us that Mark recorded the stories his mentor Peter shared with the believers in Rome, which he then used to write his gospel. It really is a direct and dynamic account.

Other sources suggest that Mark and his gospel are particularly relevant to those on the African Continent: many believe that John Mark's family came originally from Cyrene, in Libya but were displaced from there by insecurity and took refuge in Jerusalem, where they lived in the house we also read about in Acts 12:12. There is additional evidence that this house is the house with the upper room where the church was born in Acts 1 and 2, and further evidence still suggests it is the same upper room of Mark 14:12-26. All that means that Christians on the African continent can celebrate a strong connection with Mark and his writing, and identify with his concerns, not least when you add to this his concern for the Gentiles and reports of his later ministry and death in Egypt.

Where?
As above, probably to the church in Rome, and therefore to a Gentile audience. Mark's explanations of Jewish tradition point to this, see for example Mark 7:3-4, as do other features.

What?
More on content below, but the main things he says will be related to his context. Mark 1:1-13 emphasises the coming kingdom, and Isaiah's prediction of the Servant bringing a new exodus. He develops that, with Jesus' suffering and death being the way to end the exile and bring the new exodus. Jesus' disciples are to follow in his footsteps, as agents of the kingdom who serve rather than being served.

Why?
This may well speak into the context of a suffering church in Rome, which had lost its most important leaders, Peter and Paul. Peter's place in the gospel suggests this is correct. If what is said above about Mark's relationship to Peter and Rome, then 1 Peter is important background to it. Peter is applying the various stories he told about Jesus to the lives of Christians. During the course of the module, read and reflect on 1 Peter as an application of Mark's Gospel.

When?
The date is linked to this purpose and occasion – probably written around the time of Peter's death in 64 or 65 AD.

NOTE: The other gospels are written for different situations and purposes and are tailored to those. Matthew for Jewish believers, assuring them that the gospel is for both Jew and Gentile; Luke for Gentile believers to encourage them in their faith and place in God's purposes, with his wider vision of God's plan (in Luke-Acts); John a later reflection to lead people to believe that Jesus is the Christ in a situation where false teachers are undermining that (it is closely related to 1 John).

b) Jesus' situation

We began with the five questions and answered them in relation to Mark and his writing: Who? Where? What? Why? When?

We need to continue to think about the five questions and answer them in relation to Jesus and his ministry: Who? Where? What? Why? When?

These are questions we will touch on throughout the module. We will begin to think about them now.

Who?
We have already begun to see who Jesus is from Mark's introduction. But this is the all-important question that Mark writes about. Who is Jesus? Jesus uses various terms and titles to teach about who he is, and keeps his identity secret as he gradually teaches his disciples more and more about who he is and what his mission involves.

Around the central character of Jesus there are a number of key groups. Mark particularly focuses on three: the disciples, the crowds and the opposition, with the disciples at the

very centre. The opposition itself is made up of a number of different religious groups who were influential at the time.

Where?
Jesus' situation in first century Palestine is an important context to begin to understand. Mark's gospel follows a structure that moves from the northern area around Galilee to Jerusalem in the south. On the way they would have gone through Samaria, which had separated them for 1,000 years since the days of a united Israel. Division and prejudice marked these three different areas and Jesus would have been foreign to Jerusalem.

What?
What was going on in this situation? **Revolution** – Israel was under foreign rule and was waiting for revolutionary change, and this was pursued in various ways. Jesus came into this context. **Religion** – in this context religion had also led to bondage as the Pharisees hoped to bring change through ritual purity.

Why?
Jesus' own purpose or mission is central to all this.

When?
In the run up to Jesus' death in around 30AD.

NOTE: The other gospels emphasise different aspects of Jesus' situation in order to make their various points.

1.3.3 What is Mark's writing style?

We have already seen that Mark did not set out to create a type of writing. He put together stories about Jesus in order to tell the good news. This created a type of writing, gospel.

Gospel is made up of a number of different kinds of writing. There are two main types, but others too. Can you list the different types of writing? What does this mean for us as we read Mark?

*Mark's gospel is mainly made up of **narrative** and **teaching**. It is mainly a story full of stories about Jesus and teaching from Jesus, and that teaching from Jesus is also full of stories.*

This means we need to apply the lessons we have learnt from Modules One and Two. We can apply some of the lessons from Module One about understanding teaching material; we can apply some of the lessons from Module Two about understanding biblical stories.

*But there are other kinds of writing. **Parables** are an important feature of the gospels. We will look at those in Unit 4. Jesus also uses proverbs and pictures and quotations and other approaches in his teaching.*

*There are also **songs** such as those in Luke 1 and 2. Further down the track Module Six will help us read those. And, for even further down the track, there are elements of **prophecy** in some of Jesus' teaching (Module Nine) and **apocalyptic** (Module Ten) – Mark 13 includes that form.*

NOTE: Mark is one of FOUR GOSPELS
Why do you think there are four different gospels? What might God have in mind in leading the evangelists to write four different gospels? Perhaps discuss what the benefits of reading four different accounts of an event in four different newspapers.

The writers select, arrange and adapt material for a purpose. Mark's own style is direct and exciting and fast moving.

Be aware of the use of different sections of Mark in Matthew and Luke. Not in order to harmonise them, but so that you can ask why the author has included this story or teaching at this point and why he has used it in a particular way. In other words: Spot the difference and ask why it might be different.

1.4 DISCOVERING THE CONTENT OF MARK AND THE GOSPELS

a) How is the book structured?

Remember, Mark designed the message of his gospel to be understood as it was read out loud. He uses a number of ways of structuring his gospel in order to achieve that.

First, **Mark asks and answers two simple questions**, which divide the gospel, and all humanity, down the middle:

Question One: Who is Jesus?
Answer One: Jesus is God's Messiah

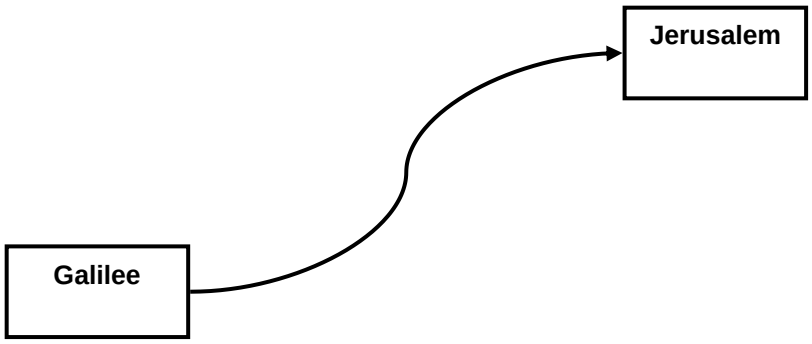
Question Two: What sort of Messiah is Jesus?
Answer Two: Jesus, God's Messiah, is a servant king

The first question leads up to Jesus' question in 8:29, "Who do you say I am?" and to Peter's answer in the same verse, "You are the Christ".

The second question is then explored from 8:31 as Jesus "began to teach them that the Son of Man must suffer many things..." and is answered, ultimately, through the Passion.

Second, and in reinforcing the above, we have seen that **Mark uses geography to structure his gospel**. At the simplest level his story is a two-stage journey:

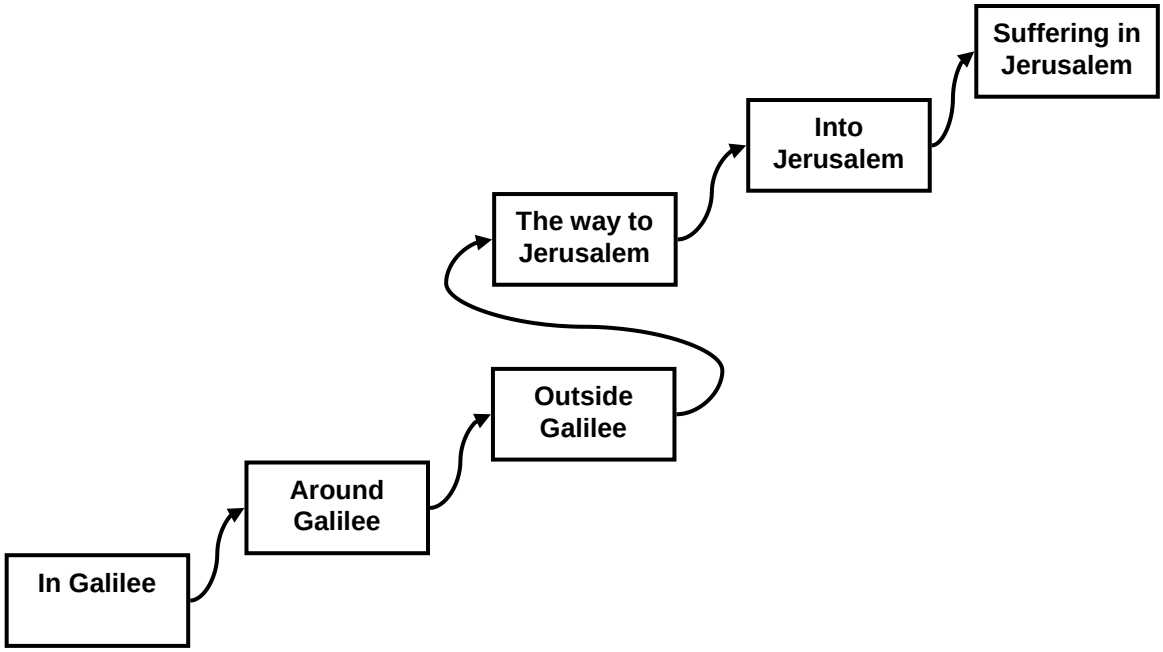
Stage 1. From Galilee
Stage 2. To Jerusalem



He develops that journey in this way:

Stage 1.
In Galilee ➔
Around Galilee ➔
Outside Galilee ➔

Stage 2.
The way to Jerusalem ➔
Into Jerusalem➔
Suffering and death in Jerusalem



Third, and also in teaching all the above, we have seen that **Mark uses three different groups of people to describe events**:

1. The disciples
2. The crowds
3. The opposition

We can combine these to give this structure:

The questions	The places	The people
Introduction – 1:1-13 “The beginning of the good news about Jesus the Messiah ...” (v. 1)		
Question: Who is Jesus? **Answer: Jesus is God’s Messiah** 1:14 – 8:21	**In Galilee** 1:14 - 3:6	The disciples, the crowds and the opposition
	Around Galilee 3:7 - 6:13	The disciples, the crowds and the opposition but the focus shifts to the disciples
	Outside Galilee 6:14 - 8:21	The disciples set against Gentile crowds and note of opposition
Question: What sort of Messiah is Jesus? **Answer: Jesus, God’s Messiah, is both servant and king** 8:22 – 15:47	**The way to Jerusalem** 8:22 - 10:52	The disciples are central. The section is framed by a picture of their learning about Jesus: it begins with the gradual opening of eyes and ends with Bartimaeus “immediately” receiving his sight.
	In Jerusalem 11:1 – 13:37	The disciples arrive with Jesus. The crowds are excited. But the opposition has its way.
	Suffering in Jerusalem 14:1 – 15:47	The opposition appears to be in charge and the disciples are scattered.
Conclusion – 16:1-8 “He has risen!” (v. 6), and will be reunited with his disciples, “just as he told you” (v. 7).		

There are other ways of understanding the structure of Mark. For example, R T France sees the book as a “Drama in three acts”, a development of the table above. He suggests the following:

Act One is ‘In Galilee’ (1:1 to 8:21).

Act Two is ‘On the Way to Jerusalem - Learning about the Cross’ (8:21 – 10:52).

Act Three is simply ‘Jerusalem’ (11:1 to the end).

b) What message does it contain?

Each passage of Mark makes a point. But all these points contribute to the big picture of Mark’s Gospel:

- Isaiah’s hope of God’s kingship being established through his chosen Messiah or Christ is near.
- Jesus is that Christ or Messiah

- The Messiah is the servant king, and God's rule will be established through the suffering of the servant.
- Jesus' disciples are called to follow in his steps as his agents, "Anyone who wants to be first must be the very last, and the servant of all." Mark 9:35

1.5 MAKING THE CONNECTIONS BETWEEN MARK'S SITUATION AND TODAY

What connections are there between Mark's situation and our situation today? We will need to make the connections at each point and each passage, but we can make some general connections.

For example, Christians often seem to expect glory without suffering – as though suffering and pain and opposition were somehow foreign to Christian discipleship. Mark clearly teaches that this is not the case and that the reverse is true as they follow a Messiah who was "familiar with pain" (Isaiah 53:3).

- Can you comment on this central idea in the light of your own experience, or the experience of your church?

1.6 TEACHING THE CONTENT OF MARK TODAY

Discuss how you would begin to teach the message of Mark to your people today. And think through how you might begin a series of teaching on Mark.

- What **main points** would you make?

- How would you **raise these issues** with your listeners?

1.7 CONCLUSION

Here are some bullet points about Mark's Gospel:

- Jesus, who is the Christ, is at the centre.
- Isaiah's message is at the heart of the OT background, a message about the hope of God's reign being established.
- Isaiah's Servant King (Isaiah 42:1), the Lord himself, is the one who will quietly, patiently and steadily put things right under his rule.
- The book is all about who Jesus is, as king, and the nature of his kingship.
- It is written for suffering believers who follow a suffering servant on the way to God's new and renewed world.

We have mentioned the significance of Isaiah as an OT reference point for understanding Mark's gospel and 1 Peter as an NT reference point for understanding Mark's gospel. Reflect on the passage below in the light of the points above:

> "In this you greatly rejoice, though now for a little while you may have had to suffer grief in all kinds of trials. These have come so that your faith—of greater worth than gold, which perishes even though refined by fire—may be proved genuine and may result in praise, glory and honour when Jesus Christ is revealed." (1 Peter 1:6-7)

Unit 2. Mark 2:1-12 (Encounter)

Overview

This unit adapts the steps of how to encounter a passage of the Bible that we learnt in Module One and applies them to the gospels, using Mark 2:1-13 as an example. In addition, it looks at how to preach from Mark and the Gospels, applying the lessons to Mark 2:1-13.

Outline

- Adapting and applying the steps of encountering a Bible passage to the gospels
- Worksheet for Encountering Mark 2:1-12 (Step 1)
- Worksheet for Encountering Mark 2:1-12 (Steps 2-4)
- Responding to the message of Mark 2:1-12
- Preaching Mark and the Gospels

Outcomes

At the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Follow and apply the four steps of Encountering a Bible passage to a passage from Mark yourself
2. Share the message of Mark 2:1-12 with a group of people today

This unit builds on previous units in Modules One and Two, where we learnt how to encounter a passage of the Bible. Before you go any further with the unit read the passage out loud, or get the participants to in small groups, and encourage and note any initial reactions to this encounter with the passage: What point is Mark making? What is striking? Is there anything new you notice?

2.1 ADAPTING THE STEPS OF ENCOUNTERING A PASSAGE FOR THE GOSPELS

In Module One we applied the steps of encountering a Bible passage to the Pastoral Epistles, which mainly contain teaching.

In Module Two we adapted those steps and applied them to stories in the Bible.

The Gospels themselves are stories that contain teaching. In this module we will adapt and apply everything that we had learnt so far to the Gospels.

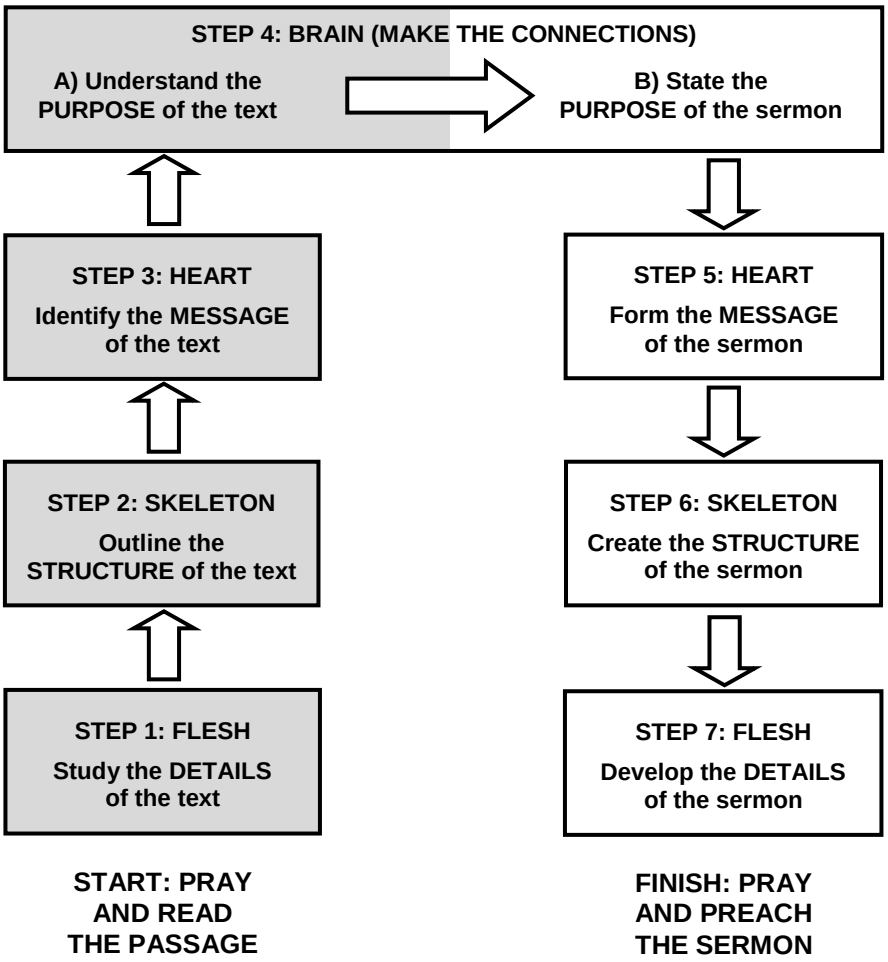
2.1.1 Recalling the Seven Steps of Scripture Sculpture

Recall the *Seven Steps of Scripture Sculpture,* which take you from a passage of Scripture to the message of a sermon, and **explain** them to a fellow participant.

*As a Trainer remind the participants about scripture sculpture. Remind them that: We study the **flesh (step 1)** of the text, the detail of the passage in front of us. The more we study the flesh the more we begin to see the **skeleton (step 2)**, the structure of the passage appear. And the more we continue to study the passage the more we get to the **heart (step 3)** of it, the central message. Finally, we grasp, or are gripped by the **brain (step 4)** of the text, the purpose the original author had in mind.*

*That brain or purpose will help us develop a **brain (step 4)** or purpose for our preaching. Remember, never preach unless you know why you are preaching. And we can then go on to develop the **heart (step 5)** of our sermon, based on the heart of the passage applied to our people today. The passage may lead to a natural **skeleton (step 6)** or structure for the teaching, or, as our culture and context is different, we may need to develop our own structure to convey the message. Finally, we can develop the **flesh (step 7)** of the sermon, the details we will use to preach the message: the illustrations, applications, words and phrases.*

The Seven Steps of Scripture Sculpture:



Remember that the first four steps of Scripture Sculpture, shaded in grey, became the *Four Steps of Encountering a Bible Passage*. They help us discover the original message and purpose of a passage, its heart and brain.

Those four steps of encountering a Bible passage remain the same for any type of Biblical material. Here they are again, each with a reminder of the outcome of each step, and the smaller steps involved.

The Four Steps of Encountering a Bible Passage:

STEP 1: FLESH – Study the DETAILS of the text

At the end of this step you will know and understand the key components of the passage. You need to:

a) Set the text in **context**
b) See the **details**
c) Seek the **meaning**
d) Summarise the **findings**

STEP 2: SKELETON – Outline the STRUCTURE of the text

At the end of this step you will be able to sketch out the structure of the passage and see how the author makes his point. You need to:

a) Note all the **bones** in the structure
b) Decide on the '**big bones**' and make an **outline** of the structure

STEP 3: HEART – Identify the MESSAGE of the text

At the end of this step you will be able to write out the author's main point in one or two sentences. You need to:

a) State the **theme** of the passage
b) State the **message** of the passage

STEP 4: BRAIN – Understand the PURPOSE of the text

At the end of this step you will be able to explain the purpose of the passage and will begin to make connections for teaching it today. You need to:

a) State the **purpose** of the passage
b) Make **connections** for teaching today

We will now adapt each step and apply them to Mark 2:1-12.

2.1.2 STEP 1: FLESH – study the DETAILS of the text

At the end of this step you will be familiar with the key components of the passage as you **set** the text in context, **see** the details, **seek** the meaning and **summarise** the findings.

Before you go any further READ THE PASSAGE (you'll find it in section 2.2, below).

a) Set the text in context

Remember, before we look at any individual Bible passage, we need to look at the book as a whole. That means keeping our general discoveries from the previous unit in mind, particularly those from Steps 1 and 2, the context and content of the book (see below).

Encountering a book of the Bible:

Step 1: Establish the original CONTEXT of the book
- Where does the book fit in the Bible's **story**?
- What **situation** was the book was written for?
- What **style** of writing was it written in?

Step 2: Discover the CONTENT of the book
- What is the **structure** of the book?
- What are the main **themes** of the book?
- What is the **message** of the book?
- What is the **purpose** of the book?

In order to set our passage in that context, remember those same three words: **story**, **situation** and **style**.

Look at our passage in your Bible and your Trainer will guide you through the relevant points below.

You can make notes in the blank spaces as we go along, and then make a summary in the blank worksheet for Step 1, which can be found in Section 2.3 below.

Story
We need to think about the passage in relation to where it comes in the Bible and in the book:

- How does it fit into the structure and themes of Mark's story? For example, what are the themes of the surrounding passages?

"Capernaum" links it to the Galilean ministry. The "crowd" and the opposition are there. 'Who is Jesus?' is a central theme of the passage. Mark 1:21-45 is all about the authority of Jesus (e.g. 1:22 & 1:27).

- Do you notice any ways in which the passage links with the Old Testament and the story of the Bible?

Mark's Isaiah theme is there in the healing (Isaiah 35:5-6). "The Son of Man" is an important link to the OT story – one with authority who represents both God and his people. Here he is given power to forgive (in Daniel 7:14 he is given power to judge).

Situation
Remember the two different situations to keep in mind:

- Are there any links with **Mark's** situation (e.g. his writing for a suffering church)?
- Are there any links with **Jesus'** situation (e.g. opposition from religious leaders)?

For example, the 'Son of Man' is an important theme for suffering Christians – Christ is Lord and judge.

The 'teachers of the law' are a vital part of Jesus' context.

Style
We need to think about Mark's style of writing:

- What sort of writing is this passage: is it story or teaching or a combination?
- If it contains teaching, what form is that teaching in: sermon, parable, saying or some other form?
- Are there parallels in the other gospels? If 'yes' then what makes this account unique; if 'no' then why has Mark included this?

For example, compare Mark 2:1-12 with Luke 5:17-26 and Matthew 9:1-8.

Luke 5:18 notes that, 'the power of the Lord was with Jesus to heal'. This is in line with Luke's introduction to Jesus' ministry in Luke 4. Mark, on the other hand, emphasises the fact that "he preached the word to them". Their 'faith' is noticed by Jesus in all three accounts. Matthew concludes by noting Jesus' authority, a point Mark does not make directly here, but one which he makes through the 'Son of Man' reference and has made already (noted above: Mark 1:21-45 is all about the authority of Jesus).

There is a summary of the above in the completed worksheet.

b) See the details of the text

We have already begun to notice some of the details; we will now highlight the most important ones.

To do this we will **look** for the important details, **highlight** them on the passage, and **list** them in the worksheet.

Look
As you read the story **look** for:

1. **Repeated** and **related** words and phrases

2. **Important**, **complicated** and **unusual** words and phrases

3. Connections and **links** between the words and phrases

Remember to do this from two perspectives**:**

First, Mark's key themes
As you listen and look at a passage note the words and phrases that link the passage with the themes and purpose of Mark's gospel. Use the work you did in Step 1 and tie it to specific details in the passage.

Second, Mark's two main types of writing: story and teaching
We looked at story in Module Two and teaching in Module One. You might need to go back to those modules to remind yourself of what you have learnt.

Remember, for **story** we are looking for key words and phrases that relate to: the narrator; the scenes; the characters; the plot; and, the message. For example, we can note what the narrator, Mark, emphasises in comparison to the other evangelists.

And for **teaching** we are looking for how any argument is built. Look for words and phrases that indicate reasons (for..., therefore..., if...), contrasts (not..., but...), comparisons and illustrations (like...), connections (and..., this..., which...).

NOTE: LISTEN to the text being read out loud
The gospels were originally read out loud. LISTEN to them as well as looking at them. Note what you hear with your ears as well as what you see with your eyes. This will also help you to teach oral learners. Note any features they mention and read them back to them. This will facilitate your learning as much as theirs.

Highlight
Previous modules encouraged us to mark and **highlight** the passage to help us see with our eyes what we hear with our ears. It improves our powers of observation and helps with learning and teaching.

The passage we are looking at now is given in the worksheet below (Section 2.2). This is how it might appear in your Bible. Your Trainer will demonstrate how you can write, underline, divide up the passage and draw on the text to highlight the important details we are beginning to notice. Be creative and use different shapes and colours if you can.

Green, red, and blue are the most common colours available for black boards or whiteboards. If you do have these colours, use BUILD's simple 'grass, earth and sky' system. Think of them in relation to the **green** of the grass (which covers the land), the **red** of the soil (that is so important for life) and the **blue** of the sky (that connects everything together).

Mark the passage as follows:

1. For **repeated** or **related** words and phrases use **green**

2. For other **important** or **unusual** words and phrases use **red**

3. For **connections** between the words and phrases use **blue**

You can use **black** (or **white** on a chalk board) for more general underlining, notes and structural divisions.

But remember, **be selective** - if you mark everything you have marked nothing!

Go ahead and mark up the passage now.

See the completed text worksheet below and use it to guide your participants.

List
Once you have marked the passage, list the important words and phrases in the worksheet for Step 1 (go to Section 2.3 below).

See the sample worksheet with comments for Trainers below.

c) Seek the meaning from the details

To seek the meaning of the details you have noticed and listed, begin to ask and answer questions:

- What do these words and phrases mean today in your language?
- What did they mean in the context of the Bible when it was written?
- What is the significance of any relationships and links between the words?
- Review your answers – are they simple, true and consistent in the context of the book, the group of books and the Bible?

Record your observations in the worksheet. Your Trainer will guide you through this.

d) Summarise the findings

Draw on all the above. What are the main things you have discovered, the most important ideas that you want to carry forward?

See the sample worksheet in Section 2.2 below.

2.1.3 STEP 2: SKELETON – outline the STRUCTURE of the text

At the end of this step you will be able to sketch out the structure of the story and see how Mark makes his point.

a) Note all the bones in the structure

You are aiming to discover the structure Mark is using. You need to combine your skills of looking at stories and your skills of looking at teaching. Be aware of how Mark might be using Jesus' own story telling and teaching structures.

See the completed worksheet and use that to guide your participants.

b) Decide on the 'big bones' and make an outline of the structure

There are major parts of the structure and minor ones; big bones and small bones. What are the 'big bones' in the passage that give it shape and structure? Capture this by making a simple summary outline of the passage. Using the clear story structure to carry the themes is a good way ahead.

See the completed worksheet and use that to guide your participants.

2.1.4 STEP 3: HEART – identify the MESSAGE of the text

At the end of this step you will be able to write out the author's main point in a sentence or two.

Remember, the Bible is 'God preaching' to his people. Therefore, a biblical message is more than just information; it tells us something important and practical about that information.

A simple way of identifying the message of a passage is to note what the author's theme is <u>and</u> to note what he is saying about that theme.

a) State the theme of the passage

Take time and care to reflect on and pray over your discoveries so far and try and capture the theme as simply and as clearly as you can. What is the main thing he talking about?

See the completed worksheet and use that to guide your participants.

b) State the message of the passage

Think about this theme and answer this question: What is the author saying about this theme?

Remember, you are aiming to discover the original meaning of a text. Therefore, you need to state the message to the original listeners by completing a sentence that begins like this: "Mark wants his listeners to understand that..."

See the completed worksheet and use that to guide your participants.

2.1.5 STEP 4: BRAIN – understand the PURPOSE of the text

At the end of this step you will be able to explain the purpose of the passage and will have made some connections so that you can teach it today.

a) State the purpose of the passage.

Keeping in mind the context of the passage you need to answer the question: Why is the author making this point?

See the completed worksheet and use that to guide your participants.

b) Make connections for teaching today.

The aim of the first four steps of Scripture Sculpture is to discover the original meaning of the passage.

However, the real aim of encountering a passage of Scripture is to apply it to our lives and ministries and to experience its transforming power. We want to discover the significance of the passage for us today.

We must keep in mind not only where the passage belongs in its original context, but also where it belongs in our hearts and lives, in our congregations and communities.

The message statement, **what** is being said, is important as we make connections today. The purpose statement, **why** it is being said is also important.

Think about **what** you and your people need to hear from this Bible passage and **why** they need to hear it.

Capture that in the form of a statement or a question that makes some connections with your situation and your congregation's situation today.

See the completed worksheet and use that to guide your participants.

2.2 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING MARK 2:1-12 (THE PASSAGE)

1 A few days later, when Jesus again
entered Capernaum, the people heard
that he had come home. **2** They gathered
in such large numbers that there was no
room left, not even outside the door, and
he preached the word to them. **3** Some
men came, bringing to him a paralysed
man, carried by four of them. **4** Since they
could not get him to Jesus because of the
crowd, they made an opening in the roof
above Jesus by digging through it and
then lowered the mat the man was lying
on. **5** When Jesus saw their faith, he said
to the paralysed man, 'Son, your sins are
forgiven.'
6 Now some teachers of the law were
sitting there, thinking to
themselves, **7** 'Why does this fellow talk
like that? He's blaspheming! Who can
forgive sins but God alone?'
8 Immediately Jesus knew in his spirit
that this was what they were thinking in
their hearts, and he said to them, 'Why
are you thinking these things? **9** Which is
easier: to say to this paralysed man,
"Your sins are forgiven," or to say, "Get
up, take your mat and walk"?
10 But I want you to know that the Son
of Man has authority on earth to forgive
sins.' So he said to the man, **11** 'I tell you,
get up, take your mat and go home.' **12** He
got up, took his mat and walked out in full
view of them all. This amazed everyone
and they praised God, saying, 'We have
never seen anything like this!' (NIV)

2.3 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING MARK 2:1-12 – STEP 1

STEP 1: FLESH – study the DETAILS of the text

a) Set the passage in context. How does the passage relate to the book as a whole?

Mark's story: *"Capernaum" links it to Galilee. Crowd and opposition are there.* ***The Bible's story:*** *"Son of Man" link to Daniel 7:14. Isaiah's theme of healing (Is 35:5-6).*

Jesus' situation: *The opposition is there.* ***Mark's situation:*** *"Son of Man" and suffering Christians.*

Mark's style: *Compared with Matthew and Luke, Mark emphasises that "he preached the word to them".*

b) See the details of the text	**c) Seek the meaning from the details**
List words, phrases and relationships:	Explain words, phrases and relationships:
"A few days later" (v. 1)	*Links the passage back. Passage of time*
"Jesus", "he" throughout	*Jesus centre stage*
"the people", "so many", "the crowd"	*Popularity, plus "the crowds" as a group*
"preached the word" (v. 2)	*The word of the kingdom. Mark's emphasis*
"paralytic" (x4, from v. 3)	*Clearly disabled. OT fulfilment (Isaiah 35)*
"faith" (v. 5)	*Trust in Christ demonstrated in practice*
"sins...forgiven" (x4, vv. 5, 7, 9, 10)	*Jesus' mission. Link between sin and sickness.*
"blaspheming" (v. 7)	*Misuse of God's name, punishable by death*
"God alone" (v. 7)	*Emphasising uniqueness of God and Christ*
"the Son of Man" (v. 10)	*Daniel 7:14 – one given authority by Yahweh*
"authority" (v. 10)	*Jesus claiming authority to forgive*
"never seen anything like this" (v. 12)	*In seeing the healing, the crowds recognise Jesus' unique authority*

d) Summarise the findings. What are the main ideas that come out of this initial study?

The preaching of the word, the message of the kingdom, belongs with healing and forgiveness.

Jesus' mission is to do with the root of the problem, the forgiveness of sins.

There is a link between sin and sickness, forgiveness and healing.

God alone has authority to forgive sins.

The Son of Man has that authority to forgive sins.

Jesus does what God alone can do.

2.4 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING MARK 2:1-12 – STEPS 2 TO 4

Help the participants to fill in their worksheets by using and adapting the guidelines below.

STEP 2: SKELETON – outline the STRUCTURE of the text

a) Note all the bones in the structure. What elements highlight the structure?

*There are a number of **links** in the passage: "A few days later" (v. 1); "When..." (v. 5); "Now" (v. 6); "Immediately" (v. 8); "But" (v. 10); "This" (v. 12).*

*There are also various **themes** which can be used (preaching the word; sickness and sin; opposition and blasphemy; etc.).*

*And there is the **structure** of the story: Setting (vv. 1-2); Problem (v. 4); Initial solution (v. 5); Problem intensifies (v. 6-9); Fuller solution (vv. 10-11); Outcome (v. 12)*

b) Decide on the 'big bones' and make an outline of the structure. What are the most important parts of the structure? Can you describe the main sections?

vv. 1-2 Setting – Proclaiming the gospel to the crowds

vv. 3-5 Problem and initial solution – Proclaiming forgiveness to the disabled man

vv. 6-11 A greater problem and fuller solution – Jesus' unique authority to proclaim forgiveness and healing

v. 12 Outcome – Jesus' unique authority is demonstrated and recognised

STEP 3: HEART – identify the MESSAGE of the text

a) State the theme of the passage. What is the author's main point?

The theme of Mark 2:1-12 is God's unique authority to forgive sins

b) State the message of the passage. What is the author saying about his theme?

Mark wants his listeners to understand that Jesus has God's unique authority to forgive sins

STEP 4: BRAIN – first, understand the PURPOSE of the text...

a) State the purpose of the passage. Why is the author making this point?

Mark is making this point in order to build a true picture of the true Christ, ultimately so that people will recognise and respond to Jesus' unique authority and power to forgive.

b) Make connections for teaching today. What is the relevance of this for us?

How do people seek forgiveness today? For the real forgiveness we need, Christ himself, alone, is the answer.

2.5 RESPONDING TO THE MESSAGE OF MARK 2:1-12

In 2.5, below, we will think through how the steps of preparing a sermon that we learnt in Module One apply to preaching from the Gospels generally, and to Mark 2:1-12 specifically.

But before we do so we will respond to the message of Mark 2:1-12 at a more basic level, by using the three questions we have used before, questions that apply the discoveries we have made in the steps of encountering that passage.

These questions consider the theme, message and purpose of the passage and how they apply to us today, as well as how we can share that message with others.

They therefore form a bridge, which will then help us to think about preaching from this type of biblical material. Here are the three questions:

1. Describe how the message you discovered in the passage spoke to you personally: What did you learn or need to be reminded of?

2. Share how the purpose of the passage helped you to apply God's word to your life: What change will this passage make to your thinking and living?

3. State and explain the message you will share with others using your own words: What is the main thing you want people to understand?

2.6 PREACHING FROM MARK AND THE GOSPELS

We have encountered and responded to Mark 2:1-12. We will now build on that and think through how to preach from Mark and the Gospels.

Remember, the steps we have followed in encountering a Bible passage form the first half of a process called 'Scripture Sculpture', a process that takes us from reading a Bible passage to preaching that passage. In order to think through how we can preach from Mark and the Gospels we will do three things:

First, we will first remember all seven steps in the 'Scripture Sculpture' process, so that we can see how it all joins together.

Secondly, we will think through how what we have already learnt about Mark and the Gospels in the first few units of this module impact the way in which we preach from these books. In other words, how we should approach the final steps in the process.

Finally, we will apply these lessons to Mark 2:1-12 and produce the key components for a sermon on that passage.

2.6.1 Remembering the seven steps of the Scripture Sculpture process

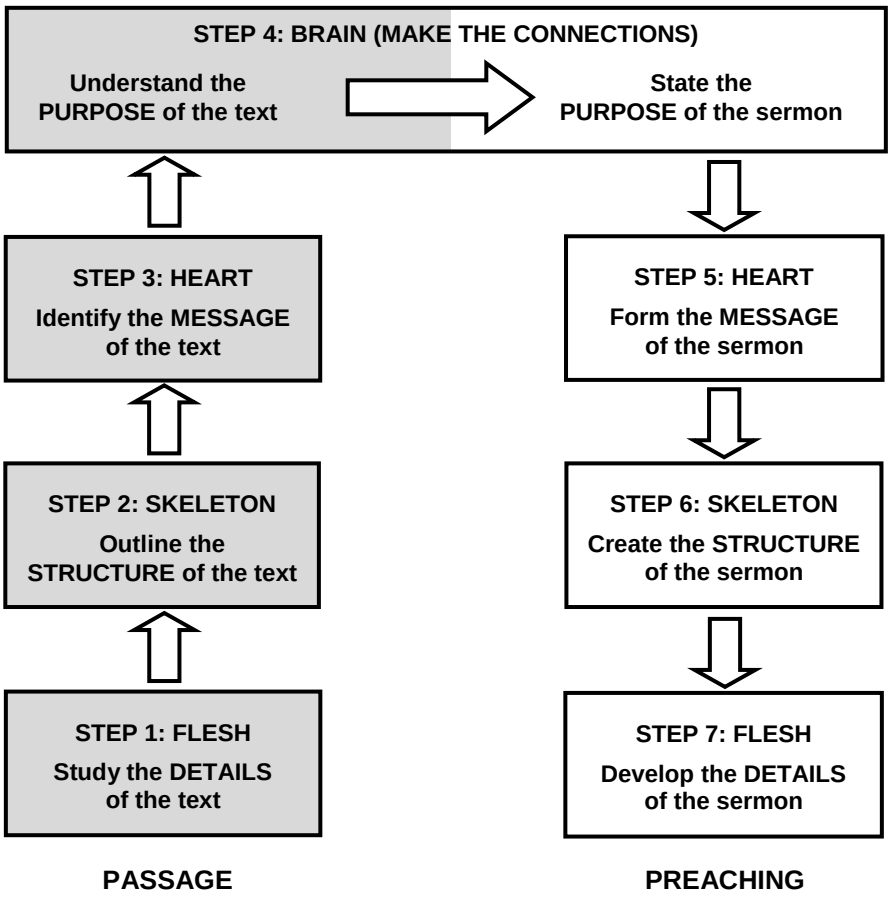
In the seven steps of the Scripture Sculpture process, below, we have gone up the left-hand side of the diagram:

> We have studied the details of the text and become familiar with its 'flesh'.
>
> We have outlined the structure of the text and have seen its 'bones'.
>
> We have identified the message of the text and got to its 'heart'.
>
> Finally, we have understood the purpose of the text, and seen the 'brain' behind it.

That last step is part of a bridge that leads into the right-hand side, where the focus is on preparing the sermon or talk; we began to think about the connections with our world and our churches today.

The next stage is to think through how to build on all this work, beginning with a clear purpose statement for the sermon. Then, using the observations from our work on the passage we need to create a 'heart', a 'skeleton', and finally some 'flesh' for our teaching.

Here is that Scripture Sculpture diagram, again, so you can see what has been done already (in grey), and what needs to be done as we develop a sermon (in white):



This means we will be focussing on the second part of Step 4 and then on steps 5 to 7. Those steps are summarised below in a table taken from Unit 13 of Module One. Look back at that unit for more guidance if you need to.

Completing the Scripture Sculpture process:

STEP 4: BRAIN – state the PURPOSE of the sermon

At the end of this step you will be able to state and explain the purpose of the sermon. You need to:

a) Keep your **listeners** in mind
b) Decide what God wants your people to **understand and obey**
c) State the **purpose** of the sermon

STEP 5: HEART – form the MESSAGE of the sermon

At the end of this step you will be able to state and explain the message of the sermon in one or two sentences. You need to:

a) State the **theme** of your sermon
b) Build on that and state the **message** of your sermon
c) **Check** that the message 'works' for your people today

STEP 6: SKELETON – create the STRUCTURE of the sermon

At the end of this step you will have a clear outline for the sermon. You need to:

a) Clarify the **main points** or structure of the sermon
b) Create an **introduction**
c) Develop the **body**
d) Have an idea for the **conclusion**

STEP 7: FLESH – develop the DETAILS of the sermon

At the end of this step you can preach the sermon to your people. You need to:

a) Remember the importance of **words**
b) Create **notes** that will help you to preach
c) Use your **voice** to communicate
d) Take care with **presentation**
e) Remember the importance of **evaluation**

Keep these steps in mind as you study the sections below about Mark and the gospels. We will take these steps above and use them as a worksheet for preparing sermon outlines throughout the module.

2.6.2 How to preach from Mark and the gospels

First, if we look back at some of the questions we began with in Unit 1, we can think about how they inform our preaching of Mark and the gospels.

- What is Mark's book all about?

It is all about Jesus. Our preaching must put Jesus, and who he is, at the centre.

- Why do you think Mark's book became known as a 'gospel'?

Mark's book is full of good news – 'the gospel' – about Jesus. Our preaching must be full of the good news, a declaration of the goods news with an expectation of response.

- Why do you think Mark quotes from Malachi 3:1 and Isaiah 40:3?

Isaiah is important to Mark and will be important in our preaching of Mark. Make it your main OT reference point for preaching Mark; that will bring a focus to it. Think through how the other gospel writers use the OT and, when preaching from those, apply that to your preaching.

- Which events in the story of Israel, God's story, might Mark be looking back to?

We noticed the link with the exodus and exile through the book of Isaiah. Remember, Mark is about the real end of the exile, a new exodus that Jesus will lead. Our preaching needs to connect with the Old Testament story and demonstrate how Christ brings it to fulfilment, for us, today.

- What is at the heart of Jesus' work?

Jesus went "proclaiming" the gospel – the good news of God. The kingdom of God is central to all Jesus' work and teaching. The good news of the kingdom needs to be the central theme of our preaching. We will learn more about the kingdom in Unit 3.

Second, we noticed that Mark is primarily **narrative** and **teaching**. That means our preaching must retell the story and use the stories (Module Two, Unit 7 (7.5.2), explains how stories affect our preaching, you might need to go back to that). And it means that we need to allow Christ to teach our people as we preach.

Jesus' teaching was through parables and illustrations and it is very rich in that material. In your preaching use those parables as the powerful communication tools that they are: retell them for today. We will learn more about the parables in Unit 4.

Because of all the above, and much more besides, we must make our preaching:

- Full of Jesus, the Christ, and the portrait Mark paints.
- Full of good news about God's kingdom, and all that Mark shares about it.
- Full of stories from the gospels.
- Full of pictures from the gospels.

2.6.3 Preaching the message of Mark 2:1-12

Use the table below to outline some of the key ideas in your sermon or talk:

STEP 4: BRAIN – state the PURPOSE of the sermon My sermon's purpose statement: *"I want my people to recognise and to respond to Jesus' unique power to forgive"*
STEP 5: HEART – form the MESSAGE of the sermon My sermon's theme and its message statement: *My theme: Forgiveness* *My message: Christ is unique in being able to offer full and free forgiveness*
STEP 6: SKELETON – create the STRUCTURE of the sermon My sermon's outline (with the main points, introduction and conclusion): *A setting for controversy (used as an introduction)* *A controversial word of forgiveness* *A controversial figure* *Have you ever seen anything like this? (used as a conclusion)*
STEP 7: FLESH – develop the DETAILS of the sermon My sermon's details (note here key words, explanations, illustrations and applications that will help you write notes or a full sermon):

Unit 3. Understanding the kingdom of God (Reflection)

Overview

Jesus' ministry began with a simple declaration: "The kingdom of God is near" (Mark 1:15). This unit reflects on the significance of that statement for encountering God's word in the gospels and issues in God's world around us.

Outline

- The importance of reflection
- The ERA cycle of reflection
- The new 'ERA': "The kingdom of God is near"
- Encounter
- Reflect
- Action

Outcomes

At the end of the unit, you will be able to

1. Recall the ERA model of reflection and discuss its value
2. Explain why 'ERA' is a good word for the model
3. Draw a diagram to explain the difference between Jesus' understanding of the kingdom and those in his day
4. Apply your understanding of the kingdom of God to an aspect of mission or ministry

This unit reviews the BUILD model of theological reflection and applies it to the important theme of the kingdom of God in order to help participants understand the gospels and begin to see the significance of the theme for mission.

3.1 THE IMPORTANCE OF REFLECTION

Do you remember looking at 2 Timothy 2:1-7 in Module One? Look up and look at those verses in your Bible.

Remember, Paul tells Timothy to pass on the gospel in the strength of Christ as a servant of Christ. He uses three pictures to illustrate what that means in practice. But Paul knows that it is not enough for Timothy just to read his words; that will not guarantee learning and action. Therefore, Paul ends that passage with a command that comes with a promise:

> "Reflect on what I am saying, for the Lord will give you insight into all this".

- What is the command?

- What is the promise?

The command is this: Timothy must pause and consider the apostle's words, carefully and prayerfully; he must engage with the message of God's word in the midst of God's world.

The promise is this: Paul promises Timothy that if he does this God will be his guide and real learning will take place. That genuine learning will lead to ministry that is guided by the gospel, which pleases the Lord.

That process of theological reflection is a three step one that encourages learning and action:

1. It begins when we **encounter** something in God's world and/or God's word with a desire for wisdom.

2. It continues with **reflection** on those situations and Scriptures in order to gain wisdom.

3. It leads to **action** in God's world with the wisdom that comes from God's word.

Such action will take us deeply into God's word and decisively into God's world. That will lead to new encounters, greater reflection and more action.

In other words, the process is a cycle that we need to continually engage with, in order to learn deeply and to lead well.

We are engaged in that cycle whether we like it or not – we are constantly encountering new things and new truths. But we need to engage with the word and the world in a disciplined way so that we are caught up in a productive cycle that pleases God rather than a vicious circle of constantly reacting to situations.

We noted that this cycle is **Bible Study** at its best: a living encounter with the living word for living in the world to God's praise and glory.

3.2 THE ERA CYCLE OF REFLECTION

We called the cycle the 'ERA Cycle of Reflection' with its three basic steps:

1. Encounter

The first step is to encounter something in God's world and/or God's word with a desire for wisdom.

- To <u>encounter</u> something is to meet something new, surprising and unsettling.

- You need to <u>describe</u> the things you encounter and your reactions.

- You must list the <u>discoveries</u> you have made.

However, those descriptions and discoveries will be shallow. They will not explain the meaning and significance of the encounter or experience. Rather than taking action immediately, you need to take the next step.

2. Reflection

The second step is to reflect on those situations and the Scriptures in order to gain wisdom.

- To reflect is to pause for thought rather than to react. It is to question, to think and go deeper, to chew things over.
- You need to consider the discoveries you have made in the light of the God's word and in his presence.
- You must list the principles, the new perspectives or ways of looking at life and ministry that come from this.

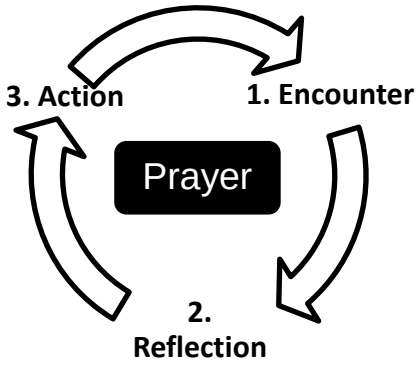
It is tempting to leave these principles as interesting topics for discussion. But rather than leaving them as theories on a page, you need to put what you have learnt into practice and take the final step.

3. Action

The final step is to take action in God's world with the wisdom that comes from God's word.

- To take action is to do something new or in a new way.
- You need to plan to put the principles into practice.
- The outcome will be new practice: ministry and mission that is more faithful to the gospel.

However, this final step is never final, because genuine action in God's world leads to new encounters, greater reflection and renewed action.



Example: Imagine you encounter a new teaching about prayer in the Bible or a new practice of prayer in the church. It causes you to study the Scriptures and reflect on prayer and the practice of prayer. That in turn leads you to act differently in your prayer life. And as you try these new ways of praying you will then have fresh encounters to reflect on and act on.

Summary table for the ERA cycle:

Step and description	Definition of key word	Activity	Outcome
To **encounter** something in God's world and/or God's word with a desire for wisdom.	**'Encounter':** To meet something new and surprising	Describe	Discoveries
To **reflect** on those situations and the Scriptures in order to gain wisdom.	**'Reflect':** To pause for thought and go deeper	Consider	Principles
To take **action** in God's world with the wisdom that comes from God's word.	**'Action':** To do something new or in a different way.	Plan	Practice

3.3 THE NEW 'ERA': "THE KINGDOM OF GOD IS NEAR"

In Module One we learned that in English the word **'ERA'** is a simple and helpful way of remembering these three steps:

'E' for **Encounter** ➔ **'R'** for **Reflection** ➔ **'A'** for **Action**

And there is meaning to this way of remembering the steps. An **era** is a word for a significant period of time. For example, the reign of a king is known as the era of that ruler.

That is why ERA is a helpful way of remembering this cycle: the reason to wrestle with the situations we face in the light of the gospel, and to then return to the context of God's world with renewed action is to bring about transformation and change.

The change we are seeking is that "God's will be done on earth as it is in heaven". In other words, to point to God's kingdom, the new era he is bringing through Christ his king.

In Mark's Gospel Jesus begins his ministry by "proclaiming the good news of God". That gospel is this: "The time has come," he said. "The kingdom of God is near. Repent and believe the good news!" (Mark 1:15).

In other words, a new era has dawned. This new era of the kingdom of God is central to Jesus' mission, central to Mark's gospel, and central to the gospel we proclaim. In fact, Matthew calls it the "gospel of the kingdom" (Matt 24:14), which summarises Mark 1:15.

We have already encountered this important theme and will throughout the module. In order to understand Mark's Gospel and in order to understand our part in God's mission we need to reflect on the meaning and significance of the kingdom of God using the ERA steps.

3.4 ENCOUNTER

Describe and **discover** things as you **discuss** the following:

- Christians frequently use the phrase 'the kingdom of God', but they rarely seem to know what it really means. In your experience, what different ideas do Christians have in mind when they talk about 'the kingdom of God'? (Include ways in which the phrase is misused and misunderstood.)

- In order to be clear, you might want to include ways in which you think some Christians use and misuse the term.

- What do you think Jesus meant by "The kingdom of God"?

- What makes "The kingdom of God" a difficult idea for people to understand today? Or, on the other hand, what makes it relevant to their lives?

The theme of the kingdom of God is central to Mark's gospel. But the phrase 'the kingdom of God' only appears fourteen times, as below. Look at these references and the surrounding passages and discuss what strikes you about the kingdom of God.

You might want to divide these passages up within groups or between groups. This should not be a detailed task; this is a first encounter.

1. Mark 1:15 - "The time has come," he said. "The **kingdom** of God is near. Repent and believe the good news!"

2. Mark 4:11 - He told them, "The secret of the **kingdom** of God has been given to you. But to those on the outside everything is said in parables ... "

3. Mark 4:26 - He also said, "This is what the **kingdom** of God is like. A man scatters seed on the ground ... "

4. Mark 4:30 - Again he said, "What shall we say the **kingdom** of God is like, or what parable shall we use to describe it?"

5. Mark 9:1 - And he said to them, "I tell you the truth, some who are standing here will not taste death before they see the **kingdom** of God come with power."

6. Mark 9:47 - And if your eye causes you to sin, pluck it out. It is better for you to enter the **kingdom** of God with one eye than to have two eyes and be thrown into hell.

7 and 8. Mark 10:14-15 - When Jesus saw this, he was indignant. He said to them, "Let the little children come to me, and do not hinder them, for the **kingdom** of God belongs to such as these. I tell you the truth, anyone who will not receive the **kingdom** of God like a little child will never enter it."

9, 10 and 11. Mark 10:23-25 - Jesus looked around and said to his disciples, "How hard it is for the rich to enter the **kingdom** of God!" The disciples were amazed at his words. But Jesus said again, "Children, how hard it is to enter the **kingdom** of God! It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for a rich man to enter the **kingdom** of God."

12. Mark 12:34 - When Jesus saw that he had answered wisely, he said to him, "You are not far from the **kingdom** of God." And from then on no one dared ask him any more questions.

13. Mark 14:25 - "I tell you the truth, I will not drink again of the fruit of the vine until that day when I drink it anew in the **kingdom** of God."

14. Mark 15:43 - Joseph of Arimathea, a prominent member of the Council, who was himself waiting for the **kingdom** of God, went boldly to Pilate and asked for Jesus' body.

- In the light of your discussion how would you begin to **describe** the kingdom of God? What new **discoveries** have you made?

3.5 REFLECT

Pause for thought and go deeper. **Consider** the discoveries you have made and begin to draw out some **principles** about the kingdom of God. Use these 6 questions, with your trainer help:

1. Who? Who is the focus of the kingdom of God? Who is involved in its coming?

2. What? What is the nature of God’s kingdom?

3. Why? Why is God’s kingdom coming?

4. When? When will God’s kingdom come?

5. Where? Where will God’s kingdom come?

6. How? How will God’s kingdom come?

- Can you think of texts and truths in Mark and the gospels that shed light on these questions, including those we have already looked at above?

1. Who? Who is the focus of the kingdom of God? Who is involved?

It is God's kingdom and Jesus, God's anointed king stands at its centre. Mark's stories about Jesus demonstrate his kingly authority, particularly those in chapters 1-8.

God's people are the subjects of the kingdom, the new family or community of those who do God's will (Mark 3:31-35). That family consists of both Jew and Gentile (Mark anticipates that, e.g. 7:24f). Against the culture of the day Mark, following Jesus, consistently describes women in positive ways, climaxing in their presence at the cross (ch. 15) and in their being the first witnesses of the resurrection (ch. 16). And the sick, the poor, and the outcasts are included (2:16). The mark of belonging is obedience to the king and to the demands of his rule, rather than any social indicators.

2. What? What is the nature of God's kingdom?

God is becoming king. It is all about his rule and reign – what it looks like when God is in charge: wrongs righted, sins forgiven, men made new, creation renewed.

The Old Testament story and expectation is important if we are to understand the kingdom of God. Remember Module Two: (1) Creation. God created the whole earth and is king of all the earth. (2) Fall. The kingdom of this world is set against God through man's rebellion and Satan's schemes. (3) Salvation. Remember the story of salvation including the Exodus. Yahweh is the great KING, over Pharaoh the king. God commands: "Let my people go". That theme of God's kingship is developed in the Psalms: for example, Mark 1:11 refers back to Psalm 2:7. The Psalms are full of it, e.g. Psalm 47:1.

Mark links the enthronement of God with the end of the Exile and the New Exodus of Isaiah 35 and 40-55 (for example see the mixture of images from the Exodus and the Return from Exile in Isaiah 35). Isaiah promises that God will come as king and Mark shares the good news that this is being fulfilled in Christ: God is becoming king and reclaiming and establishing his kingdom. He is 'coming into power' or the 'revolution is on the way' in political language. And all this looks forward to (4) New Creation. Joseph of Arimathea is a faithful Israelite who, in Mark 15:43, is living with these expectations.

For now, the kingdom is "God's redemptive power released into history, bringing good news to the poor, freedom to prisoners, sight to the blind, and liberation to the oppressed" (René Padilla).

3. Why? Why is God's kingdom coming?

God is honouring his covenants and keeping his promises. He is bringing the OT story to completion.

4. When? When will God's kingdom come?

It is both now and not yet; both present and future.
For example: now – Mark 1:15, 10:14f, 12:34; not yet – Mark 9:47, 10:23-25.
It does not arrive all at once but in stages – Mark makes this clear throughout that it is present in Christ, but will be completed in the future.

5. Where? Where will God's kingdom come?

God rules the whole of the creation, which the kingdom of darkness has invaded, but the kingdom of God is breaking in to that, which will ultimately bring in a new heavens and a new earth – a whole new creation.

For now, the kingdom of God is not about a place but about a people – a people who bow the knee to Christ and follow him. For example, see Luke 17:20-21: "The kingdom of God does not come with your careful observation, nor will people say, 'Here it is,' or 'There it is,' because the kingdom of God is within you" [meaning 'among you' or 'in your midst'].

In other words, the church is the community, an outpost, of the kingdom and is where the life of the kingdom is seen and how its influence felt as 'salt and light' in the world. The church is therefore not the kingdom, but the "little flock" that will inherit and inhabit the kingdom (Luke 12:32).

6. How? How will God's kingdom come?

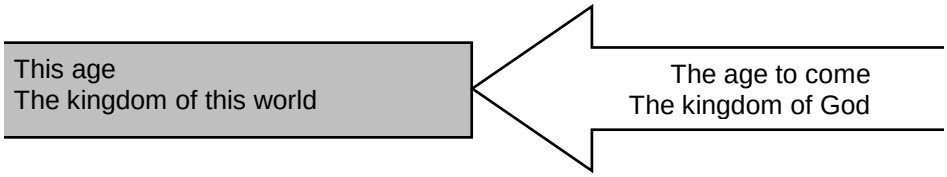
Through the work of Christ: his suffering as the servant king, bearing our sin and bringing an end to our exile and bringing about a new exodus, achieved as one who "did not come to be served, but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many" (10:45).

This work of Christ is then declared through the word of Christ, the gospel, which calls men and women to recognise Jesus for who he is, the Lord of all the earth. Those who come under his rule form a new or renewed people, the church, who together proclaim and demonstrate the kingdom of God, through word and deed. Human values are turned upside down by those of God's rule, in which the first are last and the last first (10:31). Christ's church is therefore "like an arrow sent out into the world to point to the future" (Jürgen Moltmann).

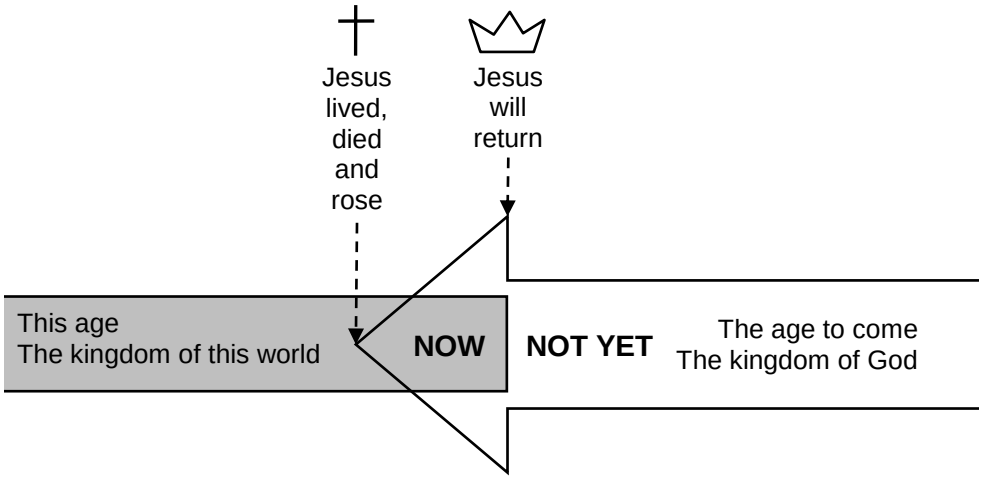
- What are the key **principles** your **consideration** has led to?

NOTE: Jesus' teaching compared with the teaching of his day
Both Jesus and his contemporaries based their understanding of God's coming kingdom on the teaching of the Old Testament. However, Jesus taught the fuller and richer meaning of prophets such as Isaiah.

The popular understanding of God's coming kingdom
- A sudden end to this evil age (sin, sickness, demonic power)
- The beginning of the new age of justice, peace, health, the Spirit's presence



Jesus' fuller understanding of God's coming kingdom
- Jesus' kingship is present NOW but is NOT YET complete
- In other words, the ages are overlapping
- Christ's coming guarantees that this age will come to an end one day
- Christ's coming means the new age has begun already
- Christ's coming appears to be unimpressive
- Christ has authority (Mark 1-2) but that authority can be rejected (Mark 2-3)
- Christ's second coming will bring this evil age to an end and bring in God's new age
- The new age will be seen by all and Christ's authority will be clear.



NOW: Christ's resurrection means…	NOT YET: Christ's return will mean…
Forgiveness, new life, a new community, the presence of the Holy Spirit, future hope	New Creation, new bodies, wrongs righted, final judgement
Sin, sickness and Satan have been defeated but remain present.	Sin, sickness and Satan will be removed forever.

3.6 ACTION

All the above will lead us to **act** very differently. This will mean we need to **plan** to put some of these principles into **practice**, in ministry and mission that is more faithful to the gospel of the kingdom.

The rest of this module applies these principles to areas such as:

1. Understanding Mark's gospel, not least the parables in the next unit
2. Proclaiming the kingdom of God through word and deed
3. Prayer and the kingdom of God
4. Servant leadership
5. The Lord's Supper

- To end this unit: pick just one of the areas above and think of one way in which you would see things differently and do things differently as a result of what you have learnt about the kingdom of God.

Unit 4. Encountering parables (Tools)

Overview
Parables are an essential component of Jesus' teaching and ministry...

Outline
- Introducing Parables – Mark 4:1-20
- Guidelines for understanding Parables
- Steps for understanding parables
- An example of encountering a parable – Luke 7:41-42
- Conclusion

Outcomes
At the end of the unit you will be able to
1. Discuss Jesus' use of parables
2. Give examples of different types of parables
3. Demonstrate how the steps of understanding the Bible can be applied to parables
4. Retell a parable for an audience today

This unit explores Jesus' parables and explains how they can be understood and applied today.

4.1 INTRODUCING PARABLES – MARK 4:1-20

Mark 4:1-20 has been called 'a parable about parables' – a parable that teaches us about how to understand all of the parables. **Read** Mark 4:1-20 and **discuss** the following questions as an introduction to Jesus' parables:

1. What do you think Jesus means by the word 'parable'?
This question is only designed to get the participants thinking about parables. They do not have to come up with a perfect definition and must not be put under pressure to do so. In practice participants will begin to say things such as: "parables are down to earth stories"; or "ordinary stories"; or "simple teaching about the kingdom of God"; or "illustrations from common, everyday life".

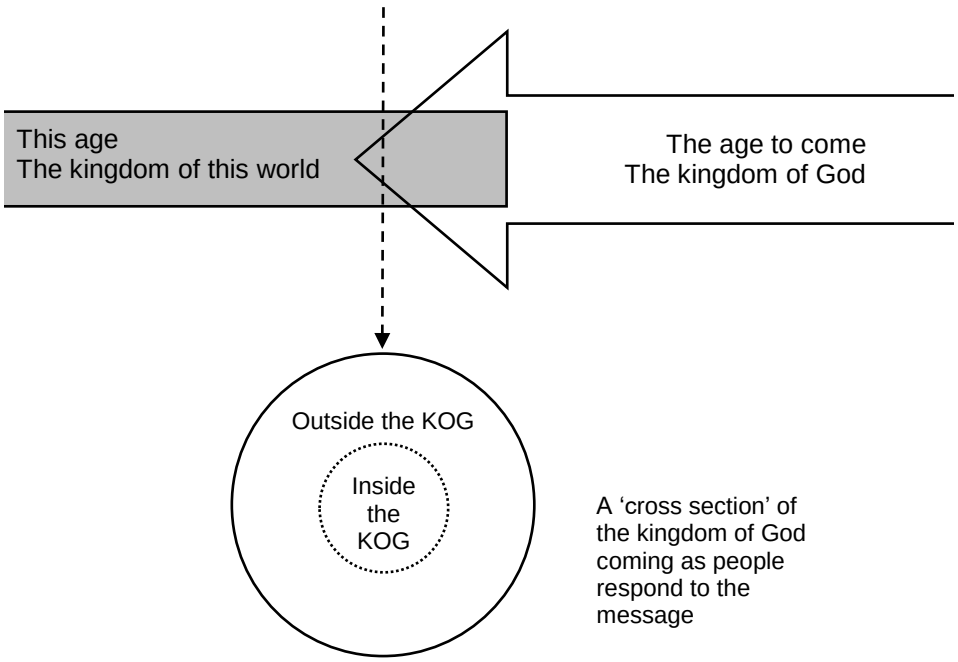
2. Are there teaching and learning tools in your culture that are like parables? If there are, what are they called? Can you share some examples of these cultural, parable-like stories and what they mean with the group?
This is an interesting and fun activity that helps participants appreciate the parables and their own stories and riddles. In Uganda, for example, there are stories or fables in which different animal characters are used to teach local truths in the various cultures: whether it is through rabbits in the north, tortoises in the east, or snakes in the south. You might want to go on and ask the group how these stories work.

3. What, in your opinion, is the main thing that Mark 4:1-20 teaches?
Mark 4:1-20 is all about proclaiming and hearing the word of God, the gospel of the kingdom. The various sections support that: vv. 1-2 are all about teaching (repeated three times); v. 3 begins with a loud "Listen!" and is about the scattering of seed, the

word of God; v. 9 reinforces this: "He who has ears to hear, let him hear"; the central verses, vv. 10-12 are again about hearing and understanding; vv. 13-20 are to help the disciples themselves hear and understand; vv. 21-25 reinforce this. And it is clear that the whole passage is about the central place of parables in this teaching and in Jesus' teaching generally (look at v. 2 and vv. 33-34). Finally, v. 13 suggests that this parable is a key to understanding all parables: it is a 'parable about parables'.

4. What do we learn about the kingdom of God in Mark 4:1-20?
Membership of the kingdom is not automatic: there are those on the inside and those on the outside. Jesus makes it clear that the message of the kingdom, the gospel, divides. He also points to the fact that the kingdom grows as the message is proclaimed and people respond. While God is the sovereign king of the kingdom and determines who is in and who is out, people are responsible and are called to listen and respond. To underline this, you can ask: "How many types of soil are there in the parable?" Most participants say the obvious "four types", but one or two often take this further and say that there are really only "two kinds": there are fruitful and unfruitful soils – the message divides humanity in two – those who respond and obey and those who remain in rebellion.

The diagram below is a development of the picture of the coming kingdom in Unit 3. It is a 'slice' through the diagram which shows that there are those coming into the kingdom and those left on the outside.



5. What do you think Jesus is saying about all parables?
All parables are: (1) set in the context of the kingdom of God; (2) teach about the kingdom; (3) call for a response; (4) confirm whether people are responsive to the good news or not, and therefore divide people; (5) bring in the kingdom because they are vehicle for the message of the kingdom.

If you are moving more slowly through the materials you can reinforce the connections with Isaiah that we have already made. Jesus quotes from Isaiah 6:9-10, which

underlines the hardness and unresponsiveness of human hearts that the preaching of the word reveals.

Isaiah 40:8 speaks of the enduring nature of the message in the context of withering plants – very similar images to those in the parable: "The grass withers and the flowers fall, but the word of our God endures forever".

Isaiah 55:10-13, which is part of the end of exile and new exodus section of Isaiah that is so important to Mark, speaks of the sovereign power of God's message: "It will not return to me empty, but will accomplish what I desire and achieve the purpose for which I sent it."

4.2 GUIDELINES FOR UNDERSTANDING PARABLES

Our introduction to the parables has begun to help us to understand them. We will now take that further with some guidelines to help us.

Parables are not …

- Unique to Jesus (see 2 Samuel 12:1-10 for example).
- Of just one kind.
- Pure 'allegories' – stories where every detail stands for something and must be decoded.
- Open to lots of different interpretations and meanings.

Parables are …

- Jesus' unique way of preaching his message of the kingdom. All the evidence suggests that parables were central to Jesus' teaching and that he used them far more than anyone else.

  They are therefore preaching tools – designed to get a response and to have an impact. They are divisive, surprising, offensive and gripping.

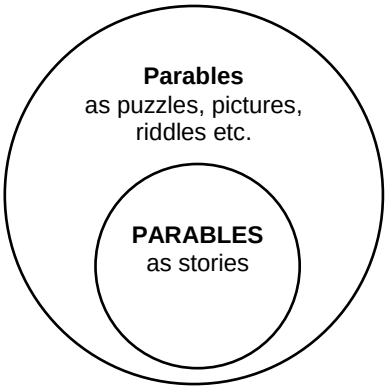
  They are part of Jesus' ministry of bringing in the kingdom – seed that is planted and grows in fertile soil. In other words, they deliver the word of God about the kingdom of God and bring in that kingdom as people respond in repentance and faith.

- Varied. Jesus taught in his mother-tongue language, Aramaic, and the Aramaic word *'methal'*, which is translated *'parabole'* in the Greek, can include a variety of figures of speech (see Fee and Stuart). Some are pure stories but many are pictures, puzzles and riddles. For example, a number are illustrations and begin with the words, "the kingdom of God is like..."

  In other words, 'parables' can mean the broader group of pictures and puzzles or just those pure stories. Your 'favourite' parables are probably pure stories such as the Lost Sheep, the Prodigal Son, or the Good Samaritan. The Parable of the

Wicked Tenants, in Mark 12:1-12, which we will look at later, is the only parable of this type in Mark.

Understanding parables: people use both a broader definition and a narrower one; there are a variety of **parables** including 'pure' **PARABLES** that are stories.



- Some seem to be allegories, but there are no secret codes. Instead the following will help you to unlock the meaning: the themes and structure of the gospel they are set in; Jesus' own teaching about the kingdom of God; and the Old Testament background. For many parables the immediate context is given by the evangelist.

- They are teaching tools – they are not designed to hide the meaning but to help people to discover the meaning for themselves.

  They are Jesus' way of teaching the true picture of the kingdom of God in a context where there were different understandings and expectations.

  And they are situational rather than general – they are told by Jesus in a specific setting, which is often mentioned, and have a particular meaning and purpose.

4.3 STEPS FOR UNDERSTANDING PARABLES

With that background and guidance, here are some steps to follow. To understand parables, we simply adapt and follow the BUILD model of understanding the Bible and these four steps:

1. Establish the CONTEXT
2. Discover the CONTENT
3. Make the CONNECTIONS
4. Teach the CONTENT

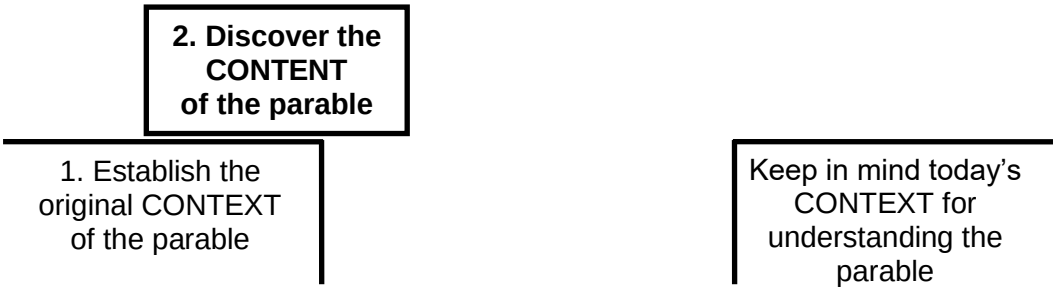
4.3.1 Establish the CONTEXT

Set the parable in context, whether the evangelist gives the immediate context or not. In other words, as we learnt above, remember the context of the gospel itself (its themes and structure – including Jesus' situation and his teaching about the kingdom), and the context of the Old Testament – look for Old Testament references and links.

As you do this, begin to make links with today's context in which the parable needs to be understood.

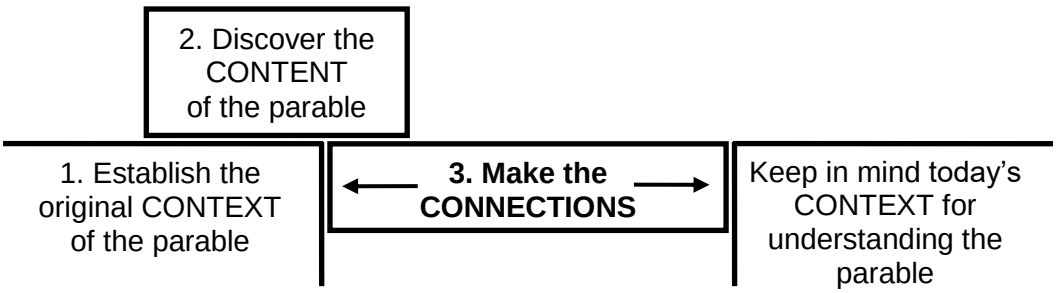
4.3.2 Discover the CONTENT

The main point of the parable needs to be understood. The details are not the messages of the parable, instead they support the main MESSAGE. As you look at the details look for the heart and brain of the parable.



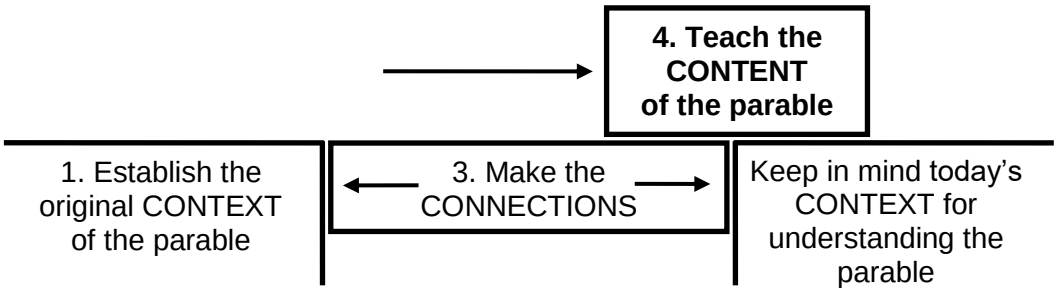
4.3.3 Make the CONNECTIONS

This is **particularly important** with the parables. Note the points of connection with the original listeners and then extend those to build the other half of the bridge, as you identify the points of connection with your listeners today.



4.3.4 Teach the CONTENT

Allow people to see the connections themselves and teach the parable as Jesus taught it: so that people can come to their own conclusions. Jesus taught them in order to evoke a response, we must do the same.



4.4 AN EXAMPLE OF ENCOUNTERING A PARABLE – LUKE 7:41-42

Luke 7:41-42 has been chosen rather than a text from Mark because it is a brief story parable with a clear context that the evangelist gives. Fee and Stuart give an excellent explanation of it, which this draws on.

4.4.1 Establish the CONTEXT

The parable itself is very short:

> "Two men owed money to a certain money-lender. One owed him five hundred denarii, and the other fifty. Neither of them had the money to pay him back, so he cancelled the debts of both. Now which of them will love him more?"

But it is set in the immediate context of Luke 7:36-50, which is set in the wider context of Luke and his presentation of Jesus and the kingdom of God, and also in the OT context, as already discussed.

For example, Luke 7:36-40 sets the scene with Jesus being invited to Simon the Pharisee's house. A prostitute, who Jesus has shown the grace of God's kingdom to, comes in and causes a scandal. Simon is disgusted and reacts with disgusting self-righteousness: "this woman Jesus accepts is unacceptable; Jesus cannot really be God's messenger".

And all this is in the context of Luke's teaching on God's salvation and kingdom: a kingdom that fulfils all the Old Testament hopes. Luke 4:17-21 and Jesus' reading of Isaiah 61:1-2 gives not only Luke's presentation of that coming kingdom but also establishes its Old Testament roots.

Remember, it is also important to keep in mind your CONTEXT. The '?' in the diagram below means you need to keep thinking about this.

Ask the participants if they can begin to see any links with us and our reactions today. It is not hard to see the way we too react to social outcasts, and the way other churches and their leaders do – just like this Pharisee. But more on that in a moment.

1. CONTEXT
The kingdom; Forgiven 'sinner'; Self-righteous Pharisee.

Today's CONTEXT
?

4.4.2 Discover the CONTENT

We have begun to see the content. What is the main point that Jesus, and therefore Luke, is making? What message did it contain in that original setting? It is a surprising message of unexpected grace and judgement – grace for the woman (v. 50), judgement on Simon (vv. 44-47).

2. CONTENT
Grace and judgment

1. CONTEXT
The kingdom; Forgiven 'sinner'; Self-righteous Pharisee.

Today's CONTEXT
?

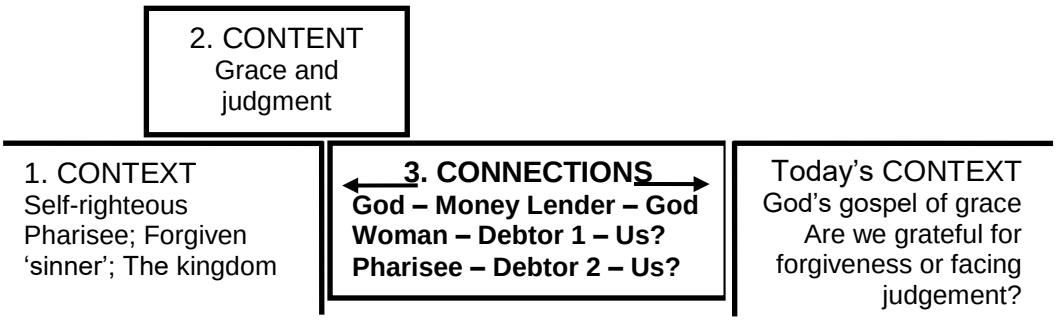
4.4.3 Make the CONNECTIONS with our situation today

The connections are especially important for the parables. We need to establish who Jesus is pointing to through the story. There are three clear points of connection for the original listeners:

- The money lender – who represents God
- The first debtor – who represents the prostitute
- The second debtor – who represents the Pharisee

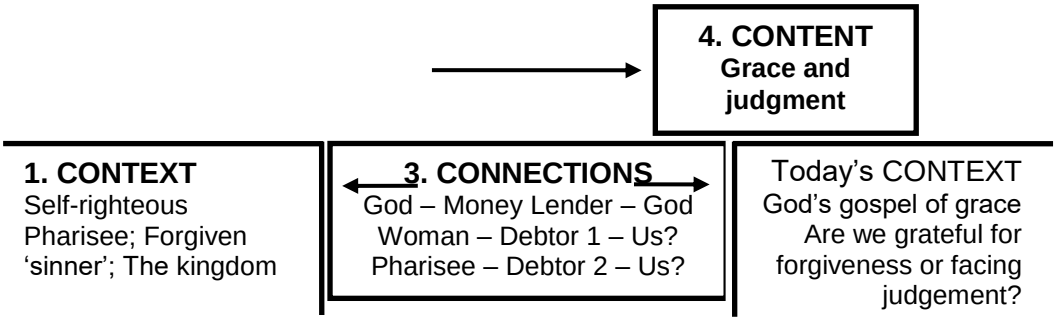
Jesus makes his point by getting Simon to see that the truth is the opposite of his view of things: he is the one under God's judgement and that the woman is the one who has learnt to receive and give grace.

In extending those connections for today, we want to teach this in a way that allows people to see themselves as God sees them. What does that mean for us and our people?



4.4.4 Teach the CONTENT of the book today

Finally, we can teach the relevant CONTENT of the parable, using those connections between then and now. Do we recognise ourselves as the first debtor: so aware of their great need of forgiveness and full of gratitude for God's grace, just like the woman? Or, like the second debtor, Simon, are we so self-important that we are unaware of the extent of God's mercy and, instead, fall under his judgment?



4.5 CONCLUSION

Parables are a unique type of teaching, set in the context of the gospels. But we still use the same process we have learnt in order to understand them. We need to establish the context; discover the content; make the connections; and teach that content.

And we will follow that process in more detail in the next unit as we look at Mark 4:26-33 using the steps of How to Understand a Bible Passage from Unit 2. But we will need to adapt those steps still further. We have seen how they applied to the gospels in general, its teaching and its stories, we now need to think about how they apply to *a parable* within a gospel.

Unit 5. Mark 4:26-33 (Encounter)

Overview

Every module has a number of opportunities for you to be coached in your ability to handle the Bible. This unit applies the lessons of Unit 2 and insights from Units 3 and 4 to Mark 4:26-33.

Outline

- Introduction
- Worksheet for the passage
- Worksheet for Step 1
- Worksheet for Steps 2 to 4
- Preaching Mark 4:26-33

Outcomes

At the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Follow and apply the four steps of Encountering a Bible passage to a passage from Mark yourself
2. Share the message of Mark 4:26-33 with a group of people today

This unit applies the skills that Participants were introduced to in Unit 2. But you also need to help them to apply some of their learning from units 3 and 4: the central theme of the kingdom of God and the parables that teach about Jesus and his kingdom.

Give the Participants an opportunity to apply the steps themselves, individually or in groups. You might want to take the whole group, interactively, through one or more stages in order to vary the approach.

Or you might vary the group sizes. For example, they could 'see the details' individually, 'seek the meaning' in groups and 'summarise the findings' with your help as the whole group.

5.1 INTRODUCTION

In this unit you will apply the lessons of Unit 2 to another passage from Mark's gospel, 4:26-33. But we have travelled quite a distance since then. Units 3 and 4 have built on that. First, we explored the central theme of the kingdom of God, and then we looked at the parables, which teach about Jesus and his kingdom. You need to look at Mark 4:26-33 in the light of all that learning.

Spend time reflecting on the text on the next page. If you are working in a group you might want to take it in turns reading it out loud between each step. Listen for and look for different things each time it is read out. Use a notepad to write the passage out and record observations and work on these before marking the text in this work book, which you will want to keep for reference. You may want to wait until your Trainer marks up a passage before recording it in this book. Use the worksheets on the pages that follow the text in a similar way.

5.2 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING MARK 4:26-33 (THE PASSAGE)

26 He also said, ‘This is what the
kingdom of God is like. A man scatters
seed on the ground. **27** Night and day,
whether he sleeps or gets up, the seed
sprouts and grows, though he does not
know how. **28** All by itself the soil produces
corn – first the stalk, then the ear, then the
full grain in the ear. **29** As soon as the corn
is ripe, he puts the sickle to it, because the
harvest has come.’

30 Again he said, ‘What shall we say the
kingdom of God is like, or what parable
shall we use to describe it? **31** It is like a
mustard seed, which is the smallest of all
seeds on earth. **32** Yet when planted, it
grows and becomes the largest of all
garden plants, with such big branches that
the birds can perch in its shade.’

33 With many similar parables Jesus
spoke the word to them, as much as they
could understand. (NIV)

5.3 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING MARK 4:26-33 – STEP 1

STEP 1: FLESH – study the DETAILS of the text	
a) Set the passage in context. How does the passage relate to the book as a whole?	
b) See the details of the text. List important words, phrases, and relationships:	**c) Seek the meaning from the details** Explain important words, phrases, and relationships:
d) Summarise the findings. What are the main ideas that come out of this initial study?	

5.4 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING MARK 4:26-33 – STEPS 2 TO 4

STEP 2: SKELETON – outline the STRUCTURE of the text **a) Note all the bones in the structure.** What elements highlight the structure?
b) Decide on the 'big bones' and make an outline of the structure. What are the most important parts of the structure? Can you describe the main sections?
STEP 3: HEART – identify the MESSAGE of the text **a) State the theme of the passage.** What is the author's main point?
b) Explain the message of the passage. What is the author saying about his theme?
STEP 4: BRAIN – first, understand the PURPOSE of the text... **a) State the purpose of the passage.** Why is the author making his point?
b) Make connections for teaching today. What is the relevance of this for us?

5.5 PREACHING MARK 4:26-33

In order to consider how to preach this passage we will first respond to the message at a more personal level, picking up on the discoveries we have already made. We will then use the table on the next page to capture some key ideas for a sermon or talk.

5.5.1 Responding to the message of Mark 4:26-33

Here are three simple exercises to do in response to God's word to us in the passage we have just encountered:

1. Describe how the message you discovered in the passage spoke to you personally: What did you learn or need to be reminded of?

2. Share how the purpose of the passage helped you to apply God's word to your life: What change will this passage make to your thinking and living?

3. State and explain the message you will share with others using your own words: What is the main thing you want people to understand?

5.5.2 Preaching the message of Mark 4:26-33

Use the table below to outline some of the key ideas in your sermon or talk:

STEP 4: BRAIN – state the PURPOSE of the sermon My sermon's purpose statement:
STEP 5: HEART – form the MESSAGE of the sermon My sermon's theme and its message statement:
STEP 6: SKELETON – create the STRUCTURE of the sermon My sermon's outline (with the main points, introduction and conclusion):
STEP 7: FLESH – develop the DETAILS of the sermon My sermon's details (note here key words, explanations, illustrations and applications that will help you write notes or a full sermon):

Unit 6. Proclaiming the kingdom of God (Action)

Overview

Jesus sent out the twelve to announce the arrival of God's new world: "Calling the Twelve to him, he began to send them out two by two and gave them authority over impure spirits" (Mark 6:7). This unit helps us to consider and plan ways of advertising the gospel, the good news of God's rule in Christ, in our local communities.

Outline

- Introduction: What have we learnt so far?
- Encounter: The proclamation of God's kingship in Mark
- Reflection: Words and deeds and sharing the gospel
- Action: Planning new ways of doing mission

Outcomes

At the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Describe the mission of the twelve and how it applies today
2. Explain why the proclamation of the gospel involves both words and actions
3. Identify an intervention in your local community that will act as an advertisement for the gospel: the good news of God's rule

6.1 INTRODUCTION

6.1.1 What have we learnt so far?

- We have already talked about sharing the gospel in our two earlier modules. Think back to what we learnt in Module One (unit 6) about sharing the good news. What do you remember from that unit?

- Now think back to unit 6 of Module Two, where we learnt about stewardship and how local initiatives can promote the gospel in our communities.

- Finally, consider the lessons we have learnt about God's kingship in this module and what that tells us about God's new world and our part in it. How might we proclaim this good news of God's rule in Jesus Christ to those around us?

6.1.2 A BUILD story of kingdom shaped proclamation

The story below is a true story, which came about as a result of a BUILD workshop close to Kampala. Read through the story and think about how God's present reign might be shared with others.

> "David (not his real name) was a little boy with a big frown. He could hardly walk because his legs had been crooked from birth. In his home area in the north of Uganda, this also meant he was an outcast. His parents were too ashamed to send him to school where he would have been mocked, and the rumours in the community were that his parents were cursed. A local MP told his grandfather, Benjamin (not his real name), a pastor in the Church of Uganda, that he might be able to help. But when Benjamin took David to the MP's office in Kampala there was no sign of the MP and the office told them to go away. So, Benjamin brought David with him to the BUILD training workshop he was on his way to.
>
> "Benjamin explained the situation to everyone at the workshop and they gathered around and prayed for David and the family. After they prayed, one person there said that he knew of a doctor, a Christian, who had opened an orthopaedic hospital for children. The doctor agreed to see David and said that he hoped the hospital could help. Over the course of time BUILD leaders helped organise visits to the hospital for David. After a series of operations, which were surrounded by much prayer from the Church of Uganda's own prayer network and great bravery on David's part his legs are now straight. It looks as though a complete miracle has happened, which of course it has.
>
> "David returned to a BUILD workshop a year later with his grandfather so that they could bring a letter of thanks from the parents and share the story with the whole group. David has gone from being a little boy with a frown to one who is constantly smiling and who can now walk and run for the first time. He has now started primary education and the family are no longer ashamed or viewed as under a curse locally – in fact, quite the reverse: many have started attending church in the local area as they are all talking about what God has done for David and the family and how he has lifted the curse and brought such transformation."

- How does this story illustrate the nature of God's kingdom?

- What does the story tell us about the way in which the good news of the kingship of God can be shared with those around us?

6.2 ENCOUNTER: THE PROCLAMATION OF GOD'S KINGSHIP IN MARK

Although this is an 'action' unit we have already learnt that any action that is genuinely Christian is rooted in reflection. That reflection involves an **encounter** with something, **reflection** to gain wisdom before taking **action**. The summary table is below:

Step and description	Definition of key word	Activity	Outcome
To **encounter** something in God's world and/or God's word with a desire for wisdom.	**'Encounter':** To meet something new and surprising	Describe	Discoveries
To **reflect** on those situations and the Scriptures in order to gain wisdom.	**'Reflect':** To pause for thought and go deeper	Consider	Principles
To take **action** in God's world with the wisdom that comes from God's word.	**'Action':** To do something new or in a different way.	Plan	Practice

Therefore, we will begin by encountering the proclamation of God's kingship in Mark's gospel.

6.2.1 Jesus and the proclamation of God's kingship

In Mark 1:14-15 we read this:

> "Jesus went into Galilee, proclaiming the good news of God. 'The time has come,' he said. 'The kingdom of God has come near. Repent and believe the good news!'"

Jesus understands that his work is all about the proclamation of God's kingship, which demands a response from people.

Remember, the very first verses of Mark tell us that Jesus' work is not only about proclaiming the good news of God's kingship, but that he is the one who is establishing it and implementing it. Look back to Mark 1:1:

> "The beginning of the good news about Jesus the Messiah, the Son of God"

That verse is packed with meaning. Mark tells us that the good news, the gospel, is all about Jesus.

Jesus, means 'YHWH saves', and this saviour is none other than God's own Messiah, his kingly ruler who has come to put things right.

Mark builds on this by making it clear that this Saviour and Messiah is none other than God's own Son.

Even more dramatically, Mark 1:3 tells us that Jesus, the Messiah, the Son of God is none other than the Lord himself, in person, coming to rescue and release and restore his people. It is the quotation of Isaiah 40:3 that tells us that the Lord is coming.

The gospel could not be more exciting: here, underlined by the use of Malachi 3:1 in Mark 1:2, is the Lord himself coming to rule his world. Jesus is announcing the world changing news that he is being enthroned as the ruler of the whole earth!

6.2.2 God's people and the proclamation of God's kingship

Jesus shows that God's new, or renewed, people will be central to his strategy of announcing, establishing and implementing his kingly rule.

In 3:14-15 he shows that this is his plan and he begins to set it in motion: "He appointed twelve that they might be with him and that he might send them out to preach and to have authority to drive out demons."

From 3:20 to 6:6 they are "with him" that first purpose for the selection of the twelve. But in 6:7 Jesus prepares to "send them out", that second purpose.

Read Mark 6:6-13 out loud and then look closely at the passage and discuss the questions below:

- How does the mission of the twelve relate to Jesus' own mission?

- What do these verses tell us about the ways in which the good news of God's kingship is to be announced?

- Jesus gives them a single command, "authority over impure spirits" but this then has a wider application in verses 12 and 13. Given the nature of God's kingship that is becoming a reality in Christ's enthronement and the situation of the world he is coming to claim, why do you think this command is so important? And why might it lie at the root of a wider application?

- Mark 6:30 tells us this: "The apostles gathered round Jesus and reported to him all they had done and taught." Does this simple verse reinforce your ideas or change them in some way?

- What do you think all this has to tell us about how we should carry out Jesus' mission today?

6.3 REFLECTION: WORDS AND DEEDS AND SHARING THE GOSPEL

Do you remember the three ways of sharing the gospel that we learnt about in Module One? First, we can share our testimony. Second, we can explain the message. Third, we can demonstrate the change the gospel makes.

As a result, we began to discuss the difference the gospel makes in our lives. In the language of the Pastoral Epistles transformed lives are an important way of making "the teaching about God our Saviour attractive" (Titus 2:10).

We have seen that Jesus, in Mark's gospel, is the one who first established this pattern, which Paul picks up: "The apostles gathered round Jesus and reported to him *all they had done and taught*." We will now take this idea further and think together about how we can use both words and deeds to proclaim the gospel.

6.3.1 God's rule, God's love and God's justice

In Module One we also learnt about three reasons for sharing the gospel: God's rule, God's love and God's justice. All three belong together, but God's rule, his kingdom, is the leading truth.

Many Christian thinkers believe there is a difference between the good news that Jesus proclaims, as recorded in the gospels, which talk a great deal about the kingdom of God, and the good news that Paul and the Apostles proclaim, as recorded in the letters, which they say talk more about the various truths or doctrines that are central to the gospel. But we are already beginning to see that that is simply not true. God's kingdom or kingship or rule is central to the entire New Testament, indeed to the whole of the Bible.

In Module One we saw that the gospel is based on the fact that God is in charge of the world – he is the one who has purposes, makes plans and is able to follow through on them. Paul repeatedly uses the phrase "our Lord" (2 Tim 1:8) when talking about Jesus. He and the other New Testament writers recognise that Jesus is God's ruler. And they regularly use 'kingdom' language. For example, Paul also commands Timothy to "preach the word" on the basis of Jesus' "appearing and his kingdom" (2 Tim 4:1).

We need to not only speak of God's rule but demonstrate it in our lives, families and churches. In other words, showing the relevance of the Christian message to all aspects of life creates a convincing context for talk of God's **rule**.

- Begin to talk and think about how our lives and families and churches can show that Jesus Christ is Lord. That he is in charge of the world and that his way of organising the world provides real hope and change for the good.

It is also important and helpful to remember those two other motives for sharing our faith: God's love and God's justice.

Jesus is a loving king. Therefore, loving actions provide an attractive setting for sharing the message of God's **love**. That will be part of showing what God's kingship looks like.

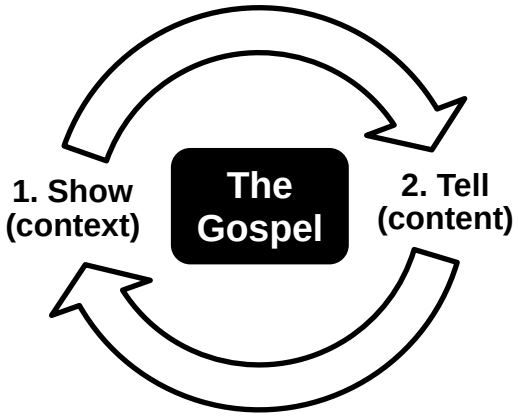
- Begin to discuss how you can build on your ideas of pointing to God's way of organising the world by thinking through what it means to demonstrate the love of God.

Jesus is a just king. Just actions give a strong background for the proclamation of God's **justice**, which is such an important part of the world God is establishing.

- Talk to others in the group about how you can add justice into the way in which you seek to show God's way of doing things.

6.3.2 The two-way relationship between telling and showing the gospel

Taking the reflection a step further. What we are discovering is that there is a two-way relationship between telling and showing the gospel. We need to keep both of these aspects together:



1. Show and tell
When we demonstrate something of the impact of the gospel on our lives and reach out in love and care to other people, it raises questions in their minds and gives us opportunities to explain the gospel, to proclaim the hope that we have.

> "Always be prepared to give an answer to everyone who asks you to give the reason for the hope that you have" (1 Peter 3:15).

2. Tell and show
When we tell people the gospel it must be done in the setting of the relevance and impact of the good news on our lives, family, church and community.

> "Dear children, let us not love with words or speech but with actions and in truth" (I John 3:18).

In other words, the **content** of the message we tell must be consistent with the **context** we create for the message as we live lives of love.

6.3.3 Proclaiming the kingdom through 'holistic mission'

This understanding of mission is often called 'holistic mission' or 'integral mission'. Christian thinkers use these terms to describe what mission should be because mission is sometimes reduced to words alone or to social action alone.

A picture: Wholemeal flour makes healthy, wholemeal bread. Wholemeal flour is unrefined, it is flour with nothing taken out – it still has all the goodness that your body needs. White, refined flour, stores better but much of the nutrition has been removed. Holistic or integral mission is like wholemeal bread – it has everything in it for effective evangelism, all the essential ingredients God intended it to have.

- Think about some of the mission work you have seen or have been involved in. Have all the ingredients for telling the good news of God's kingship been included in these efforts? What has been included and left out?

6.3.4 Listing some principles for kingdom shaped mission

- In your group use the table below to list some principles for holistic mission or what we could call 'kingdom shaped mission': mission that gives people a taste of what God's rule of the world looks like in practice.

Mission principle	The principle described
1.	
2.	
3.	
4.	
5.	

You can share these with the larger group if you are breaking into smaller groups. Sharing them will help you to sharpen and improve them.

6.4 ACTION: PLANNING NEW WAYS OF DOING MISSION

As with other themes in BUILD, we are building our thinking in an area, in this case that of holistic mission or what we are beginning to call ‘kingdom shaped mission’.

Module One sowed some seeds in this area. Module Two picked up the theme in relation to stewardship. Module Four will look in more detail at strategic planning. And Module Five builds on our understanding of mission. The other modules will contribute to our understanding and practice, including Module Nine, which will look at the breadth of mission as well as what makes mission Christian.

Here we are simply interested in beginning to develop a vision for holistic, word and deed mission that will bring the good news of God’s kingship to your local community through your local church, inspired by Jesus and the Twelve.

- Share some of the initiatives you have seen in action that have been faithful to the principles you have outlined and worked on.

- Identifying and describe an intervention in your local community that will act as an advertisement for the gospel: the good news of God’s kingly rule in Christ.

- Commit these plans to God in prayer.

Unit 7. Matthew 5:1-12 (Encounter)

This unit applies the lessons of Unit 2 to Matthew 5:1-12. Refer back to previous 'Encountering the Bible' units for learning outline and outcomes.

As with previous units that encounter Bible passages, give the participants an opportunity to apply the steps for themselves and help them with the process. The worksheets have been completed to help you.

7.1 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING MATTHEW 5:1-12 (THE PASSAGE)

In order to fit the whole passage on one page it is shown on the next sheet.

Use the space below for some initial comments as you **set the passage in context**. In other words, how does the passage relate to the book as a whole?

This is an opportunity to at Matthew's own account of the good news and how it compares with Mark's.

5 Now when Jesus saw the crowds, he
went up on a mountainside and sat down.
His disciples came to him, **2** and he began
to teach them.

He said:

3 ‘Blessed are the poor in spirit,
for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.
4 Blessed are those who mourn,
for they will be comforted.
5 Blessed are the meek,
for they will inherit the earth.
6 Blessed are those who hunger and thirst
for righteousness,
for they will be filled.
7 Blessed are the merciful,
for they will be shown mercy.
8 Blessed are the pure in heart,
for they will see God.
9 Blessed are the peacemakers,
for they will be called children of God.
10 Blessed are those who are persecuted
because of righteousness,
for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.

11 ‘Blessed are you when people insult
you, persecute you and falsely say all kinds
of evil against you because of
me. **12** Rejoice and be glad, because great
is your reward in heaven, for in the same
way they persecuted the prophets who
were before you. (NIV)

7.2 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING MATTHEW 5:1-12 – STEP 1

STEP 1: FLESH – study the DETAILS of the text	
a) Set the passage in context. How does the passage relate to the book as a whole?	
b) See the details of the text. List important words, phrases, and relationships:	**c) Seek the meaning from the details** Explain important words, phrases, and relationships:
d) Summarise the findings. What are the main ideas that come out of this initial study?	

7.3 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING MATTHEW 5:1-12 – STEPS 2 TO 4

STEP 2: SKELETON – outline the STRUCTURE of the text **a) Note all the bones in the structure.** What elements highlight the structure?
b) Decide on the 'big bones' and make an outline of the structure. What are the most important parts of the structure? Can you describe the main sections?
STEP 3: HEART – identify the MESSAGE of the text **a) State the theme of the passage.** What is the author's main point?
b) Explain the message of the passage. What is the author saying about his theme?
STEP 4: BRAIN – first, understand the PURPOSE of the text... **a) State the purpose of the passage.** Why is the author making his point?
b) Make connections for teaching today. What is the relevance of this for us?

7.4 PREACHING MATTHEW 5:1-12

In order to consider how to preach this passage we will first respond to the message at a more personal level, picking up on the discoveries we have already made. We will then use the table on the next page to capture some key ideas for a sermon or talk.

7.4.1 Responding to the message of Matthew 5:1-12

Here are three simple exercises to do in response to God's word to us in the passage we have just encountered:

1. Describe how the message you discovered in the passage spoke to you personally: What did you learn or need to be reminded of?

2. Share how the purpose of the passage helped you to apply God's word to your life: What change will this passage make to your thinking and living?

3. State and explain the message you will share with others using your own words: What is the main thing you want people to understand?

7.4.2 Preaching the message of Matthew 5:1-12

Use the table below to outline some of the key ideas in your sermon or talk:

STEP 4: BRAIN – state the PURPOSE of the sermon My sermon's purpose statement:
STEP 5: HEART – form the MESSAGE of the sermon My sermon's theme and its message statement:
STEP 6: SKELETON – create the STRUCTURE of the sermon My sermon's outline (with the main points, introduction and conclusion):
STEP 7: FLESH – develop the DETAILS of the sermon My sermon's details (note here key words, explanations, illustrations and applications that will help you write notes or a full sermon):

Unit 8. Poverty and prosperity (Reflection)

Overview

The gospels, and particularly Luke's Gospel, have much to say about poverty and riches, which remain important issues in our communities today. This unit considers different aspects of poverty before looking at Luke's teaching. Finally, it helps us to take action as agents of the king, proclaiming the good news of the kingdom as Jesus' hands and feet in our churches and communities.

Outline

- Introduction
- An encounter with poverty and prosperity in Luke
- A reflection on poverty and prosperity in Luke
- Taking action: proclaiming good news to the poor
- Conclusion: "give me neither poverty nor riches"

Outcomes

At the end of the unit you will be able to

1. List the factors in your local community that create and sustain poverty
2. Define poverty using key ideas from the Bible
3. Explain some of the dangers of wealth, as Luke sees them
4. Write a vision statement for your community, which your church can help to make a reality as an agent of Christ the King

8.1 INTRODUCTION

In Matthew 5:3-10 we saw that Jesus begins The Sermon on the Mount with the values that are to shape and be held by his new people. We noticed that those verses are framed by the phrase "the kingdom of heaven", which is Matthew's way of talking about God's kingship. That picture frame reinforces the fact that The Beatitudes are about the character and characteristics of the agents of God's kingdom, his people who extend his rule in his world in the light of his world to come.

Those verses begin with the words, "Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven." We discussed what that meant: God's people recognise their own spiritual poverty and bankruptcy, which leads to their longing for God's kingdom to become a reality. God's true people welcome God's reign.

But does that mean Jesus is only addressing *spiritual* poverty? What about the causes and consequences of poverty that are the daily experience of so many people on the African continent?

Begin this unit of reflection on poverty and prosperity by discussing some or all of these issues and questions:

- Share experiences of poverty, whether your own experiences or those of others you know. What are the related issues and feelings that poverty brings with it?

- Describe the different attitudes to poverty and prosperity that you encounter among Christians and in churches in your local area.

- People talk about 'the poverty trap'. What do they mean by that? Can you list the different factors that create and sustain poverty? How do they relate to each other?

- On the other hand, wealth can bring its own problems and difficulties. Are you aware of any of those from what you see in your locality or nation as a whole?

- Have you encountered 'the prosperity gospel'? What do you think people mean by that phrase and what are its effects on Christian ministry in your area? Can you comment on its popularity and the reasons for that?

This unit looks at the issues surrounding poverty and prosperity, especially from the viewpoint of Luke and his gospel.

The unit does not aim to provide neat answers or to tackle issues of poverty and development. The next module, Module Four (Nehemiah and the Historical Books: Building God's People and Strategic Leadership), builds on some of the issues in a unit entitled 'Poverty and development'. That unit takes some of the learning in this module on 'Proclaiming the kingdom of God' and 'Poverty and prosperity' and looks at how churches can act as agents of the kingdom. And we will look at finances in Module Eight, when we look at Proverbs and the wisdom material, which has such helpful insights.

8.2 AN ENCOUNTER WITH POVERTY AND PROSPERITY IN LUKE

Luke has a particular interest in both poverty and prosperity, including the 'problem' of wealth. That emphasis on the dangers of wealth might be because of his audience: 'Theophilus' and others in his mould may well have been wealthy and they lived in a deeply divided society in which an elite, rich minority lorded it over a large poor majority.

In order to compare Matthew's perspective with that of Luke, read Matthew 5:1-12 again out loud, followed by Luke 6:17-26:

- Do you think Jesus has a different understanding of poverty in mind in the sermon. Luke records a summary of "on a level place" to the one Matthew includes "on a mountainside"? How are these two types or aspects of poverty linked?

- If we take the phrase "Blessed are you who are poor" as an introductory one for verses 20-22, how do the ideas that follow fill out the meaning of poverty in Jesus' thinking? What other issues does Jesus see as being linked to poverty?

- How do these ideas contrast with his understanding of those "who are rich" and what are the 'problems' associated with wealth? Where in Luke does he raise these issues?

8.3 A REFLECTION ON POVERTY AND PROSPERITY IN LUKE

8.3.1 "Good news to the poor": Poverty in Luke

In Unit 11 we will look at a passage from Luke's Gospel and the book as a whole to set it in context. But it is clear from the beginning of Luke that poverty is an important theme to the writer and that it was a central concern of Jesus'.

Simply looking at an English translation shows that the word 'poor' occurs more times in Luke than in the other gospels. Have a look at these verses and the ones around them: Luke 4:18, 6:20, 7:22, 11:41, 12:33, 14:13, 14:21, 18:22, 19:8 and 21:2-4.

- What new ideas do you notice in these verses.

That first direct mention of the poor comes in 4:18: Jesus' announcement that he is fulfilling or implementing God's reign following God's agenda for that reign. It is an agenda that is taken from the book of Isaiah:

> 'The Spirit of the Lord is on me,
> because he has anointed me
> to proclaim good news to the poor.
> He has sent me to proclaim freedom for the prisoners
> and recovery of sight for the blind,
> to set the oppressed free,
> to proclaim the year of the Lord's favour.' (Luke 4:18-19 from Isaiah 61:1-2)

We will look at this passage again in more detail in Module Nine, but it is an important text when it comes to looking at what Jesus and Luke mean by 'poor'. Consider these points:

First, it is an Old Testament passage. Within the Old Testament the 'poor' of the Psalms are not mainly pictured as physically poor but as those who trust in God in the face of all the difficulties they experience, and God is on their side: their poverty is a pathway to receiving protection from the Lord. For example, look at Psalm 14:6, 22:26, 34:6 and 35:10.

Second, it is a passage that lies at the heart of the Old Testament message. Remember back to the BUILD stages in the salvation element of the Bible's story (in 1.3.1). Salvation is **promised** and then **pictured** and then **prophesied** and then **proclaimed**. Isaiah is rooted in those promises and that picture of Israel and then prophesies God's future for his people, which will be proclaimed one day. Jesus is the ultimate one whose task is "to **proclaim** the year of the Lord's favour". And that proclamation promises not only freedom but also transformation. Read on in Isaiah 61: in the rest of verse 2 we read of wrongs put right and of comfort for those who mourn (a reminder of Matthew 5:4). And then, perhaps even more amazingly still, verses 3-6 is a picture of those who are set free becoming the new people of God who will bring in his new world, one that includes a mission to all people, and real future prosperity. Have a close look at those verses.

Third, it is a passage in which 'poverty' is linked to a number of other issues. Just as we saw in Luke 6:20-22, poverty is linked to factors which create and sustain it. God will free his people from these things, from powerlessness, darkness and oppression.

Fourth, Jesus spoke these words as one who became poor. Jesus was from Nazareth and launched his work in Nazareth, an insignificant and obscure place. As Nathanael asked Philip "Nazareth! Can anything good come from there?" (John 1:46). For those with eyes to see it, the Old Testament looks forward to one who will become poor in order to bring the wealth of God's kingdom to others, one who will be excluded in order to include others. The gospels present this picture and Paul looks back to it and explains what was going on and why:

> "For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though he was rich, yet for your sake he became poor, so that you through his poverty might become rich." (2 Corinthians 8:9).

God's people now work as Jesus' representatives in bringing the wealth of the kingdom to others as God fills the hungry with good things (Luke 1:53). But what might that wealth look like?

8.3.2 "Woe to you who are rich": Prosperity in Luke

Before we take that question any further, we have already seen Luke's concern for the poor is set against the opportunities and challenges of wealth. Early on in his gospel he notes that:

> "[God] has filled the hungry with good things
> but has sent the rich away empty" (1:53).

Luke picks up that contrast and danger at various points. We have already seen the woes of Luke 6:24-26. Take a look at these passages together using the single question that follows each one:

- Luke 12:13-21: What choice does this parable present?

- Luke 16:1-15: How can we use money to love God?

- Luke 18:18-30: What promise is there for those who invest in God's agenda for the world?

8.4 TAKING ACTION: PROCLAIMING GOOD NEWS TO THE POOR

Luke takes these principles further in his second volume, Acts of the Apostles. Module Five looks at that book under the title: 'Acts and the New Testament Story: The Church in Mission and Missional Leadership'. Luke begins the sequel to his gospel with these words: "In my former book, Theophilus, I wrote about all that Jesus began to do and to

teach" (Acts 1:1), which suggests that his second volume is about all that Jesus continues to do and to teach. And as we have seen in the gospels Jesus continues to do his work and teach his word through his renewed people, the church, his "witnesses" as Luke emphasises throughout Acts, beginning in Acts 1:8.

And it is as his renewed people, his witnesses, his agents, who have been transformed by the reign of God through Jesus the Messiah, that his people implement that same reign in this world, in expectation of the next.

That new community is central to Luke as not only a place where both rich and poor meet and care for one another (Acts 2:42-47 and Acts 4:32-36), but as a people that then care for others (Acts 11:27-30).

- Can you describe what biblical prosperity might look like in your situation? Consider these elements: the relationships involved; the things that bring dignity to peoples' lives; the changes that would advertise the good news of the kingdom. You might want to consider the transformation that Zacchaeus and his community experienced (Luke 19:1-10).

8.5 CONCLUSION: "GIVE ME NEITHER POVERTY NOR RICHES"

Proverbs 30:7-9 not only reflects biblical balance on poverty and prosperity, it has a strong link forward to our next unit, in its request for 'daily bread'. Close this unit in prayer guided by these verses:

> Two things I ask of you, Lord;
> do not refuse me before I die:
> keep falsehood and lies far from me;
> give me neither poverty nor riches,
> but give me only my daily bread.
> Otherwise, I may have too much and disown you
> and say, "Who is the Lord?"
> Or I may become poor and steal,
> and so dishonour the name of my God.

Unit 9. Matthew 6:9-15 (Encounter)

This unit applies the lessons of Unit 2 to Matthew 6:9-15. Refer back to previous 'Encountering the Bible' units for learning outline and outcomes.

As with previous units that encounter Bible passages, give the participants an opportunity to apply the steps for themselves and help them with the process.

NOTE: Matthew 6:1-8 provides essential context for the short passage we will focus on. And vv. 16-18 applies the same principles and sheds light on our passage. Therefore, look consider vv. 1-18 as a whole when setting the text in context.

9.1 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING MATTHEW 6:9-15 (THE PASSAGE)

9 This, then, is how you should pray:

'"Our Father in heaven,
hallowed be your name,
10 your kingdom come,
your will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
11 Give us today our daily bread.
12 And forgive us our debts,
as we also have forgiven our debtors.
13 And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from the evil one."

14 For if you forgive other people when they
sin against you, your heavenly Father will
also forgive you. **15** But if you do not forgive
others their sins, your Father will not
forgive your sins. (NIV)

9.2 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING MATTHEW 6:9-15 – STEP 1

STEP 1: FLESH – study the DETAILS of the text	
a) Set the passage in context. How does the passage relate to the book as a whole?	
b) See the details of the text. List important words, phrases, and relationships:	**c) Seek the meaning from the details** Explain important words, phrases, and relationships:
d) Summarise the findings. What are the main ideas that come out of this initial study?	

9.3 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING MATTHEW 6:9-15 – STEPS 2 TO 4

STEP 2: SKELETON – outline the STRUCTURE of the text **a) Note all the bones in the structure.** What elements highlight the structure?
b) Decide on the 'big bones' and make an outline of the structure. What are the most important parts of the structure? Can you describe the main sections?
STEP 3: HEART – identify the MESSAGE of the text **a) State the theme of the passage.** What is the author's main point?
b) Explain the message of the passage. What is the author saying about his theme?
STEP 4: BRAIN – first, understand the PURPOSE of the text... **a) State the purpose of the passage.** Why is the author making his point?
b) Make connections for teaching today. What is the relevance of this for us?

9.4 PREACHING MATTHEW 6:9-15

In order to consider how to preach this passage we will first respond to the message at a more personal level, picking up on the discoveries we have already made. We will then use the table on the next page to capture some key ideas for a sermon or talk.

9.4.1 Responding to the message of Matthew 6:9-15

Here are three simple exercises to do in response to God's word to us in the passage we have just encountered:

1. Describe how the message you discovered in the passage spoke to you personally: What did you learn or need to be reminded of?

2. Share how the purpose of the passage helped you to apply God's word to your life: What change will this passage make to your thinking and living?

3. State and explain the message you will share with others using your own words: What is the main thing you want people to understand?

9.4.2 Preaching the message of Matthew 6:9-15

Use the table below to outline some of the key ideas in your sermon or talk:

STEP 4: BRAIN – state the PURPOSE of the sermon My sermon's purpose statement:
STEP 5: HEART – form the MESSAGE of the sermon My sermon's theme and its message statement:
STEP 6: SKELETON – create the STRUCTURE of the sermon My sermon's outline (with the main points, introduction and conclusion):
STEP 7: FLESH – develop the DETAILS of the sermon My sermon's details (note here key words, explanations, illustrations and applications that will help you write notes or a full sermon):

Unit 10. Praying for the kingdom of God (Action)

Overview

Proclaiming the good news of the Kingdom of God must go hand in hand with praying for it to come. The prayer Jesus taught us makes that a priority. This unit looks at the Lord's Prayer and how it can shape our lives and churches.

Outline

- Introduction: Praying for the Kingdom of God
- Encountering prayer for the Kingdom of God
- Reflection on prayer for the Kingdom of God
- Action on prayer for the Kingdom of God
- Conclusion: Praying with Christ in Gethsemane

Outcomes

At the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Explain how the prayer that Jesus taught can and must transform our own prayer.
2. Evaluate the prayer in our congregations in the light of the Lord's Prayer.
3. Make a plan for transforming the practice of prayer as a result of a proper understanding of the Lord's Prayer.

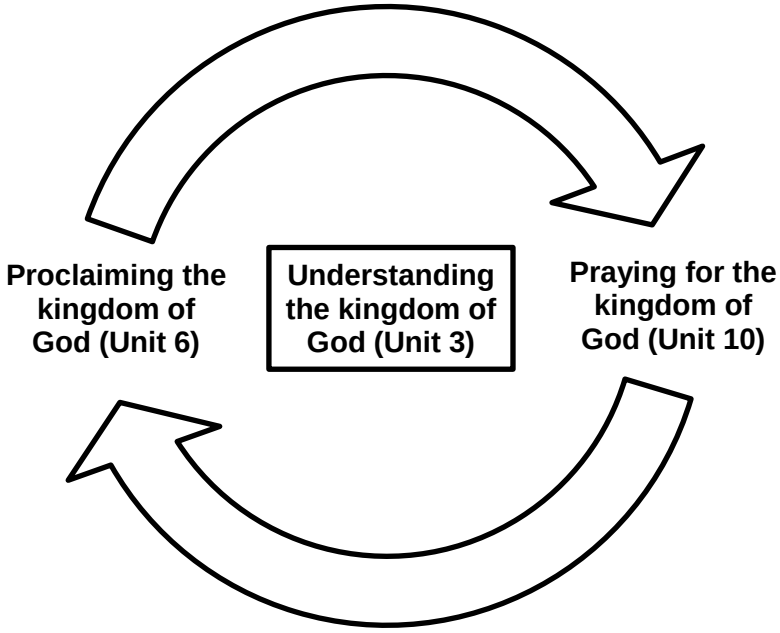
10.1 INTRODUCTION: PRAYING FOR THE KINGDOM OF GOD

The arrival of the kingdom of God is at the heart of the good news Jesus brings.

In Unit 3 we focussed on 'Understanding the kingdom of God'. God's heavenly ways coming into our earthly lives through Jesus' past intervention and the present mobilisation of his people as his revolutionary agents by his Holy Spirit: *"God's redemptive power released into history" (René Padilla).*

In Unit 6 we learnt about 'Proclaiming the kingdom of God'. Above everything else the kingdom is *God's* kingdom; it is about his rule and his work. He calls us to be his agents, to work with him in extending his rule in this age as we look forward to the age to come. But we cannot do that on our own or by trying hard, it is God's work and we engage with it, first, in prayer to him.

In this unit we will focus on prayer, as we look at 'Praying for the kingdom of God'. We can think about this relationship by looking at the diagram below and considering the importance of understanding the kingdom of God as we proclaim and pray for the kingdom of God.



The gospels constantly make this link between prayer and practice, practice and prayer. For example, The Sermon on the Mount ends with a call to put Jesus' teaching into practice or action:

> "Therefore everyone who hears these words of mine and puts them into practice is like a wise man who built his house on the rock" (Matt 7:24).

But shortly before that Jesus encourages his disciples with these words:

> "Ask and it will be given to you; seek and you will find; knock and the door will be opened to you" (Matt 7:7).

The two belong together: Proclaiming the Kingdom of God and Praying for the Kingdom of God. We must keep them together.

- Do you focus on action more than prayer or prayer more than action? How can you guard against this and make sure that you combine the two?

10.2 ENCOUNTERING PRAYER FOR THE KINGDOM OF GOD

10.2.1 Encountering prayer in our congregations

Think about and discuss the prayer you hear in your congregation or other congregations.

- What are the strengths and weaknesses of the prayer in those congregations? What priorities does the prayer you hear reflect?

- What do you think Jesus would say about that prayer in the light of the prayer he taught his disciples and his introduction to that prayer?

10.2.2 Encountering prayer in the introduction to the prayer that Jesus taught

Matt 6:5-8 is Jesus' introduction to the prayer he taught. Look back at that passage by way of reminder. We learnt two things from that introduction:

First, we learnt that genuine prayer is aimed at God himself and is not for show. However, the Lord's Prayer is often used as part of public worship.

- Do you think that it is wrong to make the Lord's Prayer part of public rather than private prayer? Explain your answer.

No, it is not wrong, but we do need to help people to understand it and use it as a form of genuine prayer. Jesus prayed in public in order to teach people to pray, and he is teaching his disciples as a group in the Sermon on the Mount.

Second, we saw that genuine prayer recognises God's care and attention and is therefore not about the number or volume of words someone uses. But we often find that people recite the Lord's Prayer without thinking and it can sound as though they are babbling like pagans!

- Do you think it is wrong to read the prayer out loud as it stands, rather than to use it as a model for prayer?

No, it is not wrong, but more than anything else we need to also learn to follow the pattern and priorities it presents, and this unit will help us with that.

10.2.3 Encountering prayer in the prayer that Jesus taught

Pray the Lord's Prayer in a common form out loud together:

Our Father in heaven,
hallowed be your name,
your kingdom come,
your will be done,
on earth as in heaven.
Give us today our daily bread.
Forgive us our sins
as we forgive those who sin against us.
Lead us not into temptation
but deliver us from evil.

For the kingdom, the power,
and the glory are yours
now and for ever. Amen.

We will reflect on this prayer and our own prayers for the kingdom of God below. But before we do, think about this question:

- How does this form of the prayer differ to the one recorded in Matt 6:9-13, which we looked at in Unit 9? Why do you think that is?

Apart from slight differences in wording, it differs in two main ways: First, it asks for forgiveness from 'sins' rather than 'debts' – but in Matt 6 vv. 14-15 interprets debt in the wider sense of 'sin'. Second, it ends with a doxology: "For the kingdom, the power, and the glory are yours, now and for ever". This ending is a later addition in some copies of Matthew's gospel and it is not original. But it is in keeping with the way Jewish prayers end (look, for example, at 1 Chr 29:11-13). And it recognises what has been said earlier in the prayer: the kingdom belongs to God; he is the Father God of redeeming power; he will be honoured and glorified. Jesus himself might have ended his prayer in a similar way on this or other occasions. But the fact that it is not there in the original encourages us to use our own words to close our prayers.

10.3 REFLECTION ON PRAYER FOR THE KINGDOM OF GOD

10.3.1 A model for our prayer

In Matt 6:9 Jesus says, "This, then, is *how* you should pray". He does not say, "This, then, is *what* you should pray". Jesus is giving us a pattern for our prayers. Look at the prayer above in the light of what we have already learnt about it in Unit 9 and consider these questions:

- In what ways do you think the Lord's Prayer provides a model for our prayers?

- How would you go about dividing up the Lord's Prayer to create a guide for our own prayers?

10.3.2 The kingdom pattern for prayer

The prayer can be used to give us 'the kingdom pattern for prayer' and 'the kingdom priorities for prayer'.

The kingdom pattern for prayer is this:

A. Come before the King	Our Father in heaven
B. Focus on the King and his concerns	1. Hallowed be your name
	2. Your kingdom come
	3. Your will be done, on earth as in heaven
C. Bring the King the needs of his people	1. Give us today our daily bread
	2. Forgive us our sins, as we forgive those who sin against us
	3. Lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil
D. Never forget the King	For the kingdom, the power, and the glory are yours now and for ever. Amen

Reflect on that pattern for prayer in the light of what we have already learnt and with your trainer, flesh out what these areas mean in practice.

The kingdom pattern for prayer fleshed out:

A. Come before the King	Our Father in heaven: *This is our anchor. In Unit 9 we saw that the Father is the God of Israel who is making his reign a reality through his rescuing and redeeming work. He is Jesus' Father and, through him, Our Father. He is in heaven, his control room, but is Lord of heaven and earth.*
B. Focus on the King and his concerns	1. Hallowed be your name: *We are to be concerned first with what the king is concerned for – his honour. Prayer begins with worship: acknowledging God's supreme worth, that he is to be praised for all he is and all he has done. His written word reveals all that and we are to use it to inform our prayers.*
	2. Your kingdom come: *The King's Kingdom, his rule and reign comes next. We turn from praise to prayer: that his kingship would be brought to bear on every sphere of life. The whole of scripture, but particularly Jesus' guidance for disciples guides this aspect of our prayer.*
	3. Your will be done, on earth as in heaven: *This not only reminds us that God's rule is about his will being brought to bear on our world, but that we are asking for God's spheres of activity, earth and heaven, to be brought together: "The kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord and of his Messiah, and he will reign for ever and ever." (Rev 11:15)*
C. Bring the King the needs of his people	1. Give us today our daily bread: *This is a prayer not only for provision from God but for dependence on him. We are to ask for what we need, as opposed to what we want or think we need. And it is a reminder of God's people's dependence on manna and his word as they journey with him. The Lord's supper reminds us of this and our future feast with him.*
	2. Forgive us our sins, as we forgive those who sin against us: *Forgiveness and the power to forgive others are essential gifts in the kingdom, which keep us forgiven and forgiving: restoring our relationships. This is an important part of the pattern, but it is not the whole thing: we need to remember the bigger picture.*
	3. Lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil: *This reminds us of all the situations that we and other believers face and in which we need to ask for grace to remain faithful. And it reminds us of the reality of evil from which we need to be spared and rescued.*
D. Never forget the King	For the kingdom, the power, and the glory are yours now and for ever. Amen: *This reminds us once again that prayer is to be rooted in God, our anchor. It is all about extending his kingdom, through his power and for the sake of his glory.*

10.3.3 The kingdom priorities for prayer

The kingdom **pattern** for prayer translates into kingdom **priorities** for prayer.

The priorities are clear in the pattern. But it is helpful to list them and to allow our prayers to be shaped by them:

1. The king we come to

2. The king's honour
3. The king's kingdom
4. The king's will

5. Our basic needs
6. Our forgiveness and forgiving
7. Our situations and our protection from evil

It is also clear in those priorities that there is a top one: God himself.

- How might those priorities begin to transform and guide your prayers and your own priorities?

10.4 ACTION ON PRAYER FOR THE KINGDOM OF GOD

Give time now to thinking about how kingdom shaped prayer can transform your prayers. Apply what you have learnt to your prayer life as individuals, as families, and as churches.

Use the three areas below to focus your discussion. How might your own attitudes, priorities and practice change in the light of Jesus' guidance on prayer?

1. Your attitude to prayer

2. Your priorities in prayer

3. Your practice of prayer

10.5 CONCLUSION: PRAYING WITH CHRIST IN GETHSEMANE

End the unit by reading Matt 26:36-46 and discussing the following questions:

- What light does the experience of Jesus and his disciples in Gethsemane shed on the relationship between Jesus' intercession and ours?

- What does Gethsemane teach us about what lies at the very heart of prayer?

- How does the passage reinforce and deepen our understanding of God as Father (Jesus' Father and our Father)?

- Can you spot the difference between Jesus' first request in v. 39 and his second one in v. 42, which he then repeats (v. 44)? Can you explain this difference and its significance?
  In v. 39 Jesus prays, "My Father, if it is possible, may this cup be taken from me. Yet not as I will, but as you will." But then in v. 42 he prays, "My Father, if it is not possible for this cup to be taken away unless I drink it, may your will be done." It is as though he senses that the Father wants his Son to go through suffering for his will to be done. Prayer seems to have prepared Jesus for this very real possibility.

- Finally, what does Gethsemane, Christ's school of prayer, teach us about prayer and suffering: Jesus' suffering and our suffering?

- Turn your discussions into prayer to end.

Unit 11. Mark 8:31-9:1 (Encounter)

This unit applies the lessons of Unit 2 to Mark 8:31-9:1. Refer back to previous 'Encountering the Bible' units for learning outline and outcomes.

As with previous units that encounter Bible passages, give the participants an opportunity to apply the steps for themselves and help them with the process.

11.1 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING MARK 8:31-9:1 (THE PASSAGE)

In order to fit the whole passage on one page it is shown on the next sheet. Use the space below for some initial comments on **setting the passage in context**. In other words, how does the passage relate to the book of Mark as a whole? Have a careful look at the structure of the book using the information in Unit 1. Look closely at the section before, Mark 8:27-30, and the section that comes after, Mark 9:2-13.

31 He then began to teach them that the
Son of Man must suffer many things and be
rejected by the elders, the chief priests and
the teachers of the law, and that he must be
killed and after three days rise again. 32 He
spoke plainly about this, and Peter took him
aside and began to rebuke him.
33 But when Jesus turned and looked at
his disciples, he rebuked Peter. ‘Get
behind me, Satan!’ he said. ‘You do not
have in mind the concerns of God, but
merely human concerns.’

34 Then he called the crowd to him along
with his disciples and said: ‘Whoever wants
to be my disciple must deny themselves
and take up their cross and follow
me. 35 For whoever wants to save their life
will lose it, but whoever loses their life for
me and for the gospel will save it. 36 What
good is it for someone to gain the whole
world, yet forfeit their soul? 37 Or what can
anyone give in exchange for their soul? 38 If
anyone is ashamed of me and my words in
this adulterous and sinful generation, the
Son of Man will be ashamed of them when
he comes in his Father’s glory with the holy
angels.’

9 And he said to them, ‘Truly I tell you,
some who are standing here will not taste
death before they see that the kingdom of
God has come with power.’ (NIV)

11.2 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING MARK 8:31-9:1 – STEP 1

STEP 1: FLESH – study the DETAILS of the text	
a) Set the passage in context. How does the passage relate to the book as a whole?	
b) See the details of the text. List important words, phrases, and relationships:	**c) Seek the meaning from the details** Explain important words, phrases, and relationships:
d) Summarise the findings. What are the main ideas that come out of this initial study?	

11.3 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING MARK 8:31-9:1 – STEPS 2 TO 4

STEP 2: SKELETON – outline the STRUCTURE of the text **a) Note all the bones in the structure.** What elements highlight the structure?
b) Decide on the 'big bones' and make an outline of the structure. What are the most important parts of the structure? Can you describe the main sections?
STEP 3: HEART – identify the MESSAGE of the text **a) State the theme of the passage.** What is the author's main point?
b) Explain the message of the passage. What is the author saying about his theme?
STEP 4: BRAIN – first, understand the PURPOSE of the text... **a) State the purpose of the passage.** Why is the author making his point?
b) Make connections for teaching today. What is the relevance of this for us?

11.4 PREACHING MARK 8:31-9:1

In order to consider how to preach this passage we will first respond to the message at a more personal level, picking up on the discoveries we have already made. We will then use the table on the next page to capture some key ideas for a sermon or talk.

11.4.1 Responding to the message of Mark 8:31-9:1

Here are three simple exercises to do in response to God's word to us in the passage we have just encountered:

1. Describe how the message you discovered in the passage spoke to you personally: What did you learn or need to be reminded of?

2. Share how the purpose of the passage helped you to apply God's word to your life: What change will this passage make to your thinking and living?

3. State and explain the message you will share with others using your own words: What is the main thing you want people to understand?

11.4.2 Preaching the message of Mark 8:31-9:1

Use the table below to outline some of the key ideas in your sermon or talk:

STEP 4: BRAIN – state the PURPOSE of the sermon My sermon's purpose statement:
STEP 5: HEART – form the MESSAGE of the sermon My sermon's theme and its message statement:
STEP 6: SKELETON – create the STRUCTURE of the sermon My sermon's outline (with the main points, introduction and conclusion):
STEP 7: FLESH – develop the DETAILS of the sermon My sermon's details (note here key words, explanations, illustrations and applications that will help you write notes or a full sermon):

Unit 12. The servant king and servant leadership (Reflection)

Overview

Jesus turns the world's understanding of leadership upside down. He used his power and released spiritual power through serving rather than controlling others. This unit considers the nature and practise of servant leadership.

Outline

- Introduction: God's concerns and human concerns
- Encountering leadership in God's world and God's word
- Reflecting on servant leadership
- Action: Being servant leaders
- Conclusion: The cross and servant leadership

Outcomes

At the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Identify sinful patterns of leadership in your culture
2. Contrast Jesus' model of leadership with the world's models
3. Illustrate godly and ungodly uses of power
4. Practise servant leadership in the way you care for and respond to others at the training event

12.1 INTRODUCTION: GOD'S CONCERNS AND HUMAN CONCERNS

12.1.1 A clash of cultures

In Mark 8:31-9:1 in Unit 11 we encountered a clash of cultures. We saw Jesus' pattern of life and leadership coming up against people's patterns of life and leadership.

Jesus asks the disciples who they think he is in the context of the various expectations the disciples were aware of. Peter takes the lead in announcing, "You are the Messiah" (Mark 8:29).

We have seen that in the structure of Mark's Gospel that declaration is the high point of the first part of the book. That first section has been gradually answering the question 'Who is Jesus?' But it is also the beginning of the next section, because it soon becomes clear that the disciples' understanding of what it means to be God's Messiah and Jesus' understanding of his role are a very long way apart.

Jesus explains in Mark 8:31 that "the Son of Man must suffer many things and be rejected by the elders, the chief priests and the teachers of the law, and that he must be killed and after three days rise again." Rather than listing and learning and changing his understanding of Jesus' mission and the type of leadership he demonstrates, Peter rebukes Jesus. But the tables are turned and Jesus then rebukes Peter! "Get behind me, Satan!" he said. "You do not have in mind the concerns of God, but merely human concerns" (Mark 8:33). The same could be said of us, much of the time.

12.1.2 Learning about leadership Jesus' way

Jesus is just beginning to teach them what kind of a Messiah he is, or in other words, what it looks like when God comes to rescue his people and establish his rule as their rightful king and what it means for God to lead his people. This learning experience will be quite a journey for them, as they follow Jesus to the cross and witness his death there.

The disciples' pattern of learning that Jesus leads them on fits with the pattern we have been using, the 'ERA' cycle. Have a look at the summary table again, and compare it with the process the disciples are going through:

Step and description	Definition of key word	Activity	Outcome
To **encounter** something in God's world and/or God's word with a desire for wisdom.	**'Encounter':** To meet something new and surprising	Describe	Discoveries
To **reflect** on those situations and the Scriptures in order to gain wisdom.	**'Reflect':** To pause for thought and go deeper	Consider	Principles
To take **action** in God's world with the wisdom that comes from God's word.	**'Action':** To do something new or in a different way.	Plan	Practice

In the first part of the book of Mark the disciples have already been through this cycle. In fact, they will have gone through it a number of times with the new experiences they encounter.

But at the bigger level of learning about who Jesus is they have been through it slowly over the course of the eight chapters. They have **encountered** Jesus as one who proclaims the kingship of God and who calls them to follow him. They have **reflected** on what this means as they see more and more of who Jesus is and what he does. They have taken **action** as his disciples, not least as they are sent out to proclaim the kingship of God. The ultimate action is their declaration that Jesus is the Messiah.

But that declaration is also the beginning of new cycle of learning. Jesus does not want them to tell anyone about who he is yet (8:30), instead they are back in school and learning what sort of Messiah Jesus is (8:31).

- What new and surprising thing do the disciples, particularly Peter, **encounter** in Mark 8:31? How would you describe it? What do they discover?
- How does Jesus help them to **reflect** on it in Mark 8:34-9:1 and in the experience that follows?
- What **action** do they take, or what difference does it make?

We will use that same process again to build on these insights and, by God's grace, transform our own understanding and practice of leadership.

12.2 ENCOUNTERING LEADERSHIP IN GOD'S WORLD AND GOD'S WORD

12.2.1 Human concerns

Discuss the negative models of leadership that you see in the world around you, including in some churches. Think of patterns of leadership that reflect sinful, "human concerns" rather than "the concerns of God". Consider those in positions of political leadership in the country at different levels, as well as in business, the family, and religious institutions. Use these questions to help you:

- What is it that motivates most leaders today?
- How do they use the resources available to them and for what purposes?
- Describe their ambitions.
- What are their strategies and approaches to influencing others?
- What is their understanding of power: where it comes from; what it is; how to use it?
- What attitudes go along with this? In other words, how does a wrong understanding of leadership shape the character of leaders today?

12.2.2 The concerns of God

Now discuss what you are beginning to see about Jesus' model of leadership. Use those same questions to help you:

- What is it that motivates servant leaders?
- How do they use the resources available to them and for what purposes?
- Describe their ambitions.
- What are their strategies and approaches to influencing others?
- What is their understanding of power: where it comes from; what it is; how to use it?
- What attitudes go along with this? In other words, how does a right understanding of leadership shape the character of leaders today?

12.3 REFLECTING ON SERVANT LEADERSHIP

In Mark 8:31-9:1 we saw that Jesus the Messiah must suffer and die before rising again as the Son of Man of Daniel 7 who has been vindicated, or proven true and right. Mark 9:1 made it clear that God's coming in Jesus the Messiah as a king who takes the form of a servant and brings the rightful rule of God into his world, "the kingdom of God has come with power".

That has begun in the person of Jesus himself. We looked on to Mark 9:2-13 where we saw that the Son of Man, the figure people all knew about from the Book of Daniel, is a rejected figure before he is a reigning figure. Jesus is Daniel's Son of Man and the Psalmist's Davidic King and Son of God and Isaiah's Servant King and much more besides. If we want to learn about real leadership and real power and real influence that extends God's kingship, we need to learn from him.

- Look at Mark 9:30-37. How does this passage reinforce what we have learnt already? How does it build on the picture we are beginning to see?
- Look now at Mark 9:35-45.
- Do you notice how Jesus draws out a lesson about leadership each time he explains about his death? Look back at Mark 9:32-34 to see what he says there about what will happen in Jerusalem. If you have time compare it with what he has said already in 8:31 and 9:31.
- How does Jesus compare human leadership with God's leadership in 10:41-45?
- Mark 10:45 is particularly important. The next section has the *immediate* healing of Blind Bartimaeus, indicating that they have now fully understood who Jesus is and what he has come to do. Learn this verse and reflect on it together. Think about the link between service and setting others free (being a ransom for them).
- How would you summarise all this?

12.3.1 Principles of servant leadership

Use the same questions we have already used to help you take this further in the light of the closer look at Mark's gospel. See if you can add to what you have already learnt to define some principles of servant leadership more sharply:

- What is it that motivates servant leaders?
- How do they use the resources available to them and for what purposes?
- Describe their ambitions.
- What are their strategies and approaches to influencing others?
- What is their understanding of power: where it comes from; what it is; how to use it?
- What attitudes go along with this? In other words, how does a right understanding of leadership shape the character of leaders today?

Servant leadership: brings the power and presence of God's rule 'on earth as in heaven' through sacrificial service done in the cause of Christ. It is motivated by a desire to see God's name honoured and by the kingship of God, transforming the present and renewing the whole creation in the future, when the Father's will is done "on earth as it is in heaven". Servant leaders use resources wisely to that end and influence others as agents of the King. They share Jesus' understanding of power: that true spiritual power is released through sacrifice and service. That is the only sort of power that brings lasting change. Attitudes of humility and kindness go with that kind of exercise of power and

shape the character of servant leaders quite differently to the character of those leaders with purely human concerns.

12.4 ACTION: BEING SERVANT LEADERS

John's gospel combines the pictures of Jesus as servant and Jesus as shepherd. Our work as church leaders means we have to be both.

12.4.1 Jesus the Good Shepherd as a model for his under-shepherds

In the context of the self-serving leadership of Israel of his day, and set against the past shepherds that Ezekiel 34 rebuked, Jesus says, "I am the Good Shepherd" (John 10:11). Look at John 10:1-18 and do the following exercise:

- Note all the different tasks the Good Shepherd does and the responsibilities he has.

- Make a list of them and think through what that means for us as shepherds under the Great Shepherd's authority.

In John 10:1-18 we see that Jesus, the Good Shepherd, leads his sheep in these ways:

- *He calls them*
- *He goes ahead of them*
- *He protects them*
- *He rescues them*
- *He gives them life, "to the full"*
- *He is ready to lay down his life for them*
- *He knows them*
- *He brings in other sheep to join them*

In 1 Peter 5:1-4 we see that Peter, who had seemed so unpromising at first when rebuking Jesus, had truly understood servant leadership:

> [1] To the elders among you, I appeal as a fellow elder and a witness of Christ's sufferings who also will share in the glory to be revealed: [2] be shepherds of God's flock that is under your care, watching over them – not because you must, but because you are willing, as God wants you to be; not pursuing dishonest gain, but eager to serve; [3] not lording it over those entrusted to you, but being examples to the flock. [4] And when the Chief Shepherd appears, you will receive the crown of glory that will never fade away.

Reflect on the passage and think about what you have learnt about the various aspects of servant leadership above and how they might apply to us as we care for God's flock, in the way the Good Shepherd does:

- The motives of servant leaders.

- The stewardship of servant leaders.

- The ambitions of servant leaders.

- The strategies and approaches of servant leaders.
- The understanding of power of servant leaders.
- The attitudes of servant leaders.

Make a plan for ways in which you can become more like the Good Shepherd.

EXTRA: We noted Ezekiel 34 above. Look at that chapter to see what bad shepherds are like in contrast. That will sharpen your understanding and appreciation of the Good Shepherd and good shepherds.

12.4.2 Jesus the Servant King as the model for all servant leaders

In John 10:1-18 Jesus presents himself as the Good Shepherd. In John 13 we see another picture: Jesus the Servant King. Read through John 13:1-17 before looking at the comments below.

John 13:1-2 sets Jesus' practical display of love in the context of the cross he will soon face. It is a picture of Christ's work on the cross and means that the cross is a demonstration of his service and sacrifice there, that, "even the Son of Man did not come to be served, but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many" (Mark 10:45).

When many leaders realise the power they have, they use it for personal gain. However, when "Jesus knew that the Father had put all things under his power" (John 13:3), he did something very different: he dressed like a servant and washed their feet, the lowest of all tasks.

- What does this teach us about true Christian leadership?
- How is power to be used and demonstrated in Christian communities?
- How might this help you in the various tasks of leadership you face?

12.4.3 Self-sacrifice must not exclude self-care

It is important to end this section by noting that self-sacrifice must not exclude self-care. We will not be able to care for others if we do not care for ourselves. It is no good serving others in ways that cause us to burn out. Jesus himself made time to be restored in his vision and relationship with the Father. We must take that very seriously and find ways of caring for ourselves and our families, if we have them.

- How can you make sure that the all-consuming work of local church leadership does not consume you and make you useless to the Lord and to other people?

12.5 CONCLUSION: THE CROSS AND SERVANT LEADERSHIP

All Jesus' teaching on servant leadership looks forward to the cross. As we saw in John 13:1 he chose a moment "just before the Passover Feast" to show the sacrificial, cleansing nature of his love: he was going to not only be the Good Shepherd but the Lamb of God (John 1:29). We will look at this more closely in Unit 13, but not before we have encountered Mark 12:1-12, which adds other dimensions to the meaning of the cross.

End this session with prayer for one another, whether in pairs or small groups, after asking about the challenges you are facing, or in a larger group. You might like to end those prayers with the words of Hebrews 13:20-21, which sum up some of what we have learnt in the form of a blessing:

> Now may the God of peace,
> who through the blood of the eternal covenant
> brought back from the dead our Lord Jesus,
> that great Shepherd of the sheep,
> equip you with everything good for doing his will,
> and may he work in us what is pleasing to him,
> through Jesus Christ,
> to whom be glory for ever and ever. Amen.

Unit 13. Mark 12:1-12 (Encounter)

This unit applies the lessons of Unit 2 to Mark 12:1-12. Refer back to previous 'Encountering the Bible' units for learning outline and outcomes.

As with previous units that encounter Bible passages, give the participants an opportunity to apply the steps for themselves and help them with the process.

13.1 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING MARK 12:1-12 (THE PASSAGE)

12 Jesus then began to speak to them in
parables: 'A man planted a vineyard. He
put a wall round it, dug a pit for the
winepress and built a watchtower. Then he
rented the vineyard to some farmers and
moved to another place. **2** At harvest time
he sent a servant to the tenants to collect
from them some of the fruit of the
vineyard. **3** But they seized him, beat him
and sent him away empty-handed. **4** Then
he sent another servant to them; they
struck this man on the head and treated
him shamefully. **5** He sent still another, and
that one they killed. He sent many others;
some of them they beat, others they killed.
6 'He had one left to send, a son, whom
he loved. He sent him last of all, saying,
"They will respect my son."
7 'But the tenants said to one another,
"This is the heir. Come, let's kill him, and
the inheritance will be ours." **8** So they took
him and killed him, and threw him out of
the vineyard.

9 ‘What then will the owner of the vineyard do? He will come and kill those tenants and give the vineyard to others. 10 Haven’t you read this passage of Scripture:

“‘The stone the builders rejected
has become the cornerstone;
11 the Lord has done this,
and it is marvellous in our eyes”?’
12 Then the chief priests, the teachers of the law and the elders looked for a way to arrest him because they knew he had spoken the parable against them. But they were afraid of the crowd; so they left him and went away. (NIV)

13.2 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING MARK 12:1-12 – STEP 1

STEP 1: FLESH – study the DETAILS of the text	
a) Set the passage in context. How does the passage relate to the book as a whole?	
b) See the details of the text. List important words, phrases, and relationships:	**c) Seek the meaning from the details** Explain important words, phrases, and relationships:
d) Summarise the findings. What are the main ideas that come out of this initial study?	

13.3 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING MARK 12:1-12 – STEPS 2 TO 4

STEP 2: SKELETON – outline the STRUCTURE of the text **a) Note all the bones in the structure.** What elements highlight the structure?
b) Decide on the 'big bones' and make an outline of the structure. What are the most important parts of the structure? Can you describe the main sections?
STEP 3: HEART – identify the MESSAGE of the text **a) State the theme of the passage.** What is the author's main point?
b) Explain the message of the passage. What is the author saying about his theme?
STEP 4: BRAIN – first, understand the PURPOSE of the text... **a) State the purpose of the passage.** Why is the author making his point?
b) Make connections for teaching today. What is the relevance of this for us?

13.4 PREACHING MARK 12:1-12

In order to consider how to preach this passage we will first respond to the message at a more personal level, picking up on the discoveries we have already made. We will then use the table on the next page to capture some key ideas for a sermon or talk.

13.4.1 Responding to the message of Mark 12:1-12

Here are three simple exercises to do in response to God's word to us in the passage we have just encountered:

1. Describe how the message you discovered in the passage spoke to you personally: What did you learn or need to be reminded of?

2. Share how the purpose of the passage helped you to apply God's word to your life: What change will this passage make to your thinking and living?

3. State and explain the message you will share with others using your own words: What is the main thing you want people to understand?

13.4.2 Preaching the message of Mark 12:1-12

Use the table below to outline some of the key ideas in your sermon or talk:

STEP 4: BRAIN – state the PURPOSE of the sermon My sermon's purpose statement:
STEP 5: HEART – form the MESSAGE of the sermon My sermon's theme and its message statement:
STEP 6: SKELETON – create the STRUCTURE of the sermon My sermon's outline (with the main points, introduction and conclusion):
STEP 7: FLESH – develop the DETAILS of the sermon My sermon's details (note here key words, explanations, illustrations and applications that will help you write notes or a full sermon):

Unit 14. The cross and the Lord's Supper (Reflection)

Overview

"The Lord Jesus, on the night he was betrayed took bread …" (1 Cor 11:23). In doing so he looked forward to the cross and left his Church with a powerful way of remembering, knowing, experiencing, understanding and declaring the message of the cross. This unit explores the Last Supper and what it teaches us about the Lord and his work.

Outline

- Introduction: The cross and communion in Mark's gospel
- Encountering Mark 12:1-12 as background to the cross
- Reflecting on the Cross and the Lord's Supper
- Action: Celebrating the Lord's Supper

Outcomes

At the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Discuss the message of the cross and the Last Supper in the light of the Passover
2. Illustrate the meaning of the Lord's Supper by using a cross made up of arrows that indicate some of the different messages it contains
3. Plan a celebration of the Lord's Supper, which will encourage and equip leaders

If this unit comes on the morning of the last day of a workshop or residential time, or if it is part of a full day with local church leaders, why not use Unit 13 followed by Unit 14 as an opportunity to celebrate and reflect on the Lord's Supper, together?

14.1 INTRODUCTION: THE CROSS AND COMMUNION IN MARK'S GOSPEL

Mark's gospel builds a picture of who Jesus is and what he came to do, and through that it declares the good news of his kingship. As Mark writes we see more and more clearly what it means for Jesus to be the Son of God and the Son of Man and the Servant King. According to Mark we will only understand Jesus and his work fully as he suffers, dies and rises again.

The cross lies at the very heart of God's good news and the Lord's Supper is his gift to his people to help us remember and celebrate all he has done. This unit looks at the cross and communion so that we can be strengthened to follow Christ. Begin by simply discussing these questions:

- Why is the Lord's Supper so important to you and your church?

- How can you use it more effectively to teach people about the gospel and to strengthen them in their faith?

14.2 ENCOUNTERING MARK 12:1-12 AS BACKGROUND TO THE CROSS

This unit is one of Christian reflection. We know what that means: we **encounter** something with a desire for wisdom; we **reflect** on those things with a desire for wisdom; we take **action** with the wisdom of God's word.

In this unit we will begin with the encounter we have already had with Mark 12:1-12 in Unit 13, before moving straight to reflection as we consider the cross and communion.

Mark 12:1-12 built on what Jesus has already said about his coming suffering, some of which we looked at in Unit 12. We saw that Jesus drew on the peoples' memory of God's neglected vineyard in Isaiah 5 – God's own people who have rebelled against him. Against that backdrop he painted a picture of God's prophets being sent to his people and their leaders, and being ignored and rejected. The greatest prophet of all, God's own Son, will be killed.

Jesus went on to suggest that others will inherit the privileges of being God's own people, his new temple where he can dwell, and that the one who was rejected will be the foundation stone in a new temple, a new people (quoting Psalm 118):

> "The stone the builders rejected
> has become the cornerstone;
> the Lord has done this,
> and it is marvellous in our eyes."

The leaders of Israel knew full well that Jesus was talking about them and "looked for a way to arrest him".

We saw that it is interesting that Peter, who Mark followed and listened to, used that same verse from Psalm 118 in 1 Peter 2:7, when describing God's new people, the Church. That passage, which also includes references to Isaiah, helps us to understand Mark 12:1-12.

Mark 12:1-12 is therefore telling us that Jesus' rejection, suffering and death, will be a whole new beginning, a work of God, something that will be wonderful as we look back on it and enjoy its fruits. It provides background to understanding the cross.

14.3 REFLECTING ON THE CROSS AND THE LORD'S SUPPER

14.3.1 Introducing Mark 14:12-26 and the meaning of the cross

The cross is very rich in meaning. We will never be able to exhaust its wealth or fully plumb its depths. Therefore, the Bible is full of different truths about the cross. We have already been learning about the cross in the BUILD curriculum. For example, we heard in 2 Tim 2:5 that, "there is one God and one mediator between God and mankind, the man Christ Jesus, who gave himself as a ransom for all people." In that verse Paul is drawing on the stories and writings about Jesus the Messiah, who, Mark tells us, "did not come to be served, but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many".

We will learn much more as the curriculum continues and as we walk with Jesus and learn from him. Here we will focus on certain truths about the cross. Mark 14:12-26 comes in the context of Jesus' approaching arrest and death. It helps us to understand the cross and the meal that celebrates God's work there. And it does so by making a

clear link with the Passover, just as we have seen that John 13 draws attention to the Passover as the setting for Jesus' example and teaching there. Therefore, before looking at Mark 14:12-26 in more detail we will consider what the Passover means for our understanding of the cross.

In Mark's gospel, and in the context of the Passover, Jesus is telling us some very important things about the cross. Above everything else he is telling us that his victory at the cross will bring about two main things, two things that belong together.

First, it will bring about a True Exodus and, second, it will bring about a True Return from Exile.

14.3.2 The Passover, Exodus and the meaning of the cross

At Passover Israel celebrated the way in which their true King set them free from the king of Egypt. Exodus 12 is one of the passages you may have looked at in the devotions during Module Two.

Exodus 12:1-30 describes the preparation for the Passover itself, including the slaughter of the Passover lamb, and it ends with the judgment on Egypt, which God's people are spared through the blood of that lamb.

Exodus 12:31-42 describes how Pharaoh released them, and it ends with a note about the 430 years they had been in Egypt and how they are to remember the Passover and the Exodus.

Exodus 12:43-50 continues to teach about those celebrations, and how foreigners can be included in God's people.

The Lord's Supper deliberately remembers those events and the blood of a New Covenant.

- The Lord's Supper reminds God's people of the original Passover and Exodus and views the Cross as the beginning of a True Exodus. What might that tell us about the work of the cross? What does God achieve there through his Messiah?

14.3.3 The true return from exile and the meaning of the cross

We said that the ideas of a True Exodus and a True Return from Exile belong together.

We have learnt about the True Exodus above. But do you remember, from the very beginning of Mark's gospel, that the coming of God himself as the Messiah, King Jesus, was also the fulfilment of a much later event in Israel's history?

Mark begins his gospel with the words,

"The beginning of the good news about Jesus the Messiah, the Son of God, as it is written in Isaiah the prophet:

> 'I will send my messenger ahead of you,
> who will prepare your way' –

> 'a voice of one calling in the wilderness,
> "Prepare the way for the Lord,
> make straight paths for him.""

The coming of Jesus was the coming of the Lord. God himself returned to his people so that they could now return to him. It was the real end of the exile, the real return. And that real end of the exile, the real return, was also the real exodus, as God's people were finally set free to serve him.

In the exodus from Egypt, they were set free from oppression – God showed he was King over all other kings and powers.

At the end of the exile, the return from Babylon, they were released from the shame of and judgment on their sin and rebellion. God showed that through his Servant he was bearing their sin and shame.

We will look at this more in Module Four and Nehemiah and the Historical Books and in Module Nine and Isaiah and the Prophets. There we will look in detail at Isaiah 53:1-6. Turn to Isaiah 53:1-6 now and read it together.

- The Lord's Supper reminds us of the real end of the exile, which is also the true exodus. What might that tell us about the cross and what the Lord achieved there?

This prayer of thanksgiving from the Anglican book of Common Worship for use after Easter is a response to these wonderful truths. It is a prayer you can pray together:

> Blessed are you, Lord God of our salvation,
> to you be praise and glory for ever.
> As once you ransomed your people from Egypt
> and led them to freedom in the promised land,
> so now you have delivered us from the dominion of darkness
> and brought us into the kingdom of your risen Son.
> May we, the first fruits of your new creation,
> rejoice in this new day you have made,
> and praise you for your mighty acts.
> Blessed be God, Father, Son and Holy Spirit.
> ***All*** **Blessed be God for ever.**

14.3.4 Mark 14:12-26 and the meaning of the cross

Now look at Mark 14:12-26 and see how it picks up the Old Testament themes we have discussed above. Remember, from Unit 1, that the Upper Room may well be in Mark's family home in Jerusalem.

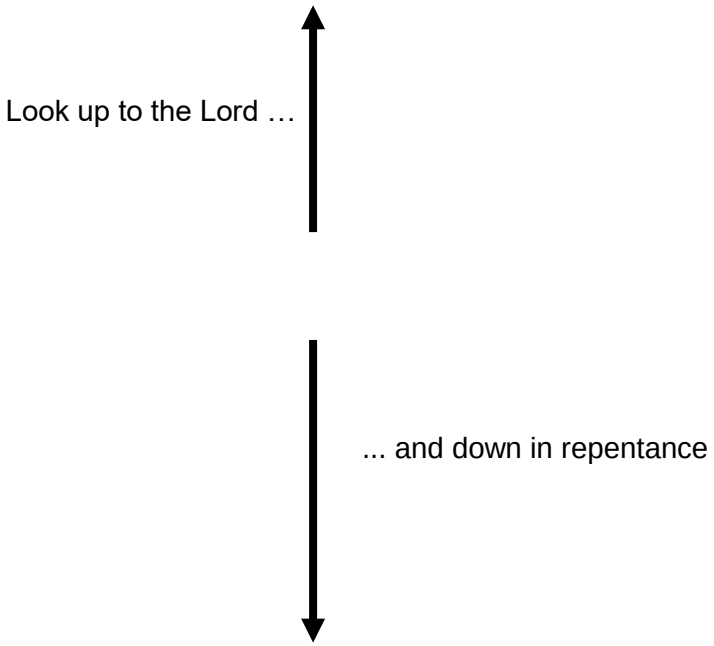
- What does Mark 14:12-26 tell us about the meaning of the cross?

- What does Mark 14:12-26 tell us about the meaning of Holy Communion?

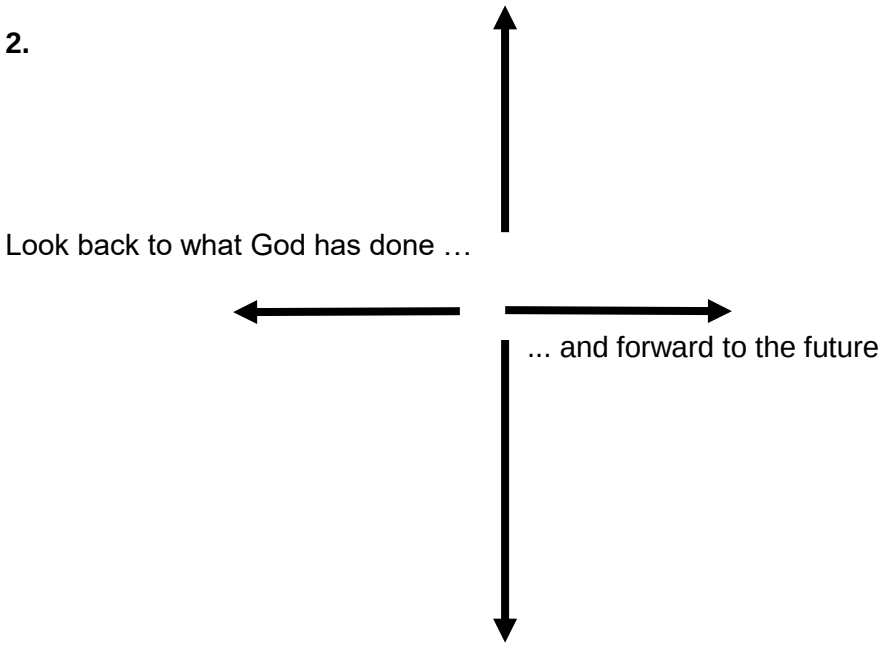
14.3.5 Picturing the meaning of the cross and communion

The pictures below, with their simple arrows, are a way of drawing the meaning and message of the cross. Your trainer will draw these out, one stage at a time, to build a cross. The arrows point in different directions to remind us about different truths. See if you can add verses to these to illustrate them.

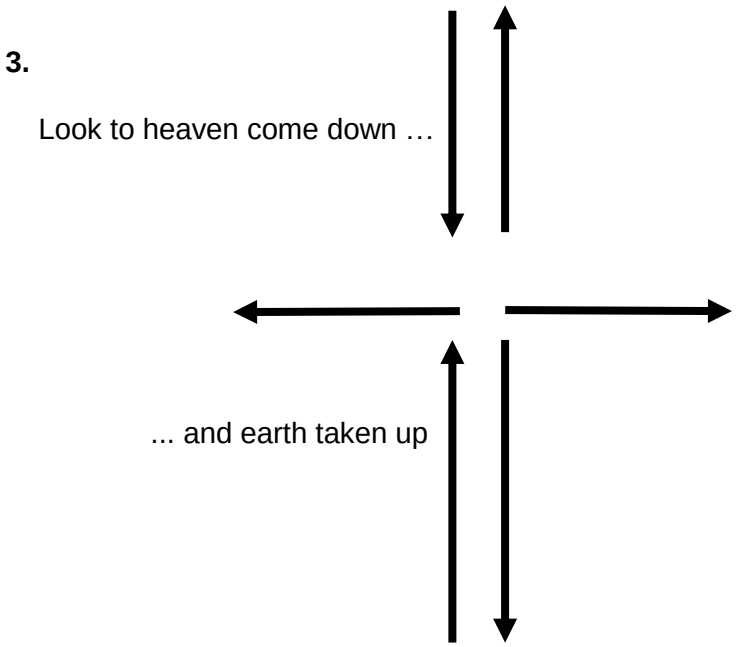
1.



2.


Look back to what God has done …
... and forward to the future

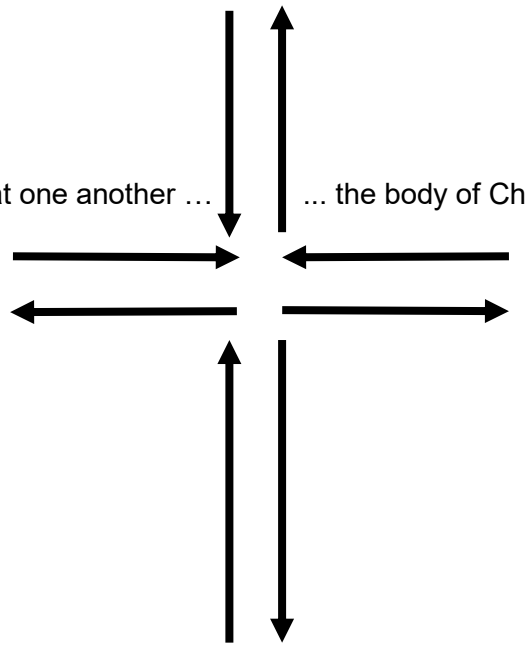
3.


Look to heaven come down …
... and earth taken up

4.

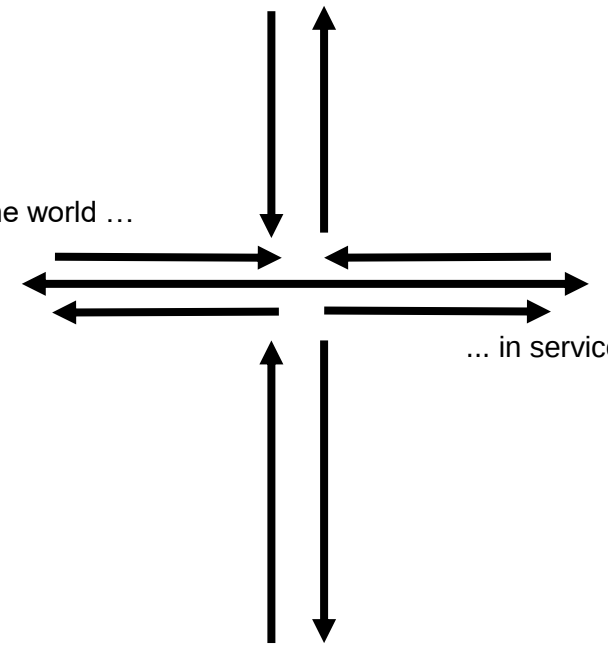
Look together at one another …

... the body of Christ



5.

Look out to the world …



... in service and mission

14.4 ACTION: CELEBRATING THE LORD'S SUPPER

The Lord's Supper proclaims the message of the cross in a way we can taste and touch. It is a powerful reminder of God's new covenant or agreement with his people, made with his own blood.

14.4.1 A simple celebration of Holy Communion

The Lord celebrated supper with his disciples in a very simple way, as we have seen in Mark 14. Paul uses those same words and traditions in 1 Cor 11:23-26:

> [23] For I received from the Lord what I also passed on to you: the Lord Jesus, on the night he was betrayed, took bread, [24] and when he had given thanks, he broke it and said, 'This is my body, which is for you; do this in remembrance of me.' [25] In the same way, after supper he took the cup, saying, 'This cup is the new covenant in my blood; do this, whenever you drink it, in remembrance of me.' [26] For whenever you eat this bread and drink this cup, you proclaim the Lord's death until he comes.

It reminds us that the Lord's Supper is:

- An act of remembrance of Jesus, looking back, as we have seen.
- An act of proclamation, declaring "the Lord's death".
- An act of expectation, looking forward, proclaiming the Lord's death "until he comes".

We have seen that in the picture of the cross and the arrows. It means it can be celebrated very simply as we break bread and eat it, and pour wine and drink it together in remembrance of what Jesus has done for us.

But it is helpful to have a structure to follow.

14.4.2 The structure of a service of Holy Communion

One common structure is given below:

1. Greet one another in the name of the Lord
2. Prepare for worship together
3. Confess sin and receive assurance of God's forgiveness
4. Read and respond to God's word
5. Pray for the Church and the world
6. Share in the peace of the Lord
7. Prepare the Lord's table
8. Pray a communion prayer and break the bread

9. Share the bread and wine

10. Leave with God's blessing to live his way

- Think about those different elements together and how they help us to celebrate the full meaning of the Lord's Supper.

14.4.3 A service of Holy Communion

God's Church has a rich variety of different liturgies or words and prayers to use in worship together. The words below are from the Church of Uganda's 'Come and Worship' book and are given for your reflection and use. Have a look through them and see how they are used in the structure above, which is included as the numbered titles below. Not all the liturgy is given, and these words are not everything that might need to happen, at some points just the title of the section is given. Think about what other words and worship might be needed in between these, and why each part is important.

1. Greet one another in the name of the Lord

Minister: The Lord be with you;
All: and with you also.

2. Preparation for worship together

All: Almighty God,
our hearts are open before you
and there is nothing we can hide from you;
breathe your Holy Spirit into
our hearts and cleanse our thoughts
so that we may truly love you
and worthily praise your holy name;
through Jesus Christ our Lord. Amen.

3. Confess sin and receive assurance of God's forgiveness

Almighty God, our heavenly Father,
we have sinned against you
and against our neighbour
in thought and word and deed,
through negligence, through weakness,
through our own deliberate fault.
We are truly sorry
and repent of all our sins.
For the sake of your Son Jesus Christ,
who died for us,
forgive us all that is past
and grant that we may serve you in newness of life
to the glory of your name. Amen.

4. Read and respond to God's word

5. Pray for the Church and the world

6. Share in the peace of the Lord

Christ is our peace.
He has reconciled us to God
in one body by the Cross
We meet in his name and share his peace.

The peace of the Lord be always with you
All: **and also with you.**

Let us offer one another a sign of that peace.

7. Prepare the Lord's table

8. Pray a communion prayer and break the bread

Rejoice and lift up your hearts.
All **We lift them to the Lord.**

Let us give thanks to our Lord God.
All **It is right to give him thanks and praise.**

O Lord, Holy Father, Everlasting God,
it is not only right but also our duty
to give you thanks, at all times and in all places,
through Jesus Christ our Lord.

Therefore with angels and archangels,
and with all saints in heaven,
we praise your glorious name forever, saying:

All **Holy, holy, holy**
God of power and might,
heaven and earth are full of your glory.
glory be to you, Lord most high. Amen.

All **We do not come to your table, merciful Lord,**
trusting in our own goodness,
but in your mercy.
We are not good enough even to eat the crumbs
that fall from your table.
But you never change;
your nature is always to have mercy.
We, therefore, humbly ask you, gracious Lord,
to let us eat the flesh of your dear Son, Jesus Christ
and to drink his blood,
So that our sinful bodies may be made clean by his body
and our souls washed by his precious blood,
and that we may, forever, dwell in him and he in us. Amen.

Almighty God, our heavenly Father,
we praise and thank you
for giving us your Son
to suffer and die on the cross for our salvation.
As we receive the bread and wine in the way the Saviour showed us,
may we truly receive his body and his blood.

The night that he was betrayed;
He took bread …
and after giving thanks ,
broke it …
and gave it to his disciples, saying:
"Take and eat;
this is my body which is given for you,
do this in memory of me."
After supper, he took the cup
and after giving thanks
he gave it to them saying:
"Drink this, all of you;
This is my blood of the new covenant
which is shed for you and for many
for the forgiveness of sins.
Do this, whenever you drink it,
in memory of me.

Therefore, heavenly Father,
we remember his offering of himself
made once for all upon the cross;
we proclaim his mighty resurrection and glorious ascension;
we look for the coming of your kingdom,
and with this bread and this cup
we make the memorial of Christ your Son our Lord.

All **O Lamb of God,**
who takes away the sins of the world,
have mercy on us;
O Lamb of God,
who takes away the sins of the world,
have mercy upon us;
O Lamb of God,
who takes away the sins of the world,
grant us your peace.

The service continues with the Lord's Prayer.

9. Share the bread and wine

Draw near with faith.

May the body of Christ preserve you in eternal life.
Amen.
May the blood of Christ preserve you in eternal life.
Amen.

10. Leave with God's blessing to live his way

All **Almighty God,**
we thank you for feeding us
with the body and blood of your Son,
Jesus Christ.

Through him we offer you our souls and bodies
to be a living sacrifice.
Send us out
in the power of your Spirit,
to live and work
to your praise and glory. Amen.

May the peace of God,
which is greater than we can understand,
be in your hearts and remain with you,
so that you may always know and love God,
and of his Son Jesus Christ our Lord;
and may the blessing of God almighty,
the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit,
be with you, now and always. Amen.

Go in peace to love and serve the Lord.

All **We go in the name of Christ. Amen.**

14.5 CONCLUSION: LOCAL LITURGY AND THE LORD'S SUPPER

In 1989 the Provincial Synod of the Anglican Church of Kenya approved a new liturgy of Holy Communion for their Church, developed when the former Archbishop, David Gitari, was Bishop of Mount Kenya East and Chairman of the Liturgical Commission. He wrote:

> "This is not a modern translation or even adaptation of the old, not an importation of liturgical revision from the West, but rather a new liturgy which has grown out of recent developments in African Christian Theology and liturgical research. It is both thoroughly Biblical and authentically African, both faithful to Anglican tradition and refreshingly creative."

If you are able to access it look through it and consider how it expresses biblical truth in fresh ways. You might like to end this session with one form of after communion blessing that is part of that liturgy, which begins with this instruction: "The people accompany the first three responses with a sweep of the arm towards the cross behind the Holy Table, and their final response with a sweep towards heaven." Here is the blessing itself:

Minister: All our problems
People: **We send to the cross of Christ**

Minister: All our difficulties
People: **We send to the cross of Christ**

Minister: All the devil's works

People: **We send to the cross of Christ**

Minister: All our hopes
People: **We set on the risen Christ**

Minister: Christ the Sun of Righteousness shine upon you and scatter the darkness from before your path: and the blessing of God Almighty, Father, Son and Holy Spirit, be among you, and remain with you always. **Amen.**

Unit 15. Making disciples (Action)

Overview

The church must grow in depth as well as size. Jesus' strategy for that is to have disciple-making-disciples. This unit explores what that means in Scripture and practice.

Outline

- Introduction: Is your church shallow or deep?
- What is our job?
- Be a disciple
- Make disciples
- Conclusion: "I am with you always"

Outcomes

At the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Summarise Jesus' strategy for growing the church
2. Explain the different components of Jesus' approach to discipleship
3. Evaluate our churches and the quality of their discipleship
4. Plan ways of developing discipleship in your church(es)

15.1 INTRODUCTION: IS YOUR CHURCH SHALLOW OR DEEP?

Uganda has many lakes, and it is set in a region with many lakes. The region – with Uganda at the centre, surrounded by South Sudan, Kenya, Tanzania, Rwanda, Burundi and the Democratic Republic of Congo – is sometimes known as the Great Lakes Region.

Those lakes vary in size and depth. For example, Lake Kyoga, to the north of Lake Victoria, is fairly large but very shallow. It is around 1,720 square kilometres in size but only four metres deep on average. Nowhere is it more than six metres deep.

Lake Bunyonyi, on the other hand, set in the south west corner of Uganda, is fairly small but very deep. It is only 60 square kilometres in size but is at least forty metres deep. (There are rumours that it might be almost a kilometre deep in some places; no one seems to know how deep it really is.)

- Discuss which of these lakes – Kyoga or Bunyonyi – best describes your Church (whether it is the Church of Uganda or another national church or the local church you belong to)? Explain your answer to others.

Lake Victoria is a wonderful balance of size and depth. It sits at the heart of the region and feeds the whole area with fish, water and climate control, and it provides power from the mighty Nile, which flows all the way to the Mediterranean Sea, watering lands on its way. Lake Victoria is the second largest lake in the whole world in terms of surface area, covering almost 70,000 square kilometres. It is 85 metres deep in some places and 40 metres deep on average.

- How can we increase both the size and depth of God's Church?

15.2 WHAT IS OUR JOB?

15.2.1 A Great Commission

There are several 'commissions' in the gospels, where the disciples are sent out to do Jesus' work in the light of returning to the Father. At the end of Mark, Jesus tells the disciples: "Go into all the world and preach the gospel to all creation" (Mark 16:15). Some people dispute that ending, but that command rests on earlier verses: Mark 13:10 tells us that "the gospel must first be preached to all nations" and 14:9 is another reminder that the gospel is to be "preached throughout the world". Luke 24:46-49 and Acts 1:8 are other 'commissions', which we will look at more in Module Five. And in John 20:21 Jesus tells his disciples: "As the Father has sent me, I am sending you".

But the most extensive commission is found at the end of Matthew's Gospel. Read it out loud together:

> [16] Then the eleven disciples went to Galilee, to the mountain where Jesus had told them to go. [17] When they saw him, they worshipped him; but some doubted. [18] Then Jesus came to them and said, 'All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. [19] Therefore go and make disciples of all nations, baptising them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, [20] and teaching them to obey everything I have commanded you. And surely I am with you always, to the very end of the age.' (Matthew 28:18-20)

- What do these verses tell us about how the Church is to grow in both numbers and depth?

15.2.2 Disciple making disciples

There are two very simple things to notice about how the church grows in size and depth.

First, we are to be disciples. Verse 16 tells us that it is the 'disciples' who obey Jesus and go to the place he had told them to meet with him.

Second, we are to make disciples. Verse 19 goes on to say that those disciples are told to make other disciples.

It is very simple: we are to be 'disciple making disciples'. That is how the church will grow in every dimension. It is the great need of the church today: Be a disciple of Jesus and make disciples of Jesus.

This has already been a theme of BUILD. In Module One we saw that gospel centred ministry puts multiplication of gospel workers at the centre. Paul tells Timothy to pass on the message, to give it away, that is how it will be guarded and how the church will grow: "And the things you have heard me say in the presence of many witnesses entrust to reliable people who will also be qualified to teach others" (2 Tim 2:2). That speaks of four generations of those who have heard and passed on the gospel: Paul, Timothy, 'reliable

people' and those 'others' they will teach. We need to build on that and commit ourselves to being disciples of Christ who make disciples of Christ.

15.3 BE A DISCIPLE

A disciple is a learner: one who learns from Jesus and then lives like Jesus. That means following him.

In our study of Mark, we have already seen that disciples are Jesus' agents of the Kingdom, spreading his influence in this world in expectation of the next. In 6.2.2 we discussed 'God's people and the proclamation of God's kingship' and saw that God's new, or renewed, people will be central to his strategy of announcing, establishing and implementing his kingly rule. Remember, in 3:14-15 Jesus shows that this is his plan and he begins to set it in motion by appointing the twelve. First, from 3:20 to 6:6 they are "with him" and learn from him. But in 6:7-11 Jesus prepares to "send them out", which they do in vv. 12-13. And throughout the rest of Mark he teaches them more and more of what it means to be like him, including, in Mark 8:34, that, "Whoever wants to be my disciple must deny themselves and take up their cross and follow me."

Discipleship is one of Matthew's main concerns, as we are seeing already from his commission. Here are six different points about discipleship from Matthew that will help guide us in being disciples:

15.3.1 Messiah

From the beginning it is clear that Jesus is the one who fulfils the story of Israel and the calling of God's people. That foundation is laid from Matthew 1:1 to 4:11. He is the Messiah: "And a voice from heaven said, 'This is my Son, whom I love; with him I am well pleased'" (Matt 3:17).

- Disciples need to learn more and more about Jesus the Messiah and make that our life's passion and work.

15.3.2 Message

Matthew then draws attention to the simple message that the Messiah has: "Repent, for the kingdom of heaven has come near" (4:17). It is a simple message but it has all the depth of God's kingship behind it, for every area of life.

- Disciples need to be clear about the good news: the declaration that Jesus the Messiah is king of heaven and earth and everyone must submit to him.

15.3.3 Messengers

Matthew immediately shows that the message will need messengers to take it out: "Come, follow me," Jesus said, "and I will send you out to fish for people" (4:19).

- Disciples need to know the Messiah, know his message and be prepared to take it to others.

15.3.4 Method

Matthew then tells us: “Jesus went throughout Galilee, teaching in their synagogues, proclaiming the good news of the kingdom, and healing every disease and illness among the people” (4:23). Jesus showed his disciples what it meant for him to be Messiah, but in doing so he also showed them what it means to do his work. Much of what he did was unique: not least his bearing the sins of the world. But all of it has something to say to us as disciples, about how we are to live and serve.

Jesus constantly moves from teaching to practise. He tells us about living by faith and shows his disciples what it means to live by faith. He tells us about prayer, and then, in Gethsemane, for example, he has a practical school of prayer. The commission is not just to be taught but to obey: “teaching them to *obey* everything”. Jesus gives us examples of that in the gospels, but other Christians show us too. They are not perfect, but we are to learn from them as well as discern what is and is not Christ-like about them. Paul was a very good example. He told the church in Corinth “Follow my example, as I follow the example of Christ” (11:1).

- Disciples need to not only know the Messiah and his message, but to live like him.

15.3.5 Manuals

Matthew, more than any other gospel, has lengthy teaching sections within it. So, when we come to the commission at the end and the job of, “teaching them to obey everything I have commanded you” we know where to find that teaching. In fact, there are five teaching sections. The first is Matthew 5-7, which we have already looked at. It has become known as The Sermon on the Mount because of the opening verses. But it is not so much a sermon as we tend to think of a sermon, but a time of training the disciples in the hills. It provides a discipleship manual. Matthew 10, Matthew 13, Matthew 18 and Matthew 24-25 are the other four sections. The Christian believes that the whole Bible is the word of Christ to his people. We can use the Old Testament through the lens of the New Testament to learn about discipleship. And we can use the rest of the New Testament teaching in the light of Jesus’ teaching in the gospels. But these five manuals are particularly important.

- Disciples need to use the manuals Jesus gave them.

15.3.6 Mission

Mission is not an optional extra for disciples. All disciples are told to ‘go’. For some that might just be in the local village, for other it will be further afield. But all disciples must have a sense of being sent.

- Disciples are sent on a mission; God’s church is sent on a mission.

15.4 MAKE DISCIPLES

We can use those six different points about discipleship from Matthew to help guide us in making disciples:

15.4.1 Messiah

Disciples need to learn more and more about Jesus the Messiah. We need to focus on teaching others about Jesus and must make that the centre of our disciple making.

- How will you teach others about Jesus the Messiah?
- What resources do you have?

15.4.2 Message

Disciples need to be clear about the good news: the declaration that Jesus the Messiah is king of heaven and earth and everyone must submit to him. We need to keep reminding others of the gospel and teach it from different scriptures and perspectives.

- How will you plan to teach the gospel to others?
- What resources and methods can you use?

15.4.3 Messengers

Disciples need to know the Messiah, know his message and be prepared to take it to others. Jesus selects messengers for that. He says “follow me”. We need to select individuals, ‘reliable people’ as we saw in 2 Tim 2:2. Remember, they will teach others and multiply the work.

- Who will you select to be disciples?
- How many people is it realistic to influence in depth?
- When will you meet with them and what will you give time to?

15.4.4 Method

Disciples need to not only know the Messiah and his message, but to live like him.

- How can we create situations and communities in which we can help people to not only know about Jesus and his gospel, but to live like him?

15.4.5 Manuals

Disciples need to use the manuals Jesus gave them. We saw the five manuals in Matthew and need to use those. But we also saw that the Bible is our manual, we need to learn to handle the Bible and teach others to handle it.

- How can you use the training manuals in Matthew to train others?

- How might you use the different methods and approaches in BUILD to build others up?

15.4.6 Mission

Disciples are sent on a mission; God's church is sent on a mission.

- How can you demonstrate this yourself and train all disciples to be on Jesus' mission as his agents, in whatever situation God has put them in?

15.5 CONCLUSION: "I AM WITH YOU ALWAYS"

We have been called to a big task, but we need to remember Jesus' authority ("All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me") and Jesus' presence with us ("And surely I am with you always, to the very end of the age").

Commit yourself to being a disciple-making-disciple, and note down three things that this will mean doing in practice. End as a group in prayer, recognising Jesus' authority and presence with you, so that the church can grow in depth as well as size.

Review questions for Module Three

- Look back through the titles of the units in the module. Which units had the greatest impact on you and why is that the case?

- Think back to your time in and use of the module. In what ways has your leadership been challenged and changed as a result of the module?

- In a similar way, reflect on the ways in which your church has been influenced by any teaching from the module, which you have passed on in some way.

Blank worksheets for encountering additional Bible passages

STEP 1: FLESH – study the DETAILS of the text (TEXT:_____)

a) Set the passage in context. How does the passage relate to the book as a whole?

b) See the details of the text. List important words, phrases, and relationships:	**c) Seek the meaning from the details** Explain important words, phrases, and relationships:

d) Summarise the findings. What are the main ideas that come out of this initial study?

STEP 2: SKELETON – outline the STRUCTURE of the text (TEXT:_____)

a) Note all the bones in the structure. What elements highlight the structure?

b) Decide on the 'big bones' and make an outline of the structure. What are the most important parts of the structure? Can you describe the main sections?

STEP 3: HEART – identify the MESSAGE of the text

a) State the theme of the passage. What is the author's main point?

b) Explain the message of the passage. What is the author saying about his theme?

STEP 4: BRAIN – first, understand the PURPOSE of the text...

a) State the purpose of the passage. Why is the author making his point?

b) Make connections for teaching today. What is the relevance of this for us?

Blank worksheet for preaching additional Bible passages

STEP 4: BRAIN – state the PURPOSE of the sermon (TEXT:_____) My sermon's purpose statement:
STEP 5: HEART – form the MESSAGE of the sermon My sermon's theme and its message statement:
STEP 6: SKELETON – create the STRUCTURE of the sermon My sermon's outline (with the main points, introduction and conclusion):
STEP 7: FLESH – develop the DETAILS of the sermon My sermon's details (note here key words, explanations, illustrations and applications that will help you write notes or a full sermon):

Contents of upcoming BUILD modules

Module Four **Nehemiah & the Historical Books:**
Building God's People & Strategic Leadership

Unit 1. Building the Bible's story (Tools)
Unit 2. Encountering Ruth (Tools)
Unit 3. Nehemiah 1 (Encounter)
Unit 4. Intercession (Action)
Unit 5. Nehemiah 2:11-20 (Encounter)
Unit 6. Mobilising God's people (Action)
Unit 7. Nehemiah 4 (Encounter)
Unit 8. Facing opposition (Action)
Unit 9. Nehemiah 5 (Encounter)
Unit 10. Poverty alleviation (Action)
Unit 11. Nehemiah 8:1-12 (Encounter)
Unit 12. Expository preaching (Action)
Unit 13. Leading small groups (Action)
Unit 14. Building God's people (Reflection)
Unit 15. Strategic leadership (Action)

Module Five **Acts & the New Testament Story:**
The Mission of the Church & Missional Leadership

Unit 1. Encountering Acts and the NT Story (Tools)
Unit 2. Encountering Acts 2:1-13 (Encounter)
Unit 3. God's mission and our mission (Reflection)
Unit 4. Encountering Acts 2:42-47 (Encounter)
Unit 5. Mission shaped church (Action)
Unit 6. Encountering Acts 8:9-25 (Encounter)
Unit 7. The Holy Spirit and baptism (Reflection)
Unit 8. Deliverance and healing (Action)
Unit 9. Encountering Acts 15:36-41 (Encounter)
Unit 10. Handling conflict (Action)
Unit 11. Christian mission and local culture (Reflection)
Unit 12. Encountering Acts 17:16-34 (Encounter)
Unit 13. Christ's Lordship and other religions (Reflection)
Unit 14. Evangelistic speaking (Action)
Unit 15. Missional leadership (Action)

Module Six **Psalms & Poetry:**
Worshipping the King & Wholehearted Leadership

Unit 1. Encountering the Psalms and Poetry (Tools)
Unit 2. Psalm 23 (Encounter)
Unit 3. Guidance: How God leads his people (Reflection)
Unit 4. Psalm 51 (Encounter)
Unit 5. Wholehearted leadership (Reflection)
Unit 6. Kingship and Christ in the Psalms (Tools)
Unit 7. Psalm 73 (Encounter)
Unit 8. Reflection & action, learning & teaching (Tools)
Unit 9. Songs of suffering (Reflection)
Unit 10. Dying & death, burial & bereavement (Action)
Unit 11. Psalm 95 (Encounter)
Unit 12. Worshipping the King (Action)
Unit 13. Psalm 127 (Encounter)
Unit 14. The pastor's family and God's family (Action)
Unit 15. Learning from your church's story (Reflection)

Module Seven **Ephesians & the Epistles:**
God's Plan for the Church & Local Church Leadership

Unit 1. Understanding Ephesians and the Epistles (Tools)
Unit 2. Ephesians 1:3-10 (Encounter)
Unit 3. Confidence in Christ (Reflection)
Unit 4. Ephesians 3:7-13 (Encounter)
Unit 5. God's plan for the church (Reflection)
Unit 6. Ephesians 4:11-16 (Encounter)
Unit 7. Transforming church leadership (Action)
Unit 8. Ephesians 4:29-32 (Encounter)
Unit 9. Building a new community (Action)
Unit 10. Ephesians 5:25-33 (Encounter)
Unit 11. Building Bible interpretation skills (Tools)
Unit 12. Gender, marriage and ministry (Reflection)
Unit 13. Understanding the Trinity (Reflection)
Unit 14. Ephesians 6:10-17 (Encounter)
Unit 15. Spiritual warfare (Action)

Module Eight **Proverbs & Wisdom:**
The Fear of the Lord & Practical Leadership

Unit 1. Introducing wisdom (Tools)
Unit 2. Encountering Proverbs (Tools)
Unit 3. Proverbs 3:1-12 (Encounter)
Unit 4. Wisdom for leadership I (Reflection)
Unit 5. Proverbs 5:15-23 (Encounter)
Unit 6. The Song, sex and sexuality (Reflection)
Unit 7. Issues facing the church: HIV and AIDS (Action)
Unit 8. Proverbs 11:23-27 and 13:7-11 (Encounter)
Unit 9. Wisdom with funds (Action)
Unit 10. Proverbs 20:5-12 (Encounter)
Unit 11. Wise counsel (Action)
Unit 12. Proverbs 27:11-22 (Encounter)
Unit 13. Working with children and young people (Action)
Unit 14. Ecclesiastes 3:1-8 (Encounter)
Unit 15. Wisdom for Leadership II (Action)

Module Nine **Isaiah & the Prophets:**
The Sovereign King & Prophetic Leadership

Unit 1. Encountering the Prophets (Tools)
Unit 2. Introducing Isaiah (Tools)
Unit 3. Isaiah 6 (Encounter)
Unit 4. Preaching the Prophets (Action)
Unit 5. Isaiah 12 (Encounter)
Unit 6. Prophecy today (Reflection)
Unit 7. Isaiah 40:1-11 (Encounter)
Unit 8. "Here is your God!" (Reflection)
Unit 9. Isaiah 53:1-6 (Encounter)
Unit 10. Isaiah, Christ and the New Testament (Reflection)
Unit 11. Isaiah 58:6-9 (Encounter)
Unit 12. Advocacy and the local church (Action)
Unit 13. Isaiah 61:1-4 (Encounter)
Unit 14. A great commission (Reflection)
Unit 15. Prophetic leadership (Action)

Module Ten **Revelation & Apocalyptic:**
The Victorious Christ & Leaders that Endure

Unit 1. Introducing Revelation (Tools)
Unit 2. Exploring Revelation and Apocalyptic (Tools)
Unit 3. Revelation 1:12-18 (Encounter)
Unit 4. A leader's vision of Christ (Reflection)
Unit 5. Revelation 2:1-7 (Encounter)
Unit 6. A leader's vision of the church (Reflection)
Unit 7. Revelation 5:1-10 (Encounter)
Unit 8. Revelation 6:1-8 (Encounter)
Unit 9. A leader's vision of history (Reflection)
Unit 10. Persecution and martyrdom (Action)
Unit 11. Revelation 19:11-21 (Encounter)
Unit 12. A leader's vision of judgment (Reflection)
Unit 13. Revelation 21:1-8 (Encounter)
Unit 14. A leader's vision of heaven (Reflection)
Unit 15. Leaders that endure (Action)